不老春
Spring Unending

目录 / Contents

谶 / Prophecy . . . 2
风中芦苇 / A Windblown Reed . . . 7
“长生之门” / "The Gate to Longevity" . . . 10
一叶知秋 / Summer's Lease . . . 17
获释 / Free at Last . . . 21
忧患实多 / Deadly Cure . . . 28
各西东 / Separate Ways . . . 32
仙人抚我顶 / The Longevity Ritual . . . 40
故事尽头 / The End ...? . . . 46
乐土 / To "Heaven" . . . 50
境遇 / Dilemma . . . 57
梦中天台 / Castle in the Sky . . . 65
直如弦 / Unbending Will . . . 72
未烧尾 / A Sow's Ear . . . 80
公无渡河 / Into the Fire . . . 86
登天阶 / To Heaven! . . . 91
东方式诺言 / An Eastern Promise . . . 98
有舍有得 / Pain and Gain . . . 105
区区 / Significance of the Insignificant . . . 112
不复还 / No Turning Back . . . 115
致此离离 / Goodbye, Friend . . . 122
别来无恙 / Long Time No See . . . 130

讖

Prophecy SU-01

When black grass creeps, the children cry, a thousand fields where dead ones lie.
孩童们：黑绒出，小儿苦，良田千里遍尸骨。

When thunder roars and dark clouds curl, the earth splits wide, the spirits swirl.
孩童们：冬雷吼，乌云布，地裂千里鬼哀哭。

When the dragon glares, birds take flight. Yin twists with Yang, sun and moon unite.
地牛眨，千鸟临，阴阳颠倒日月停。

UTTU Office
UTTU 编辑部

???: When Huanzhou falls, the immortal descends, granting longevity and the calamity's end.
???：……涣城亡，仙人降，长生不死脱灾殃。

???: Talk about inspiration! I'm using this as the introduction for my feature article. The mysterious vibe's gonna have them totally glued to the pages!
???：这就是我收集到的关键材料——！我准备把它用在报道开头，一定能成为一个夺人眼球的好引子！

???: Got a whole lotta other stuff too. Gonna start as soon as I wrap up this fieldwork.
???：当然，我还收集了其他的东西……等我完成实地考察，就立刻着手撰写。

???: Trust me, Ms. Verity. This article's gonna be the star of UTTU's special issue on the East. I guarantee it!
???：请相信我，空心木女士，这一定会成为《UTTU》东方特刊的一篇精华报道——

As Reed provides her update, her voice shakes a delicate strand of spider silk before being carried off in the wind.
汇报人的声音沿着蛛丝自远处的风中传来，如实收录了她所有的兴奋和期许。

The two editors nod. One reaches out and gingerly touches the silk before them.
两位编辑点了点头，其中一人率先伸出手，触碰眼前纤细的蛛丝。

Verity: I think you really have something, Ms. Reed.
空心木：我了解了，芦草结编辑。

Verity: An elliptical rhyme concerning disasters and the secrets of longevity. It's no surprise that adventurers find it so intriguing.
空心木：一首关于灾难与“长生”的童谣，凭借着其晦涩难懂的字眼，吸引了众多探险爱好者为之着迷。

Verity: But stories like this are not all that uncommon. I worry it won't have enough substance to carry our special issue.
空心木：但类似的记载并不少见。光凭这些，我看不出它有撑起一期特刊的潜力。

Verity: What makes you so sure it's worth a field trip?
空心木：是什么让你认为这条线索有继续实地调查的价值?

Reed: Ah, great question, ma'am. Well, I did some homework. It's not that much to go on, but if you'd just hear me out ...
芦草结：噢，您的问题很精准——我做过一些准备了，虽然还不是很详细，但勉强够用……

The wind carries the sounds from the other side faithfully, even the soft noise of her turning pages.
风忠实地传递着所有信息，包括她努力翻动纸张的声音。

Reed: There's been all kinds of mantic rhymes in China since, like, the dawn of recorded history, a lot of them obscure or ambiguous. Like, uh, here. There's this one about the Zhou dynasty: "He who sells bows and quivers shall bring the collapse of Zhou ..."
芦草结：自古以来，中国就有相当多类似的谶纬童谣，比如著名的“燕飞来，啄皇孙。皇孙死，燕啄矢”，还有“豆入牛口，势不得久”……

Reed: But really, it was the man's adopted daughter who married Emperor Yōu of Zhou and led to the empire's downfall, and she wasn't even the main cause! What I'm saying is, most of these mantic rhymes are laced with veiled analogies. Who knows what they could mean?
芦草结：它们往往用隐晦的象征来暗指事情的变化、发展，其中部分是事后编造出来的，也有部分内容模糊，仔细一想，会发现有许多种解读。

Reed: But this one's different—an exact event at an exact location. It's gonna be a breeze finding more details in the local annals. And my informant promised they'd give me more information when I get there.
芦草结：但这首童谣描绘的画面相对具体，不少内容能和当地的县志记载对应。
而且，把它告诉我的热心人坚持说自己手里有更多信息。

Reed: So, yeah, this trip could be a bust, but I'll regret it for the rest of my life if I don't get to the bottom of it. So, here I am in Zhu County.
芦草结：跑空是常有的事，可万一错过重要线索就亏大啦。所以我买了票，下了车，到了地方——

Reed: And guess what I found?
芦草结：然后，你们猜——

She pauses, savoring the suspense.
她得意地卖了个关子。

Reed: The wind really does slow around here! Only a little, but it for sure does!
芦草结：在这座小城里，风的确有细微的迟滞！

The editors exchange surprised looks and lean in.
编辑们惊讶地对视了一眼，坐直了身子。

Barbara: Will you need any further assistance?
数羊羔：你是否需要协助?

Reed: I'm all good for now. But I'll let you guys know.
芦草结：暂时不用，我还不能完全确定，等有了新发现再告诉大家。

Reed: First, I've gotta contact my informant and set up a meeting. Then, I'll interview some locals on the street.
芦草结：我打算先联系那个人，约好时间和地点见面。然后再向本地居民打听……

Reed: Who knows? We could even find another shelter if things go well.
芦草结：如果顺利，也许我们又能找到一个安全的去处……

She's so eager to share her plans that she fails to notice her colleagues have fallen quiet.
她兴奋地讲述着自己的规划和成果，没有注意到同伴们已经安静了好一会儿。

Verity: She's always been a go-getter in every life.
空心木：行动力强的确是她的优点，也一直被很好地继承了下来。

Barbara: But I worry for her. You know how obsessed she is about longevity. These clues she found are unlikely to be a coincidence.
数羊羔：但你知道，对她来说，“长生”是一个难以抗拒的主题。这些事又太巧合地凑到了一起……

Verity: You needn't worry. Reed grew up there, originally. She won't have any trouble getting accustomed.
空心木：不用太担心，芦草结原本就长在那片土地，对那边的环境和文化不算陌生。

Verity: But let's keep an eye on her, just to be sure.
空心木：我们保持关注就好。

The woolly editor holds her worried expression. Verity returns it with a silent pleading glance, motioning toward the still-open silk.
毛茸茸的编辑仍旧抛来担忧的眼神。空心木没再开口，只示意她触碰眼前的蛛丝。

Street, Zhu County
祝县·街道

Barbara: Reed? Are you still there?
数羊羔：芦草结？你能听见吗？

Barbara: We trust you've made a good decision with this article, but our network isn't stable right now. You'd better ...
数羊羔：这的确是很好的题材，但若是涉及到风网的扰动，你最好——

The noise from the streets drowns out the rest of her words.
街道上的嘈杂声响淹没了她的话语。

Reed: My bad. Didn't mean to block the way!
芦草结：不好意思，我马上让开！

Reed: Cool, cool, gotta go! I'm racing against the clock here! Call you later.
芦草结：抱歉，我得先去忙了，总之时间不等人，晚些再说吧！

Barbara: Watch out ... danger.
数羊羔：万一……危险……

Reed: No worries. I'll be careful. Bye bye!
芦草结：放心，我没这么莽撞——拜拜！

Reed ends the connection, adjusting her spiderweb brooch as she dodges through the crowds of people and passing bikes.
芦草结中断了通讯，将蛛网胸针扶正，侧过身子躲避拥挤的人群与穿行而过的单车。

She looks around and spies her goal not far away.
她左右张望，在不远处找到了自己的目的地。

Reed: Hate to hang up on you, Barbara, but I've got, like, no time to do this. Maybe I'll buy her some local delicacies to say sorry.
芦草结：没办法，还有好多事要忙。回去的时候给小羊带些本地特产，再跟她认真解释一下。

Reed: Place sure is lively, so many stores, oh my God, and the restaurants! Finally, no more driving to Chinatown to get a decent meal.
芦草结：这县城里好热闹啊。人多，店铺也多……吃的也多！终于不用专门跑去唐人街了！

Reed: Alright, first things first. Gotta find an Internet cafe to contact the informant. Oh, better get a couple bottles of water too.
芦草结：先联系那个人，噢，还得赶快买几瓶水……

The grass-headed editor walks toward the sign across the street.
编辑朝着街对面的招牌走去。

An electric fan oscillates back and forth, attempting in vain to blow away the heat rising from the road.
长城牌落地扇缓慢地来回转头，尽力吹开柏油马路上扩散而来的热浪。

Reed rests on a bamboo chair, her hand finding the mouse in a familiar motion.
芦草结在竹椅上坐下，娴熟地握住了鼠标。

Endless Stream BBS
流水无涯论坛

She processes the new information, immediately drawing up a mental map of her impending investigation.
编辑迅速地在脑海里整理好了刚得到的信息。

Reed: Nice and clear. Let's go.
芦草结：清楚详细，没什么问题。

Reed takes a confident step forward.
编辑势在必得地迈出了脚步。

Reed: Excuse me. Do you know the way to Jīn's Well? It's under a tree by the Paifang.
芦草结：您好，请问您知道金家水井头怎么走吗？就在牌坊边大槐树下面。

Middle-Aged Woman: What well? Never heard of it.
中年妇女：哪块儿？没听说过啊？

Middle-Aged Woman: If you're looking for scenic spots, go to the outskirts of town. There's a lot of beautiful sculptures and architecture out there.
中年妇女：小姑娘，你是过来旅游的吧？要看木雕石雕，往远点的郊区走，老房子多，又安静。

Middle-Aged Woman: And the Mei trees in the central park are famous. But I don't know anything about a well.
中年妇女：看梅树的话就往城中公园去。其余的就真不知道喽。

Reed: Oh, thanks. I'll check them out later.
芦草结：谢谢您。忙完了我会去这几个地方逛逛的。

She waves goodbye to the fifteenth kind person she has questioned so far. The information she's been hoping for still fails to arrive.
芦草结向碰上的第十五个好心人挥手道别，预料中的捷报丝毫没有出现。

Standing in the heart of Zhu County, she lets her eyes wander from the new unfinished buildings rising in the east over to the ancient horse-head walls in the west.
她站在祝县正中央，目光从东边还未竣工的崭新高楼转到西边的马头墙。

Reed: Jianshe Road ...
芦草结：建设路……

The street sign's metallic glare blinds her for a moment.
路牌反射的金属光泽让她眼前一片空白。

Reed: That's it. I've asked everyone on the street. No well, no stall, no Grandma Wáng.
芦草结：转了半天，整条街的铺子也都问过了。水井头找不到，王婆婆的铺子也没个影。

Reed: There's no way I got the address wrong. Did my informant lie? Not likely. What good would that do them?
芦草结：我肯定不会记错地方。要是那个人骗我……也不用特地回消息编一串找不到的地名吧……

Reed: The northern custom house, the Great Buddha Temple, Jianshe Road, Renmin Road ...
芦草结：钞关……大佛寺……建设路……人民路……

The locations feel off to the young editor. Each one seems to have no connection to the others.
年轻的编辑苦苦思索着这些风马牛不相及的名词。

Reed: What if these are all old locations? Like, they're names of places from the past?
芦草结：……难道，她告诉我的都是过去的地名？

Elder: Hey, young comrade. What are you doing in the middle of the street?
老人：小同志，怎么站在路中间发愣？

A voice speaks, bringing a tide of relief that washes over her like soft rain.
一个声音恰到好处地响起，向这株垂着头的植物投下了善意的绿荫。

Elder: You've been asking around for directions, haven't you? To the bus stop? Just follow me. I'm heading there right now.
老人：你刚刚找张姨问路，我都听着了。是有什么急事？是不是要搭公交去文化宫？我正好去下棋。

Reed: No, no. I'm meeting someone by Jīn's Well. Do you know where that is?
芦草结：不用不用。我和朋友约好在金家水井头见面，您知不知道怎么过去？

Reed: Could be an old name, like, really, really old. So, if you know of anywhere even kinda similar, that'd be great. Anything will do.
芦草结：这可能是很久之前的叫法。要是您觉得有什么地方像，都可以告诉我，我一个一个找。

Elder: Jīn's Well, Jīn's Well ... I've lived here almost 60 years and never heard of it.
老人：水井头……水井头……我就是这里人，五六十年了，没听过。

Reed: Then, it might be more than 60 years old. Maybe a hundred or so?
芦草结：那时间再久些，也许隔了两代……一百来年呢？

Elder: 100 years old? You've got to be kidding. Things change so fast. The whole county looks completely different every few decades, let alone a century.
老人：一百年前？哎哟，现在的世界天翻地覆，一天一个样，几十年前的事情都难找咯！

Elder: You're not trying to pull a fast one on me, are you? I thought you needed help.
老人：你不要故意和老人家开玩笑，小同志。我是真怕你误了事，才停下喊你！

Reed: No, sorry.
芦草结：那……

She considers each piece of information, trying to find a path through their mutual confusion.
她努力思索着每条信息，想尽可能从一团乱麻中找出方向。

Reed: Oh, wait, the rhyme! Have you ever heard of this rhyme?
芦草结：对了，童谣！您有没有听过一首童谣？

Reed: It's about black grass, thunder, the earth opening up, and an immortal.
芦草结：有黑绒、惊雷、地裂之类的异象，还提到了仙人，还说和长生有关……

Elder: What? A rhyme?
老人：哈？啥玩意儿？

The scorn in his voice is withering.
老人的语气十分鄙夷，编辑沉在地上的心又往下掉了几分。

For a moment, the approaching deadline and her still blank pages seem like a freight train rushing toward her.
恍惚间，她已经看到了截稿日将近，而稿纸上还一片空白的美妙光景。

Elder: Aren't you a little too old to be searching for things from fairy tales?
老人：小同志，看你也不小了，打听这哄小孩的玩意儿干什么？

Elder: But I have heard it before—an immortal that slept deep beneath Zhu County. In ancient times when the sky shattered and the earth broke apart, they emerged to save the town.
老人：这传说我过去也听过，说是城底下睡着一位仙人，古时候碰上地裂天崩，是祂救了城中百姓。

Elder: But the immortal disappeared right after, taking the Method of Longevity with them, and no one has ever figured out where they went.
老人：仙人原本能长生不死，但法门却与祂一同消失，再不见天日。徒留后世人苦苦追寻长生之法……

Elder: Still, grave robbers turn up around here every year. Those troublemakers just won't give up.
老人：因为这，以前还老有外地人来这里乱挖，说是要找寻仙人留下的长生法宝。

Elder: You seem like a bright young lady. Surely you don't buy into this longevity nonsense, right?
老人：小同志，看你像个文化人，可别掺合这些牛鬼蛇神的事。现在还和你讲什么“长生”的，肯定是骗子。

风中芦苇
A Windblown Reed SU-02

Reed shoots up from her seat. The storekeeper, half-startled, looks over to her.
芦草结猛地站起身，一旁的小卖部老板娘惊了一跳，朝她望过来。

Storekeeper: What's wrong? Is that computer acting up again? Don't you worry. I'll have my daughter fix it.
老板娘：丫头，你怎么了？是这网不好使了？我待会就喊我姑娘来看下，不急，不急！

Storekeeper: You look a little pale. Here, have some water.
老板娘：瞧你脸色这么差，来，先喝口水……

Hot steam rises up from the plastic cup.
冒着热气的塑料杯递到芦草结面前。

Storekeeper: These newfangled computer things are quite complex, you know. It takes time to understand how they work.
老板娘：咱们这也是才用上新鲜东西不久，要时间适应的。水土不服嘛……

Reed: Thank you, ma'am. Can I ask, do you know of any old gates that are still around here?
芦草结：您人真好——您知不知道，这里哪儿还有以前的城门?

Reed: Even if there's just a bit of wall left, or even a single brick! Anything!
芦草结：哪怕只剩半堵墙，一块砖也行！您告诉我就成！

The storekeeper looks puzzled. But eventually she gestures with her chin into the distance.
老板娘疑惑地多打量了她两眼，朝远处扬了扬下巴。

Storekeeper: An old gate? You must've been too busy to notice it before. Over there.
老板娘：你一路急匆匆的，没注意到吧。喏。

Storekeeper: It's just a gate like any other. Why do you ask?
老板娘：大家每天都打下边过，有什么好看的?

Reed: Hmm.
芦草结：唔……

Reed: I'll have another pack of water, ma'am. Can I stay here for a couple more hours?
芦草结：我再买一箱水，姨姨，这把椅子能不能借我多坐几个钟头?

Even against the deep darkness, Reed can still make out the shape of the tall building.
在沉沉的夜色中，芦草结仍能辨认出高大建筑的轮廓。

She rubs her eyes and looks around.
她揉了揉眼睛，环顾四周。

Everything is still. Even the wind has stopped.
一片寂静，连风的声音也止歇了。

Reed: It's late, but this must be the place. The wind's definitely slowing down around here.
芦草结：在附近观察了一下午，这里的确就是风最为迟滞之处。

Reed: *sigh* Barbara's right. There's gotta be a reason for this interference in the network.
芦草结：好吧……小羊的叮嘱是对的。风网恰好在这里出现扰动，也许不是偶然……

Reed sighs and rubs the yellowing grass on her head.
芦草结叹了口气，揉了揉自己头上发黄的草叶。

Reed: I'm totally running out of time. Whoever's behind this, I gotta confront them STAT.
芦草结：但我没有时间了。是牛鬼还是蛇神，都只能拉出来看看了。

Reed: I guess I might miss the article deadline, but I can still solve the interface issue. That counts as a win, right?
芦草结：你说，如果我交不上报道，却解决了编辑部的网络异常……是否也不算是白来一趟?

Her grass blades sway as she watches a spider descending down a strand of web.
她头顶的草叶晃了晃。一只蜘蛛小心地牵着丝线坠下来。

Reed brushes the silk with her finger.
芦草结用指腹抵住那根蛛丝。

Reed: The wind doesn't hover in place for no reason, let alone get tangled up.
芦草结：风从来都是流动的，它不会无缘由地停留在某处。

Reed: So, if it gets tied up in a knot like this, there's gotta be some kind of special power making it stick.
芦草结：如果所谓的系结真的存在，一定有某种力量使那片区域静止……

Reed: That power clings to any wind that passes by. The closer the wind is to the knot, the slower it becomes. So, all I need to do is ...
芦草结：流经它的风会被拖慢脚步，即使只是……那么……

Reed: Find the spot where the wind's moving slowest.
芦草结：一枚小点。

Reed: *gasp* Over there!
芦草结：找到了!

She cries out with joy only to realize her surroundings as she ducks her head in embarrassment.
编辑兴奋地喊出声来，又迅速回过神，心虚地低了低头。

Reed: Oops, sorry. I'll try to keep it down.
芦草结：哎呀，不好意思不好意思。我不是故意吵闹的。

Luckily, at night here in this quiet neighborhood, Reed seems to be the only one awake.
好在周围仍然空无一人。小城的夜里，似乎只有她醒着。

She grabs her flashlight and walks out toward the gate.
她拿起手电，走向城门。

Reed: It's close. Lemme feel for the wind again.
芦草结：就在附近。具体位置还得再确认……

She reaches out her hand, but this time no silk appears.
她伸出手，但这次并没有蛛丝及时垂落。

Reed: Hmm?
芦草结：嗯?

A breeze stirs the grass on her head.
一阵风拂动了她头顶的草叶。

It carries broken sobs, then the bell of an approaching bike.
风中夹杂着细碎的哭声，再仔细听，多了一道由远及近的车铃。

Reed: I knew you'd come! C'mon! Show yourself!
芦草结：早知道你会来！出来！

Her flashlight beam sweeps the area, but it doesn't find her expected foe.
手电亮光扫过，芦草结预想中的敌人并未出现。

Reed: You're OneWithFlow, right?
芦草结：不是论坛里那个人？

Reed: Wait. What if they aren't even human?
芦草结：等等，如果对方本来就不是“人”，那么……

Her spirits lift a little.
她顿时又打起了几分精神。

Reed: I've gotta dig deeper. This'll totally make the article—
芦草结：这次调查就更有价值了！我的报道将会——

Reed: Ah!
芦草结：哎呀！

Something warm and heavy presses against her leg, letting out a cry like a baby.
某样沉重而温暖的物件紧挨着她的小腿，发出婴孩的哭泣。

She looks down, shocked. A bike bell rings behind her.
她惊讶地低下头，车铃在背后响起。

Reed: Alright, my bad. I shouldn't have broken into your place.
芦草结：好吧，不怪你们，是我没打招呼就闯进了你们家里。

Reed: I'll leave, I promise. Just gimme a sec.
芦草结：我很快就走，再看几眼就走……

Reed angles her flashlight downward, taking notice of a faint mark on the stone wall.
光圈从头顶落回地面，芦草结敏锐地捕捉到了石墙上一闪而过的凹凸痕迹。

Reed: Are those carvings?
芦草结：刻字？

Reed: Let me see. "Step into our gate, and gain eternity. From the hands of the immortal, law descends—no calamity, no end."
芦草结：入我教门，长生有成……仙人授法，无劫无殃。

Reed: Bingo. Finally, something concrete.
芦草结：看来我真的找对地方了。

She takes a few steps forward, her left hand reaching for the spiderweb brooch on her chest.
她向前走了两步，左手伸向胸口，轻轻敲了敲那枚蛛网胸针。

Reed: Hello? I've got some amazing findings to report. There's an old gate in town where the wind's almost totally frozen.
芦草结：我有重要的新发现。祝县古城门底下的刻字前面，风在这里几乎静止……

Reed: Hello? Barbara? Ms. Verity?
芦草结：小羊？空心木女士？

She finds a familiar silence as she nears the wall. The spider lies dormant and still.
她想起刚接近城墙时的寂静，还有一直沉默的蜘蛛。

Reed: Huh, it was pretty windy when those Carbuncles popped out. They must've disturbed the air.
芦草结：那群卡邦克鲁过来的时候还有风。

Reed: Can't get any connection on the spider as is. Guess I've gotta make some wind myself.
芦草结：它们在暗中活动，一定会带动周围的气流。就算没有蜘蛛帮忙，只要能捕捉到一丝微风……

She switches off her light.
她按灭了手电。

Reed: Here goes.
芦草结：一定有办法。

She stomps her foot, and a familiar bike bell sounds nearby.
她用力跺了跺脚，不远处响起熟悉的车铃声。

Reed silently apologizes to the small creatures.
芦草结在心里向那群小生物道了歉。

Reed: Next, guide the wind to untie the knot.
芦草结：接下来，引导这些风散开……

Reed: What?
芦草结：……什么……?

Her body stiffens.
她的身体骤然僵硬了。

Everything vanishes. Sound, light, even smell disappear as the void swallows her whole.
一切都不复存在，不再有声响、光亮、气味。无止尽的黑暗毫不客气地将她吞下。

Until an unfamiliar voice cuts through the darkness.
而后，一道陌生的询问将她打捞而起。

???: Want to try mine?
???：要不要尝尝看?

The wind sweeps her up and pulls her toward the voice, then stops and plummets.
席卷着她的狂风猛然向着声音收缩、凝固，然后猝然下坠。

“长生之门”
"The Gate to Longevity" SU-03

???: Go on, have a taste.
???：来一口嘛!

Reed: Who's there?
芦草结：是谁?

Reclining Lady: I was certain you'd been dying to try the clear soup, Mayfly.
倒卧的女子：你不是一直都想尝尝这家的清白盏吗，惠姑?

Reed: Clear soup?
芦草结：清白盏?!

From the reflection in the bowl, Reed sees a frown on a face that doesn't belong to her. Through that reflection's eyes, she notices a white rim of sugar that rounds the bowl.
碗中倒映出一个皱着眉的少女。芦草结借着她的眼睛，打量着碗沿细白的糖粒。

Mayfly: You just poured a whole potful of sugar in, Paper Heron. You can hardly even call it clear soup anymore. Eugh, what a waste.
惠姑：你倒的糖都够老板再做一大锅了，鹭鸶剪，它早就没有原先的味道啦！好糟蹋东西。

Paper Heron: Aha, really? I think it could use a touch more.
鹭鸶剪： 可我还觉得远远不够呢……

Noise fills her head. Cold seeps through her clothes. Rough cloth rubs against her skin. The air spiced with the comfortable smell of wet dirt.
喧哗声灌入脑海，寒冷从衣物外透进来，粗糙的麻布无时无刻不在摩擦着皮肤，空气里尽是水和尘土的腥味。

Boy I: *whining* Mama, my hands are cold.
男童 I： 啊——娘——我手好冷——

Ancient Woman I: Cold or not, you don't press your hands against someone's neck! It's rude.
古代妇女 I： 那也不能塞衣领子里！叫人看见成什么样子?

Ancient Man I: I'm visiting my cousin. Heard there will be something special at the fair this year.
古代男子 I： 这不是正好来看亲戚嘛！诶，你听说了没有，这次庙会好像不简单啊……

Vendor I: Classic Zhu snacks for only three wen! Only three wen!
小贩 I： 祝县老字号！三文钱一碗暖汤，三文钱一碗！

Reed: Zhu County? But, this looks totally different.
芦草结： 这是……祝县?

City Gate, Ancient Zhu County
古祝县·城门

Mayfly: You want more? Have you ... Have you lost your taste, Heron?
惠姑： 加了这么多糖，你都不嫌甜……你、你舌头坏掉啦……鹭鸶剪。

Paper Heron: Not just my taste, all my senses. That's why I roam the land, see? I'm seeking a cure.
鹭鸶剪： 不止是舌头，别的地方也坏啦！所以我才走南闯北地找法子来治我这个毛病。

Mayfly: Then, you're here to see the immortal too?
惠姑： 那你也是来找仙人的?

Paper Heron: Ah, no, merely seeking a companion of mine. She does have the look of an immortal, though I couldn't say for sure whether she is one.
鹭鸶剪： 唔……我是来访友的。但我那朋友生得仙风道骨……我也不知道她是否能算上……

Paper Heron: But tell me about this immortal you seek.
鹭鸶剪： 你说的那仙人什么样?

Mayfly thinks for a moment, then continues shyly.
惠姑想了想，不好意思地继续解释道。

Mayfly: Honestly, I know very little about them. All I've heard is that an immortal is supposed to come to the fair this year to teach people the Method of Longevity.
惠姑： 其实我也没见过，只是大家都这么传——今年的庙会上会出现一个仙人来传授长生之法……

Mayfly: They say it grants both a long life and lasting health.
惠姑： 他们说，只要学了这种仙法，不仅能使人长生不老，还能强健人的体魄。

Mayfly: Its results are said to be remarkable. An old granny learned it, and now she can swim the Nanfei River back and forth, even during winter.
惠姑： 有个老奶奶学了这个以后，冬天能在南淝河游三个来回呢……

Mayfly: Maybe it's the cure you're looking for too!
惠姑： 你这毛病，兴许长生之法也能治!

Paper Heron: Sounds intriguing. I'll be sure to keep an eye out.
鹭鸶剪： 那好啊，我到时候仔细问问仙人……

Paper Heron: But why the hushed voice?
鹭鸶剪： 可是你说话为什么要这么小声？

Mayfly looks around anxiously.
惠姑有些担忧地看了看周围。

Mayfly: Because the guards might hear me. The magistrate posted a notice saying the rumor's false; anyone who spreads it will be punished.
惠姑： 因为有关“长生之法”的消息传出来之后，祝县县令就颁布了一张告示，让大家不要听信谣言，更不能乱传。

Paper Heron: Hmm, words do carry weight. Rumors can grow out of control if left unchecked.
鹭鸶剪： 嗯，人言可畏，要是传得太过夸张，确实不好。

Mayfly: True.
惠姑： 是吧……

Mayfly: Still, it's drawn all sorts to Zhu County. Just look at the line behind us. Some told me they came all the way from Liaodong, far in the frozen north.
惠姑： 这里排队的人，有好多都是冲着“长生之法”来的，我听讲……好像还有从辽东特意过来的。辽东诶，听讲那是个又冷又远的地方。

Paper Heron: Is that so? Good for them, eh?
鹭鸶剪： 是吗！这么厉害啊！

Mayfly: Shhh! Keep your voice down. Aren't you afraid of the guards?
惠姑： 你、你小声点！不怕被抓起来呀?

Mayfly: You're a Daoist. They'll search you head to toe.
惠姑： 你是道士，一会儿搞不好会细细地查你呢！

Mayfly: I heard all manner of folk are trying to sneak into the town, the kinds that'll do anything for the Method of Longevity.
惠姑： 我听讲，有好多流民啊，方士啊，小精怪啊……为了学“长生之法”，都混进祝县去了。

Mayfly: There've even been deaths. See those guards? They're checking every traveler looking for vagrants, Yao, and criminals. Speak of the Method, and you'll be locked away in an instant.
惠姑： 那些巡捕就在查这个呢。说是因为那些坏人在县内作乱，犯下了好多杀害人命的案件……县内外，只要有人提这个，就会被抓进去盘问一番。

Mayfly: That's why they're so strict. They've even got Reversion Bells to magically identify us Yao.
惠姑： 所以现在城门处的检查都可严格了，还用上了振气铃，就为了把那些坏人隔离在外面。

Mayfly: But I think those things only work on the dull-witted ones. Quite a few have slipped through already.
惠姑： 但这只能防得住那些脑子不太灵光的，别人跟我讲，想到办法混进城去的精怪也不少。

Paper Heron: Reversion Bells only reveal a Yao's true face. They cannot tell virtue from vice.
鹭鸶剪： 振气铃只能让妖现出原形，能分辨出人心好坏的可不是这个。

Paper Heron: Yet there are things that can: truth potions, the Immortal's Brush, even some arcane beasts.
鹭鸶剪： 别苦着脸了，我跟你讲点好玩的，这世上确实有能够分辨人好坏的东西，但却不是振气铃。

Paper Heron: Hmm? You're not listening, Mayfly. Take a breath. All will be well.
鹭鸶剪： 法器呢，谛聆水和仙茅笔都可以分辨人的好坏，灵兽呢……

Mayfly: Eugh, frost take me. I don't need a magic lesson right now.
惠姑： 好啦好啦……我没心情听这个……

Mayfly shakes her head, letting her gaze rest on Paper Heron's mule.
惠姑摇了摇头，瞥见了鹭鸶剪的骡子。

Mayfly: Hey, you've got a lot of stuff packed up on that mule. You selling those things at the fair?
惠姑：你骡子背上挂了这么多各式各样的小玩意儿，是要带去庙会摆摊吗？

Paper Heron: No, I wanted to get a gift for my friend, but I'm not so sure of her taste, so I bought whatever caught my eye. I'll let her choose whatever she likes.
鹭鸶剪：不是，当时我看着觉得好玩，便也给朋友带些，可不知道她究竟喜欢什么，便都买了，总能撞到她心仪的。

Mayfly: Is this a snow lotus carving? Did you find it in the Western Regions?
惠姑：这是玉雕雪莲吗？你在西域买的？

Caught up in the excitement of this new sight, Mayfly can't help but start asking questions, her tone alive with interest.
看到从未见过的东西，惠姑的话匣子便打开了。

Mayfly: What was it like there? Is it as beautiful as they say? Please, tell me all about it.
惠姑：那里景色怎么样？是不是很漂亮？跟我讲讲这个吧！

Paper Heron: Ah, the view was breathtaking. Standing at the cliff's edge, watching the world turn white with the falling snow. I didn't even realize where I was. My mule carried me there, see?
鹭鸶剪：那地方确实好看！悬崖峭壁，万里雪飘，风光无限啊！只是我任骡子带我走遍天涯，不知那里原来是被叫作西域……

Paper Heron: The Western Regions, hmm, to the west, then? Where exactly is that?
鹭鸶剪：西域，在西边吗？西边在哪里？

Paper Heron's eyes dart upward, forward, side-to-side, until they look like a needle on a broken compass.
鹭鸶剪环视着四周，如同一只失了磁的罗盘。

Mayfly: *sigh*
惠姑：……唉。

Mayfly: I almost forgot how hopeless you are with directions. Lucky I found you on your way here, or rather, on your way somewhere else entirely.
惠姑：我都忘记了你是个指着南却要往北走的家伙，不然也不会半路上被我捡到。

Mayfly: Never mind. Let's get back in line.
惠姑：算了算了，我们还是继续排队吧。

She doesn't wait for a response. Mayfly looks over the crowd toward the city gate, her fingers rubbing a hidden object in the folds of her clothes.
堵上了鹭鸶剪的嘴，惠姑透过人群的缝隙望着城门，不安地捏着衣角里的什么东西。

There's a low current of unease that runs through the crowd. As if they were moving along a treacherous bridge, each shift of their feet cautious as heads bob side-to-side, checking for movement.
烦躁隐隐浮动在人群之中，略高于鞋底被碾的砂石，略低于因无聊而四处晃动的天灵盖。

It doesn't move. For a time, it feels like it has never moved at all. Each person taking their turn to sigh as they look ahead with a worried expression.
这队伍如盘古开天辟地时就排在这里没有动过一般，不论是谁都只能远远地望一眼排头，然后深深地叹一口气。

Mayfly: *sigh* How much longer must we wait? I'll start growing roots if this line doesn't budge.
惠姑：要排到什么时候？我等得快发芽了……

Ancient Man I: Move forward, will you?
古代男子 Ⅰ： 往前走走了！

Constable I: Get moving! Those who passed the cargo check must go to the Reversion Bell! Hurry it up. There's a whole line behind you!
巡捕 Ⅰ： 快快快，通过行李盘查的赶紧走，去振气铃那儿。后头还那么多人呢！

Constable I: Next!
巡捕 Ⅰ： 下一个！

The impatient constable gestures for the static line to advance.
巡捕不耐烦地催促着，朝后面的队列挥了挥手。

Mayfly: I'll be next.
惠姑： ……马上就轮到我了……

Mayfly squeezes the little object tight beneath her robes as she edges forward.
惠姑用手攥着衣角内的物件，磋磨着蹭了过去。

Constable I: What's that you have tucked in your sleeve? It looks solid.
巡捕 Ⅰ： 衣角里缝了什么？这么硬？

Mayfly: N-Nothing, officer.
惠姑： 没、什么都没有，官爷。

Constable I: Hands in the air. Give—
巡捕 Ⅰ： 别抓着衣角，把……

A cry comes from up ahead, causing both of them to turn their heads.
惊呼声从前面的队列传来，惠姑向声音来源望去。

Mayfly: What happened?
惠姑： 怎么了？

A bronze bell rings, its noise emanating from a man at the front of the line, the vibrations pressing him into the ground.
青铜铃音在一名男子的身周凝聚了起来，并将他死死地压在地上。

Civilian I: Aghh.
平民 Ⅰ： 呃啊……

Civilian II: Claws. His hands are turning into claws!
平民 Ⅱ： 爪子……他长出爪子了！

Under the bell's power, the man transforms into a large yellow dog, its features fiendish, its fangs sharp.
在铃音的震慑中，男子缓缓变化，化形成了一只青面獠牙的大黄狗。

Yellow Dog: *roar*
黄狗精： 吼——

Civilian II: Run! It's a Yao! Run!
平民 Ⅱ： 不好啦！精怪跑出来啦！快跑啊——

Constable II: Capture that monster! Don't let it get away!
巡捕 Ⅱ： 拦住他！别让这个黄狗精跑了！

Civilian III: Stop pushing! Someone fell down here!
平民 Ⅲ： 别挤我！有人摔倒了！

Mayfly: Hey. Stop-Stop pushing!
惠姑： 诶……别，别挤了！

Mayfly: Where's the Yao? Where?
惠姑：那精怪呢，那精怪在……

Paper Heron: Eight views merge, the mystery of Qi. Three lights darken, and all lose their way.
鹭鸶剪：八景冥合，炁入玄玄。三光无明，皆失其路。

Mayfly: W-What?
惠姑：咦……?

Mayfly: Heron, wh-what was that spell? I feel woozy.
惠姑：鹭鸶剪……你念了什么呀？我……好晕啊……

Paper Heron: Come on. Hop up.
鹭鸶剪：来，上骡！

Mayfly: What's happening? I ...
惠姑：我、大家……这是……怎么啦……

Paper Heron: We can't let that yellow dog tear through the crowd.
鹭鸶剪：黄狗横冲直撞，城门处人又多，相互踩踏致伤可就不好了。

Paper Heron: I'll subdue it before harm comes to anyone. Easy now, big fellow.
鹭鸶剪：还是都冷静一下，等我制服了这黄狗，大家便能继续进城逛庙会。

Yellow Dog: Roar!!!
黄狗精：吼——嗷——!!!

Paper Heron: Ah, you're tougher than I thought.
鹭鸶剪：哦？你还挺能撑的嘛！

Paper Heron: Show me what you've got.
鹭鸶剪：那我们来比试一下吧！

???: Who is responsible for this mayhem?
???：谁在城门闹事?!

Yellow Dog: *whimper*
黄狗精：呜……呜……

A young man in an officer's uniform knocks the yellow dog out with a single strike. As it crumples to the ground, he turns his blade toward Paper Heron now seated on her mule.
一击将黄狗精击晕后，官吏模样的青年持刀转向骡上的鹭鸶剪。

???: Causing chaos at the city gate, are we? Looking for trouble?
???：你就是作乱城门的罪魁祸首?

Paper Heron: Your most discerning lordship, I swear on all that is good. 'Twas he who started it.
鹭鸶剪：大人明察，非我也，狗也！

???: Hmph. Was there really any need for all this?
???：区区黄狗精，岂须用你这么大阵仗。

The officer's token hangs plainly and openly on his belt, tempting Paper Heron to begin reading its inscription aloud without thinking.
那武官的腰牌就明晃晃地系在腰带之上，鹭鸶剪不免读出声来。

Paper Heron: Patrol Bureau of Zhu County, Chief Constable, Chéng Héguāng.
鹭鸶剪：直隶涣州府祝县太白巡检司，巡检，程和光……

Cheng Heguang: At your service.
程和光：正是在下。

Cheng Heguang: Dù Liù, stay and maintain order. Yáng Wǔ, arrest this Daoist. Ensure she lifts the spell before you put her away. I will question her personally.
程和光：杜六，杨武！你们一人安顿百姓，一人让道人解除咒法，并将其关押，我过会儿来审！

Du Liu & Yang Wu: Understood!
杜六 & 杨武：是！

The spell's force lingers in the air. The others at the gate remain dazed as the world spins.
术法的余韵尚在，城门处其他人的世界仍在一片昏冥中旋转。

Dù Liù and Yáng Wǔ push their way through the confused crowd.
杜六杨武只能从迷乱的人影中缓慢地清出一条路来。

Civilian II: Aah. Where am I? Is this heaven?
平民 II：唉……唉……我这是到哪儿啦？天庭还是龙宫？

Civilian III: Wait. What happened to the money in my purse? Did that dog curse my sight?
平民 III：不对啊……怎么打开钱袋也看不见钱……我的眼睛瞎了？

Mayfly: Ah, don't look at me. I didn't do anything.
惠姑：唔……不是我干的……不是我……

Constable II: Damned yellow dog! You won't get away from us!
巡捕 II：黄……狗……精……别想跑……！

A dazed constable holds the Reversion Bell as he stumbles into the crowd.
一名昏了头的巡捕举着振气铃倒向了人群，浑然不觉黄狗精并不在此处。

Mayfly: Eh?
惠姑：——哎？

Under the bell's power, Mayfly's human form disappears.
在铃音的震慑中，惠姑的身影已然不再。

In its place appears a wilting tuft of grass.
眼前只有一株半枯的黄草。

Paper Heron: Oh, no!
鹭鸶剪：不好！

Reed: Wait, she's a ...?
芦草结：——她?！

Acting on pure instinct, Reed calls out, but the scene before her dissolves away like mist.
情急之下，芦草结喊出了声音。眼前的景象顿时雾气般散去。

A light wind rustles her hair. Zhu County feels the first chill winds of autumn.
微风拂过发梢，祝县也已稍有秋日的凉意。

Without realizing it, she has left the gate tower and found herself walking alone through the dark streets.
不知不觉间，她已走出了城门楼，回到了夜间的街道上。

Reed: The wind can hold on to information for a long time, so I'm guessing that knot must've been here for ages. Then, that must have been Mayfly's memory?
芦草结：风能长久地保留信息，这系结应该有不少年头了……我看到的是……惠姑的经历?

Reed: Her true form was a tuft of reed, just like me.
芦草结：她竟然跟我一样，也是苇草……

Reed: It was already winter, though; she would've been running out of time.
芦草结：从周围的景色看，那时候是冬天……

She thinks of the calendar in her notebook. Over three hundred boxes, two-thirds crossed out.
她想起自己在笔记本上的涂画，三百多个格子已经划去三分之二。

Reed: Then, my informant from the forum ... Could it be her?
芦草结：那个论坛上的人……会是惠姑吗?

一叶知秋
Summer's Lease SU-04

Inn, Zhu County
祝县·旅馆

Reed sits quietly by the bed.
编辑已经在床边默坐了许久。

No sign of her spider friend. No glow from the brooch on her chest.
每个角落都没有熟悉的蜘蛛朋友，她的胸针也始终不曾亮起。

She has walked every street in the city but never found an answer. It was all in vain.
她已经拿着胸针走遍了城内的大街小巷，但留给她的只有死一样的寂静。

Reed: Nope, wind's still giving me nothing.
芦草结：不行，联系不上编辑部……

A few dry leaves break off from her head, drifting toward her pillow.
几片枯黄的叶子自她的头上掉下，落在床褥之间。

Reed: Maybe I should leave so I can contact Ms. Verity and then decide if I want to head back.
芦草结：也许我应该先出县城，坐大巴去市区，询问空心木女士的意见后再折返回来……

Reed: No. It's all too suspicious. She'd tell me to abort, for sure.
芦草结：不……那个人太可疑了，空心木女士绝不会让我再继续调查了。

Reed: *sigh* Basically, I should give up and just go back to headquarters. I could pick another topic to work on if I still have time.
芦草结：所以我应该就此放弃，回到总部。如果我还有时间，就再筹备新的选题。

How much time do you have left?
你还有多少时间?

Reed: Time. Hah. Like I've ever had that.
芦草结：我……还有时间吗?

The budding writer lets out a short laugh at her own expense as she picks up a fallen leaf from the bed and smooths it flat.
编辑自嘲地笑了笑。她捡起掉落在被间的草叶，将它轻轻展平。

Reed: Winter's coming.
芦草结：冬天就要到了。

Reed: I'll have withered by then. Even if another reed'll sprout from my body next year, "I" will be gone for good.
芦草结：到那时，我便该枯萎了。尽管明年又会有一株新的苇草，但那株草并不是我。

Reed: The inevitable end of every ephemeral plant.
芦草结：对于我们这样春生冬死的草本植物而言，这就是我们的命运。

Reed: Mayfly ... She was one of us. I wonder what happened to her. Did she find a way to keep on living?
芦草结：惠姑……她后来怎样了呢？她逃过这样的命运了么?

Reed: Hrmph.
芦草结：……不行。

Reed: I can't. I just can't accept that I'll die without finishing my article, especially when I'm, like, a single step away from finding a way to stay me.
芦草结：我……不甘心。我不甘心就这样结束，这明明是我离答案最近的一次……！

She places the blade of grass between the pages of her notebook.
草叶被认真地夹在了笔记本的纸页之间。

Reed: That's that. I just need to keep going. Besides, these knots are an anomaly that needs to be fixed anyway; why shouldn't I be the one to do it?
芦草结：风的凝滞本就是异常事件。解开它，风就能恢复正常的流动。没有我，它也理应被其他神秘学家解开。

Reed: Alright, forget about whatever this OneWithFlow's trying. I'll just do my thing.
芦草结：不必去理会枯荣自任。我能靠自己的本事解开第一个系结，也能解开剩下的。

Reed: I-I have to finish this article.
芦草结：我……必须完成我的选题。

Reed closes her notebook and steps out the door.
她合上笔记本，踏出了房门。

Once more, the wind seems to pull at her, nearly tearing her mind straight out of her body. The gust leaves behind an uneasy feeling in her stomach.
意识再一次被狂风从躯体中抽出，这依旧让芦草结感到极大的不适。

She bears the feeling and waits for the fall she knows is coming.
强忍住这种感觉，她等待着预料中的下坠。

Reed: Is this another of Mayfly's memories?
芦草结：……还会是惠姑吗?

A brief sadness rises in her, then a faintly familiar voice cuts it off.
物伤其类的悲伤短暂升起，旋即被隐约耳熟的声音打断。

???: Chief?
???：小程巡检?

???: May I enter?
???：我能进来吗?

Cheng Heguang: Please.
程和光：请。

City Defense Office, Ancient Zhu County
古祝县·门军房

After settling the disturbance, Dù Liù makes his way to the town's constabulary office and knocks at the door of his chief.
处理完城门处的骚乱后，杜六叩响了城门门军房的门。

At the desk, Chéng Héguāng bends over a mess of documents.
书案前，程和光正埋头研究着厚厚的案卷。

Du Liu: Sir, the Daoist has lifted the spell. Several people in the crowd were injured by that yellow dog; we've sent them to get treatment.
杜六：小程巡检，那道人已经解除了咒法，百姓中有几名因黄狗精而受了惊吓，磕碰了几处，我已命人送去医治了。

Du Liu: Order has been restored at the gate. Inspections are ongoing.
杜六：城门关卡也已恢复秩序，平民正有序过关。

Du Liu: The Daoist and her mule are locked up. She's ready for interrogation. Yáng Wǔ is watching her.
杜六：杨武将那道人和她的骡子押进了城门班房，等候您查问。

The chief nods, barely looking up from his files.
程和光点点头，将目光从案卷中拔了出来。

Cheng Heguang: Good. Return to your position. I will go to see her immediately.
程和光：好，你回岗吧，我马上就去杨武那边。

Dù Liù looks down over the papers, letting out an unintended grumble as he realizes their meaning.
杜六好奇地上前瞅了瞅程和光的手中之物，冲着密密麻麻的字抱怨。

Du Liu: Ah. Forgive me, Chief, but isn't that someone else's job? I fail to see why we should bother investigating these animal carcasses. I know the Stilted Parade is about to begin, but—
杜六：小程巡检，属下不懂，今年庙会的搜检真要这么严苛吗?

Cheng Heguang: You understand the importance of this for the people, do you not? We must leave no stone unturned.
程和光：“高跷巡神”岂是普通的庙会?

Du Liu: Yes, but even so, it seems a waste of our men's time to look into a few dead animals?
杜六：即使它再重要，为了调查动物遗尸的案件，也有些过为已甚了。

Du Liu: There's no proof that they were killed by Yao. Perhaps it was some beasts in the mountain that chased them here.
杜六：更何况现在并无任何证据表明此事为精怪所为，兴许就是山上饿极的野兽干的呢?

Du Liu: And even if it was a Yao, there's no need to take it so seriously. It's best to leave them to their own affairs.
杜六：而且即使就是“它们”作祟，我们也无需做出如此大的阵仗……毕竟，谁知这其中是否涉及“它们”自己的恩怨情仇。

Cheng Heguang: "Their own affairs"?
程和光：什么叫“它们”?

Cheng Heguang: All residents of the Ming Empire, be they human or Yao, are bound under the same law, and it is our duty to uphold it.
程和光：无论是人是妖，只要有违反大明律令、威胁百姓安全之事，我们就当义不容辞。何必想这么多无关紧要之事?

Cheng Heguang: You know as well as I do that something is afoot here. Those carcasses are involved in all this. I can feel it.
程和光：你也知道，最近县里不太太平。我总觉得，这动物遗尸的案件与其他精怪犯下的案子有千丝万缕的联系。

He points at the file in his hand.
程和光指了指手中的案卷。

Cheng Heguang: This report just reached me. Another carcass was found in Chunhua Alley this morning.
程和光：这是刚送来的案子，今早在城中春花巷内又发现了一具动物遗尸。

Cheng Heguang: Like the others, it was intact, yet pale and dry. There were also sightings of the same mysterious parade near the scene.
程和光：与前几案相同，被发现时尸体面容灰白，肌肉失养，但肢体完整。在案发地的不远处，也再次出现了神秘游行队伍的目击报告。

Cheng Heguang: They were spreading rumors about the Method of Longevity. They have already amassed a small following.
程和光：散播长生流言的正是这支游行队伍，据我所知，已经有县民被他们蛊惑，去修行什么“长生之法”。

Cheng Heguang: And do not forget Commander Lì's orders: we must make sure the fair is without blemish. This risk is too large to ignore.
程和光：正值“高跷巡神”开办期间，厉守备早就嘱咐过我们，在此期间定要护县民周全，我们有什么理由不严查?

Du Liu: But, Chief Chéng, the men have been working for weeks without rest. They're exhausted. If we give them more work—
杜六：可是这几天兄弟们跑前跑后，轮流站岗，早就累得要命——

Dù Liù doesn't have time to finish his complaint before another knock interrupts him.
杜六还未讲完，门军房的门便再度被叩响。

Constable I: Chief, Yáng Wǔ is expecting you.
巡捕 I：程巡检，杨武问您何时过去!

Cheng Heguang: Understood. I'll be there shortly.
程和光：我知道，我马上就去。

His subordinate decides to bite back his words.
抱怨尚未开始就被打断，杜六只得把满腔苦水都咽进肚里。

Du Liu: I must go. Excuse me, Chief.
杜六：那属下就先行……

Cheng Heguang: Hold on! Hmm.
程和光：等一下！咳……

Dù Liù waits, already expecting his next words.
杜六站在原地，等待着程和光发话。

Cheng Heguang: I, hmm, I know that everyone has been working hard of late, and I am sincerely grateful for their efforts.
程和光：我……我知道最近因为城防的事情三班倒，大家都很疲乏。

He stumbles to find the right words.
程和光不熟练地搜肠刮肚着。

Cheng Heguang: So, let them know, once the fair is over, I will take them to the finest restaurant in town.
程和光：此事过后，我定会在县里最好的酒楼中……

Cheng Heguang: My treat.
程和光：宴请各位。

Du Liu: Much appreciated. But I'm certain even a chief's salary couldn't cover such a meal.
杜六：那属下代弟兄们谢过小程巡检了。不过小程巡检自己的俸禄应该就没多少，到时候……

Du Liu: I'll have their bellies filled before we go. We wouldn't want to embarrass you, huh?
杜六：我让弟兄们先喝三大碗井水再去，免得小程巡检难堪。

Cheng Heguang: No need. The chef there is a friend. They won't charge me much if I bring the ingredients myself. Bass is in season.
程和光：不必，此时鲈鱼正肥美，我与那酒楼的后厨相熟，自带食材的话，花销并不会太高。

Du Liu: Oh, you're bringing bass? I'll tell the men to skip lunch then.
杜六：如果是小程巡检自己钓的，那我便通知弟兄们空着肚子等了。

Du Liu: Still the record holder of the Fishing Competition, aren't you? Who else but Chéng could pull up a bass half his size?
杜六：“涣州鲈鱼王”的名号，今年还没易主吗？当年那条 28 斤的鲈鱼可真叫人眼馋。

Cheng Heguang: Please, Dù Liù, it's just a way to make some extra wen. Right, enough talk. Back to work.
程和光：不过是钓着玩玩，顺带补贴家用……好了，执勤期间，不宜聊太多无关话题。

Du Liu: Yes, Chief Chéng! I'll take my leave then.
杜六：得嘞！那属下告退。

He leaves, and the young officer returns to his files.
杜六退了出去，程和光便又将精力投回到了案卷之中。

The mist rises again, covering the scene before her and then dissolving away.
目所能及处，一切景象又烟雾般消散。

The darkness is familiar now. She waits for the inn's open window to return to her sight.
芦草结已经习惯了这片黑暗。她等待着眼前重新亮起旅馆那扇推开的窗户。

Reed: That wasn't Mayfly's memory. How many people are involved in this story? Are they somehow connected to each other?
芦草结：并不是惠姑……这风结里有多少人的往事?
他们都是当年的当事人?

???: Perhaps this will make things clearer.
???：别急，我帮你一把。

Reed: ...!
芦草结：……！

Wind screams past her, pulling her again toward some distant, unknown place.
风从她的身边呼啸而过，被牵引着汇往未知的远处。

Her thoughts sink first, spreading like roots digging into the earth. Then, a nursery rhyme lifts them up.
她的思绪先下沉，蔓延出无数根系，扎根于泥土。随后，又被一首童谣托起。

获释
Free at Last SU-05

Children: When black grass creeps, the children cry, a thousand fields where dead ones lie.
童声：黑绒出，小儿苦，良田千里遍尸骨。

Children: When thunder roars and dark clouds curl, the earth splits wide, the spirits swirl.
童声：冬雷吼，乌云布，地裂千里鬼哀哭。

Jail, Ancient Zhu County
古祝县·班房

Paper Heron: Hmm? A local rhyme from Huanzhou, isn't it?
鹭鸶剪：嗯？这是涣州的地方歌谣吗?

In the cell, Paper Heron listens with interest to the distant children's voices. Her mule chews straw on the floor, unconcerned with their present state of affairs.
班房内，鹭鸶剪竖着耳朵，饶有兴味地听着远处街道上传来的隐约童声，骡子则悠然嚼着铺在班房中的茅草。

Beside her, Mayfly strains on her tiptoes at the small cell window, her face a contortion of overlapping anxieties.
一边的惠姑尽力地踮着脚扒在班房小小的窗口上，显然没有这种好心情。

Mayfly: It's only been a few hours since we came in, and they've already captured another five Yao. We're doomed.
惠姑：他们抓了好多小精怪进来，我一直在数着。就咱们进来这会儿，都有五个了。

She turns dejectedly and leans against the cell's earthen wall.
惠姑垂头丧气地转过身来，靠在班房的土墙上。

After a moment of brooding silence, she yanks the once-cherished object from her pocket and flings it to the ground.
沉默了一会儿后，口袋里一直珍藏着的物件被她狠狠地扔在了地上。

Mayfly: Liar! You wretched, dirty liar!
惠姑：骗子！骗子！

Mayfly: That merchant swore his trinket could fool the Reversion Bell, but it didn't. I spent all I had on it.
惠姑：说什么不会被振气铃影响，一点用都没有！还那么贵！

Mayfly: And that wretched yellow dog. If it hadn't made such a scene, I might have slipped right past. I hate you. I hate you all!
惠姑：害得我被那黄狗精连累……！我踩……我把你踩碎……！骗子！

Mayfly: *sob* I'm such a fool.
惠姑：呜……我真是笨到家了……

Paper Heron: Now, now. They'll release us soon. We only need to wait.
鹭鸶剪：别急别急，也许等会儿就能被放出去了呢。

Paper Heron smiles, looking first at the distraught Mayfly, then toward the trampled amulet on the floor.
鹭鸶剪笑盈盈地看着生气的惠姑，又看了看地上被踩碎的草结护符。

Paper Heron: And, for the record, your amulet is not a fake. Its power is merely too weak to silence the Reversion Bell without a spell. It could be that the merchant forgot to tell you.
鹭鸶剪：嗯……这护符倒是有用，只不过是最初级的隐身护符，不念咒掐诀的话，对付振气铃倒用处不大。

Paper Heron: You're no fool. No one's to blame.
鹭鸶剪：那人也不算真的骗你，兴许只是没说清楚。

Mayfly: A-Are you defending him? D-Don't you see how miserable I am?
惠姑：你，你还替他讲话？我都已经……到这了……

Paper Heron: Now, now, we'll be just fine. They can't keep us locked away forever.
鹭鸶剪：哎呀，早晚会出去的嘛。他们又不可能关我们一辈子。

She picks up the amulet while murmuring a few words, then dusts it off, and hands it back to Mayfly.
鹭鸶剪捡起破碎的草结护符，念念有词了几句，擦了擦灰，递给惠姑。

Paper Heron: Here, take this. Might prove useful.
鹭鸶剪：留着吧，万一以后有用呢。

Mayfly: Get that away from me!
惠姑：我才不要这玩意儿！

Paper Heron: All right, all right, no need to fear. Remember that spell I cast on you? Now they'll see you as just a bundle of hay. I'll pick you up and take you with me when I'm freed.
鹭鸶剪：好吧，那我收着。你别生气啦，他们还不知道我用一捆稻草替了你，等我脱身后，你也就可以进城啦。

Mayfly: *sigh* I never should have come here.
惠姑：唉……早知道……我就不该来……

The offer does little to lift her spirits. The grass ornament in her hair droops over, matching her defeated expression.
这安慰显然于事无补，惠姑头上的草饰都耷拉了下来。

Paper Heron, by contrast, seems completely unbothered by their predicament. Instead, her eyes are fixed on a stone in the corner of her cell.
鹭鸶剪则是专注地看起了班房角落的石头，仿佛世间一切纷扰与她无关。

A moment passes before she lets out a cry of delight.
好一会儿后，她忽地惊呼起来。

Paper Heron: And done!
鹭鸶剪：成了！

Mayfly: W-What?
惠姑：什、什么成了？

Paper Heron moves in a flourish, presenting the stone to her companion.
鹭鸶剪略微移步，露出了班房角落的一块石头。

It now bears a carving that reads, "Mayfly and Paper Heron were here."
上面正刻着“我与惠姑到此一游”。

Paper Heron: Well, there isn't much else to do cooped up in here. How do you like it, eh?
鹭鸶剪：在这里闲着也是闲着，不如留个纪念。你看，我刻得如何？

Mayfly looks at the stone brick still dusted with debris. The grooves of the carving match the width of Paper Heron's finger.
惠姑看向那还留有碎屑的石砖，字迹的凹陷处正贴合鹭鸶剪指尖的宽度。

Mayfly: Did you carve that with your nails?
惠姑：你……用手刻的？

Paper Heron: Haha, no. Just a little trick I picked up on the road—carving with air. Not mastered yet, mind you. Not exactly fit for the emperor, haha. Anything else you'd have me add?
鹭鸶剪：云游时收集到的小法术，隔空刻字。只是力道不好控制，总显得不够美观。你有什么想刻的吗？

Mayfly: That's all? That's what you use your arcane skills for?
惠姑：你的术法……就用来做这些？

Paper Heron: Hm? Of course not. I'm capable of much more than this.
鹭鸶剪：嗯？稍等，是我疏忽了。其实这术法不只能刻字……

Bent over, Paper Heron makes a gesture with her right hand. As she does, a line of sharp white Qi wraps around her finger. As she begins moving her finger through the air, the form of a reed plant etches itself into the stone.
鹭鸶剪保持着俯身的姿势，右手掐诀，指尖缠绕着一股凌冽白气，指尖缓缓在空中滑动，砖石上便一点点勾勒出一株苇草。

Paper Heron: See? It's you! Quite the way to mark the moment, eh?
鹭鸶剪：还能刻图呢！这样后来的人，也知道我们来过。

It doesn't seem to ease her new friend's concerns.
惠姑脸上的神情很难称之为高兴。

Mayfly: Heron, no! You turned me into a bundle of hay, remember? They'll know it was me.
惠姑：鹭鸶剪，你刚刚还讲拿稻草替了我……这下他们看了字和图样，不就全露馅了吗?

Paper Heron: Ah! You're right. I'll undo it at once.
鹭鸶剪：啊——！大意了，我现在就把它擦了——

Paper Heron: For a moment, I thought that our names might be here for all to see for the next ten thousand years, not mere minutes.
鹭鸶剪：本来还想着，这至少能留个一万年呢！——不好，这下可露了大馅了……

Mayfly: Wait.
惠姑：等一下……

She stops Paper Heron's hand with a firm shake of her head.
惠姑轻轻地摇了摇头，制止了鹭鸶剪的动作。

Mayfly: Leave it.
惠姑：……留着吧。

Paper Heron: Hmm?
鹭鸶剪：嗯?

Mayfly: It'll be a keepsake, like you said. If someone a thousand years from now see it and know I was here ...
惠姑：就像你讲的，留个纪念吧。如果一万年后还有一个人，知道我曾来过……

Mayfly: Well, that wouldn't be so bad.
惠姑：那……也不错。

Her voice seems to echo as if coming from some hollow void within her.
她的声音中有一股难以察觉的悲伤。

Paper Heron studies her young friend. Thoughts flutter across her eyes until she nods and smiles.
鹭鸶剪若有所思地看着惠姑，最终还是微笑地点了点头，没有抹去那小小的法术痕迹。

Paper Heron: Very well. Now stop your fretting.
鹭鸶剪：好好……反正你别再着急啦。

A set of hurried footsteps comes from afar.
远处传来一阵急促的脚步。

Paper Heron: They're coming. Hush. I'll slip you into my sleeve.
鹭鸶剪：他们来了！你现在别出声，我把你藏起来——

Paper Heron utters an incantation. In an instant, Mayfly transforms into a paper figure that she slips into her sleeve.
鹭鸶剪催动咒诀，惠姑就变成了一张纸人，柔顺地飞进了她的袖口。

Yang Wu: Chief Chéng, she's in there.
杨武：程巡检，那道人就关在此处。

The two constables open the cell door, barging inside before coming to a stop directly in front of Paper Heron.
程和光与杨武打开了牢门，走到了鹭鸶剪身前。

Yang Wu: You claimed to be a Daoist. Where's your certificate?
杨武：你说你是道士？可有度牒?

Paper Heron: Here.
鹭鸶剪：齐全的。

The chief takes her certificate and furrows his brow as he reads. He looks from the certificate to Paper Heron and then to the mule.
接过了度牒，程和光眉头紧皱，审视的目光在度牒、鹭鸶剪和骡子三者中挪移着。

Yang Wu: Issued in the Hongwu era? That's over 100 years ago!
杨武：签发年月竟在洪武年间？那距今岂不是已有百年?!

Cheng Heguang: Daoists cultivate themselves for longevity. It's only natural she looks younger than she is.
程和光：修道之人，看上去年轻些也不奇怪。

Yáng Wǔ stares at Paper Heron in wide-mouthed disbelief, but the chief has already moved on from those minor details.
杨武难以置信地看着鹭鸶剪，而程和光则更加严谨地比对起度牒的细节。

Cheng Heguang: What is your relationship with the plant spirit that was revealed at the gate?
程和光：那在城门处败露真身的草本精怪，与你是什么关系?

Paper Heron: I have no relationship with her at all. We simply happened to be in line at the same time. I didn't even know she was a Yao.
鹭鸶剪：小道与她不熟，只是在城门处碰巧遇到……我都不知道她原来还是精怪呢。

He does not reply but glances up at Paper Heron, then back at the certificate.
程和光没有接话，只是抬眼看了看鹭鸶剪，便又开始审视起度牒。

Paper Heron: Oh! Do I need a certificate for my mule too?
鹭鸶剪：莫不是我这度牒上还需带上那笨骡子的名字?

Cheng Heguang: Is your mule a Daoist?
程和光：你那骡子也入了教门吗?

Paper Heron: No.
鹭鸶剪：没有的。

Cheng Heguang: Then no.
程和光：那就不用写。

Yang Wu: Heh. What kind of interrogation is this?
杨武：……这都什么和什么啊?

Completing his check with a resigned nod, Chéng Héguāng returns the certificate to Paper Heron.
比对许久，程和光终于将度牒交还给了鹭鸶剪。

Cheng Heguang: Certificate's clear. You may go, but don't make any more trouble, or there will be consequences.
程和光：度牒没有问题，可以走了，但你下次若再惹起事端，肯定不会让你走得如此轻易。

Paper Heron: Not to worry, officer. I always keep to the straight and narrow.
鹭鸶剪：小道向来遵纪守法……

He shifts his focus from the woman to the nearby cell.
确认鹭鸶剪没有问题后，程和光的注意力便不再放在她的身上。

Cheng Heguang: Where's the plant spirit?
程和光：那草木精怪呢?

Yang Wu: In the next cell. Hasn't turned back to her human form yet. I think she's playing dead.
杨武：在隔壁，显出原型后，她便一直没有再恢复人形，估计是想以此躲避牢狱之灾……

As the two men walk over to the next cell, Paper Heron leads her mule out from the dark, damp place.
二人便这样走向下一间班房，鹭鸶剪则忙不迭地拽着骡子离开这个幽暗潮湿的地方。

Paper Heron: Here we are, free once more. Feeling alright?
鹭鸶剪：好啦，你活动活动腿脚，看看有什么不舒服的地方没有?

Finding a quiet spot, the paper figure drifts from Paper Heron's sleeve and, in a puff of smoke, returns Mayfly to her familiar form.
寻了个没人的地方，纸人从鹭鸶剪的袖中飘出，落在地上，并在一阵烟雾中变回了惠姑。

Paper Heron: Didn't I say that all would work out just fine?
鹭鸶剪：如何？我就说一定能将你也救出来。

Mayfly: Hmm. Mmm.
惠姑：嗯——嗯——

Mayfly: It's not much fun being a piece of paper. I couldn't see or hear much of anything, and my body was so flat.
惠姑：变成纸人的感觉可真怪……听不真切，看得模糊……还动不得……

Mayfly: I think I heard something about the Hongwu era?
惠姑：但我听到什么……洪武年间……?

Paper Heron: Haha, my Daoist certificate, long expired. Fortunate for us, the constable was too dull to notice.
鹭鸶剪：嘿嘿，我那度牒，算是个古董……万幸，那巡检比看起来好糊弄……

Paper Heron: Tell me, what do you plan to do in town? I hope our delay has not brought you trouble.
鹭鸶剪：对了，你之前说要进城做什么来着？可还来得及?

Mayfly: Well, ah, oh right, are you hungry, Heron?
惠姑：这个啊……嗯……啊，你肚子饿吗，鹭鸶剪?

She points to a nearby stall. The street has swelled with people, and as the crowd grows, the stall owners call out all the louder for attention.
惠姑指了指不远处的摊位。街上人群已多了起来，摊主的招揽之声也更加卖力了。

A line has formed around a set of steaming bamboo baskets. Mayfly slips into the crowd of eager customers.
热气蒸腾的笼屉旁，已有不少人翘首以盼，惠姑也自然地加入了队列。

Mayfly: *sigh* I haven't eaten since this morning. I should've had that clear soup.
惠姑：唉，一天都没吃东西了，早知道就吃一口你的清白盏了……

Stall Owner I: Here's your sweet olive cake, fresh from the steamer.
摊主 I：你们要的桂花糯米糕蒸好了喂，热烘烘，甜滋滋——

Mayfly: Thank you. *sniff* Smells divine.
惠姑：好，谢谢——诶，好香的桂花啊。

She cannot wait and takes a bite. A soft, sweet scent fills the air, and a sigh of pure contentment follows.
惠姑迫不及待地咬下去，一股清甜软熟的香气四溢开来，她忍不住发出一句幸福的叹气。

Mayfly: Mm, mm. It's ... It's so good.
惠姑：呼——真是，真是太好吃了……呜呜……

Paper Heron: Really? It's only cake.
鹭鸶剪：真有这么好吃?

Mayfly: I can't help it. It's sweet, tender, chewy. You must try it.
惠姑：很甜、很糯，很……总，总之，鹭鸶剪你也试试吧！

She smiles and hands Paper Heron a sweet olive cake, still hot to the touch. Paper Heron looks it over, then delicately lifts it to her mouth.
惠姑笑着递给鹭鸶剪一块略有些烫手的桂花糯米糕，鹭鸶剪左看右看，最后轻轻放入口中。

Mayfly: So? So? Isn't it wonderful?
惠姑：怎……怎么样？好吃吗？

Paper Heron: Mmm. Hmm. The texture is quite remarkable.
鹭鸶剪：唔，唔……口感很奇妙……

She chews with effort, searching for the vaunted taste within.
鹭鸶剪努力地嚼着桂花糕，似乎正在寻找着那传说中的滋味。

Paper Heron: Mmm. I think ...
鹭鸶剪：好像……

Mayfly: What? What??
惠姑：好像什么？

She watches Mayfly as she chews, each bite meeting waves of rapture, and attempts to mimic her delight. Somehow, the act of imitation seems to conjure the promised flavors.
她看着惠姑那幸福地嚼着桂花糕的模样，不自觉地模仿着对方，那桂花糕似乎也尝出了味道。

Paper Heron: I think it's sweet, and it grows sweeter and sweeter the more I chew.
鹭鸶剪：好像……还挺甜的，嗯，确实越吃越香甜啦！

Mayfly: Right?
惠姑：我就说！

Paper Heron: Mmm. It's good, delicious. I must get some more. Mm. Here, eat up, Mayfly.
鹭鸶剪：好吃，好吃，我得再多吃几口，惠姑你也多吃点……

Stall Owner I: You two must be visitors. Are you here for the fair?
摊主 I：看你们风尘仆仆，应该也是慕名来参加这次庙会的吧。

Paper Heron: *burp* That's right. Heard it would be quite the spectacle.
鹭鸶剪：嗝……是啊，看今年的庙会办得特别大，特别好玩。

Stall Owner I: It certainly will be. And thanks to that rumor, business is going great this year.
摊主 I：也是拜了那个“谣言”的福，今年我们这些做小本生意的也赚了不少钱。

Paper Heron: What makes this year so special, hm?
鹭鸶剪：只有今年？

Stall Owner I: Well, many religious sects have flourished in Zhu County recently, each one claiming to bring longevity to their followers. All just tall tales, of course.
摊主 I：嗯……这几年，这个教那个教的，其实都在附近城里兴盛过，追求的都是长生成仙之类的。

Stall Owner I: Only this time is different. Well, it's hearsay. But many think the reason the fair is so busy this year is that one of the sponsors found a true immortal.
摊主 I：不过，今年可不一般喽……客官，我也是听说的，您就当听个乐子。今年庙会本就办得隆重，大家都传，是因为有富商老爷求到真的仙人了。

Mayfly: I heard that too. My friend said her friend's grandfather, who'd been buried, suddenly came home alive, saying he was enlightened by an immortal in Zhu County.
惠姑：这件事我也听过……我朋友的朋友的朋友的亲戚，早该在几年前就寿终正寝，但他今年却突然回家了，说自己在祝县受了仙人点拨，才活到现在。

Stall Owner I: And they say tonight's opera is in fact an opening ceremony for the immortal's sect. They've even widened the stage.
摊主 I： 据说呐，今晚的戏就是那群富商老爷给仙人办的“入世典仪”呢，那戏台的规模都比往常大个好几倍。

Paper Heron: Ah. Sounds impressive.
鹭鸶剪： 啊……这么厉害啊！

Stall Owner I: And not just that. Have you noticed the constables? I've never seen them so nervous. I'd say ...
摊主 I： 而且，这些捕风捉影暂且不说，你就说那些个官差，往年传啥他们都没什么反应，今年却如临大敌一般，我看啊，这事……

Paper Heron: Hmm. But these are mere fancies. Is there nothing we can see with our own eyes?
鹭鸶剪： 嗯——可是听来听去，全是听说和猜测，到现在都没个实影……眼不见为虚，倒不是很有意思。

Stall Owner I: Certainly, the Stilted Parade.
摊主 I： 想有意思？去看高跷巡神啊。

Mayfly: Oh, the Stilted Parade.
惠姑： 高跷巡神！

Paper Heron: The event you mentioned on the way here, isn't it?
鹭鸶剪： 就是你路上总说的那个？

Mayfly: Yes! I heard it's great fun. Where can we see it?
惠姑： 对！听讲热闹得紧。在哪里能看呢？

Stall Owner I: Right behind you.
摊主 I： 马上就来了。

The stall owner closes the steamer and slips back into the storefront.
店主盖上了蒸笼，闪身走到了店铺之中，于门后消失了踪影。

It's only now that they realize how quiet the street had become. Not a soul in sight, until a strange, dense bank of perfumed air rolls past them.
街上不知何时失去了热闹的氛围，路人倏地都不见了，一股诡异的氛围如沉雾般从街头蔓延了过来。

Mayfly: Hmm?
惠姑： 嗯？

忧患实多
Deadly Cure SU-06

The sky grows dim above them. A low, haunting chant drifts up into the air. Curious, Mayfly looks toward the end of the street.
天阴沉了下来，幽幽地有吟诵之声，惠姑好奇地向街道尽头望去。

Mayfly: Oh, right, the parade's coming.
惠姑： 好像……有许多人过来了……

A crowded wave of people surges into view from the distance. Mayfly cranes her neck, straining to see.
浩浩汤汤，人影幢幢，惠姑尽可能地探过身子去。

Chant: Withered grass devours bone. On icy plain the spirits moan.
吟咏之声： 黑绒吞白骨，寒原鬼泣呜。

Chant: When the city falls, the Immortal descends. Longevity granted, no death, no end.
吟咏之声： 城覆仙人现，长生免祸殃。

The unearthly parade advances; a line of towering figures leads its approach in long, otherworldly strides. It takes a moment to spot the stilts as they push against the fabric with each step.
宛如天神出游一般，吟诵之声远远传来，一队巨人踏着方步靠近着，细看才发现他们脚下踩着细长的高跷。

Mayfly: What are they singing?
惠姑： 他们在唱什么？

Woman I: Withered grass devours bone. On icy plain the spirits moan.
女子 I： 黑绒吞白骨，寒原鬼泣呜。

Mayfly: What is ...
惠姑： 怎么……

The parade is near. Their chanting pours over Mayfly like a flood of divine music.
游行的队伍已至眼前，吟唱之声如天音般从惠姑的头顶灌了下去。

"Immortal" I: When the city falls, the Immortal descends. Longevity granted, no death, no end.
扮神的演员 I： 城覆仙人现，长生免祸殃。

All: When the city falls, the Immortal descends. Longevity granted, no death, no end.
众路人： 城覆仙人现，长生免祸殃。

A fox and a woman have appeared over Mayfly's shoulder. Their hushed voices brushing against her ear.
不知何时，一只狐妖和一名女子已来到了惠姑的身边，趴在她耳边厮磨着。

Woman I: We sit at the bottom of society, but still, we deserve dignity. One Yao's voice may not be heard, but what of a hundred or even a thousand more?
女子 I： 我们虽弱小，却也不能总叫人踩在头上。我们一只妖力量小，合起来难道还会小吗！

Mayfly: W-Who are you? What do you want?
惠姑： 你、你们是谁？想干什么？

Fox: Same as you, we are Yao.
狐妖： 我们都是妖，你也是。

Fox: You've seen them bat us off, even kill us, haven't you? Will you continue to suffer in silence? Will you live on in fear?
狐妖： 你难道不曾看见他们是如何驱赶、杀戮我们？这样的日子，你要忍到何时？

Woman I: We need to fight. Fight for our lives! Save our people and claim the Method of Longevity for our own! Overthrow humans and rule the world!
女子 I： 杀出去，我们一起杀出去，把同族救出来，去求那长生之法，再凌驾于人类之上！

Fox: Come, join us! If we are doomed, then we will doom them with us!
狐妖： 走啊，走吧！横竖都是死！拖他们一起死！

Mayfly: No. I-I ...
惠姑： 不、我、我……

She looks around, hoping to find help, only to realize she is surrounded by thick billows of scented fog.
惠姑本能地想向旁人寻求帮助，才发觉自己竟身处一片迷雾中。

Woman I: Those that are not with us are the enemy.
女子 I： 非我族类，其心必异。

Woman I: Did they ever show you mercy? Then, why hesitate?
女子 I： 他们可有怜惜你的命？你为何怜惜他们的?

White fur sprouts from her nose, revealing the Yao to be a hare.
白色的绒毛从她的鼻尖冒了出来，她看起来是只兔妖。

Her feet begin to stamp like war drums. The other Yao watch, then look at one another. All of them feeling the pull to join in.
她的脚跺得如战鼓一般，其余精怪见了她的模样，面面相觑一阵后，竟有了加入的趋势。

Hare: The Immortal will grant us longevity!
兔妖： 仙人将授予我长生！

All Yao: The Immortal will grant us longevity!
众精怪： 仙人将授予我长生！

Yao I: Constables! Run!
精怪 I： 不好！巡捕来了！

Mayfly: What?
惠姑： 什么?

As they round the mouth of the alley, the parade vanishes as quickly as it appeared. The chanting music fades like smoke in the air.
游行的队伍突然如烟般消失在巷口，连同那吟唱的乐声一起，仿佛从未来过。

Paper Heron: Mayfly? Can you hear me? You were caught in the parade's illusion. I had to lead you away.
鹭鸶剪： 到这儿应该就没事了，你刚才被游行的队伍施了幻术之法，听不见我的声音。

Mayfly: I-I'm alright now. Those Yao—they're seeking longevity.
惠姑： 我……我没事了。但它们，它们都是追求长生的精怪……

Paper Heron: Yes.
鹭鸶剪： 是啊。

Paper Heron: But what they're doing is a risk to our entire community.
鹭鸶剪： 可它们现在干的可不是追求长生，是在害人。

Mayfly looks down, her face turning red. Finally deciding something, she stamps her foot.
惠姑垂下头去，脸越涨越红。最后，她像是下定什么决心一样跺了跺脚。

Mayfly: Paper Heron, thank you for bringing me here. I owe you much, so I don't want to lie anymore. I ...
惠姑： 鹭鸶剪，谢谢你帮我进城。我这一路上受了你不少照顾，却一直在骗你……我……

Paper Heron tilts her head, looking puzzled but relieved.
鹭鸶剪歪了歪头，真诚而略有些疑惑地看着眼前的女孩。

Paper Heron: Lie about what?
鹭鸶剪： 有这回事吗?

Mayfly: You know my true form is a tuft of reed. I'm a Yao, just like the others in the parade.
惠姑： 你也看到了，我的真身就是一株芣草，和它们一样的精怪。

Mayfly: In truth, the reason I came all this way is to seek the Method of Longevity. I lied because, well, I feared you'd hate me. I'm sorry.
惠姑： 这番想方设法地进城，也是为了那个仙人授长生的传言。我先前不答，是有点羞于提及……希望你理解。

Mayfly: But I don't want to hurt anyone. I just wanna live longer. Even a little would do.
惠姑： 但，但我并不想害人！我只是想自己活下去……活得……久一点……

Paper Heron: Hush. You'll hear no judgment from me. Only, I don't understand.
鹭鸶剪：你别急，我并不介怀这些，倒是你……

Paper Heron: You risked a lifetime of confinement on a rumor. Is longevity really so important to you?
鹭鸶剪：县里查得这么严，你冒着这么大的风险也要来参加这个庙会，追求长生对你来说，这么重要?

Mayfly: ...
惠姑：……

She goes quiet for a moment, then looks down.
惠姑一时间收了声。片刻后，她垂下眼去。

Mayfly: Remember the travelers we met on the way here? Human or Yao, all sought the Method of Longevity.
惠姑：这一路来，我们遇到的人……抑或妖，只要听到长生之法，多少都会提起一些兴趣。

Mayfly: But you're different. You care more for the small joys in life, like that sweet olive cake we shared.
惠姑：你却始终更好奇一些我们司空见惯的东西，不急不躁，好像那法门对你而言，还抵不上路边买的桂花糕。

Mayfly: It's almost as if you don't care about how long you'll live at all.
惠姑：你又为何能不在乎长生呢?

Paper Heron: Ah ...
鹭鸶剪：我……

Paper Heron: I'm not so unlike you. I suppose I'm just curious about everything.
鹭鸶剪：不是的，我只是想多看看，多尝尝。

Paper Heron: We're already here. Why hurry? If we'd missed that cake, we'd have regretted it for the rest of our lives.
鹭鸶剪：都进了城，也不忙这一时半刻的……而且这么纯正的桂花糕，别处还吃不到呢!

Paper Heron scratches her head as she tries to explain; words rest on her tongue, but they feel, like her, suddenly out of place.
鹭鸶剪搔搔头，有些无措地解释着。

Mayfly: ...
惠姑：……

Mayfly: *sigh* You win.
惠姑：唉，你这人。

She brushes her skirt and sighs.
她拍了拍裙面，叹了一口气。

Mayfly: Sorry, I shouldn't have been so suspicious of you.
惠姑：让你见笑了，别放在心上。我不该这样问你的。

Mayfly: Though we study arcanum and can take human shapes, we Yao are still just plants and animals. Even if we look like you, our lives are much shorter.
惠姑：草木有灵，循灵而生。我们能习得术法，化为人形，但终究需得顺应大道，逃不过原定的命数。

Mayfly: Reeds like me sprout in spring and wither in winter. My entire life begins and ends in less than a year.
惠姑：像我这样的苇草，春生冬死，拢共不过活上一年。

Mayfly: I know it's foolish to risk so much on a rumor, but it's all I have.
惠姑：虽然我追寻这长生之法像是病急乱投医，但……只要是医，也算有个念想。

Mayfly: Do you know what I think when the sun sets? Not that the sky is lovely, but that I lost another day. I don't want to live in fear anymore.
惠姑：我也只是想要以后看到日落的时候，能当它是又有一天过去了，而不是……想到我的寿命又少一天了。

Paper Heron: But you spent all you had on that amulet.
鹭鸶剪：可是为了买那号称能骗过振气铃的护符，就几近耗尽了你全部身家吧。

Paper Heron: What if the Method of Longevity proves false? You'll have nothing left.
鹭鸶剪：万一这长生之法是个骗局，你岂不是会一无所有?

Mayfly smiles, but she lets her eyes stay downcast for a moment before they rise to meet her own.
惠姑低着头笑了笑，随后定定地望向鹭鸶剪。

Mayfly: Longevity means much more to me than you, Heron. When the winter ends, you will see the spring, and I won't.
惠姑：长生之法的意义对你我来说是不一样的，对你来说是锦上添花，对我来说却性命攸关。

Mayfly: If the Method is true, it will change everything. I have to take the chance, no matter the cost.
惠姑：这是能“鲤鱼跃龙门”的仙法，当然值得我倾尽所有。

Mayfly: And as you said yourself, I have nothing left to lose.
惠姑：而且，我的“所有”，其实也就是我的一条贱命罢了。

They share a long gaze. Paper Heron reads the dark eyes before her. They seem to burn like unsettled coal.
鹭鸶剪看着惠姑的眼睛，晚霞映进了那双黑漆漆的眸子里，看起来似乎正燃烧着什么。

Paper Heron: Mayfly ...
鹭鸶剪：……你——

The usually free-spirited Daoist is, for a moment, speechless. She intends to speak, but then the unexpected strikes.
潇洒自由惯了的道人一时怔怔无语，正想说些什么，意外却突然袭来。

Serious Male Voice: Commander!
严肃的男声：守备!

The familiar voice comes from around the corner, seizing her train of thought.
男子的声音突然从拐角处传出，打断了鹭鸶剪。

Paper Heron: Hmm?
鹭鸶剪：嗯?

Cheng Heguang: Commander, I come with an urgent report.
程和光：守备，属下有要事禀报。

各西东
Separate Ways SU-07

Paper Heron: Shush! Someone's here. Get in my sleeve.
鹭鸶剪：嘘，有人来啦，你再委屈一会儿!

Paper Heron gives the mule's rump a light slap. It brays as it ambles behind a nearby haystack.
鹭鸶剪拍了拍骡屁股，那骡子哞叫两声，慢悠悠躲在一旁的草垛后面了。

She presses close to the wall and peers out at the two men. One familiar, the other unfamiliar and bearing greater authority.
接着，她贴身靠着墙，望向那两个巡捕模样的人。

Cheng Heguang: Commander Lì.
程和光：厉守备。

Li Huifeng: Such hurried words, Chéng. What's the matter?
厉晦锋：这么急三火四地把我叫过来，什么事?

Cheng Heguang: It's concerning an unusual parade that has been seen moving through the town. The marchers chanted strange words and even tempted townsfolk to join their ranks.
程和光：属下得到线报，这里刚刚出现了一支奇怪的游行队伍，还带领在场的县民齐声吟诵怪异的口号。

Cheng Heguang: But they vanished as soon as our men arrived. This is the fourth such incident in as many weeks.
程和光：但巡捕到场之后，他们就离奇消失了。全县范围内，类似的案件已经发生过三起，这是第四起了。

Li Huifeng: Go on.
厉晦锋：然后?

Cheng Heguang: Sometimes they leave animal carcasses in their wake. I've ordered a search. Our men may discover something soon.
程和光：他们出现时，有时会在附近留下动物遗尸，我已命下属去搜寻了，兴许一会儿便能找到。

Cheng Heguang: These animals are unusual. They bear no marks of either hunting or natural death. It appears to be some sort of ritual slaughter.
程和光：这些动物尸体死相诡异，不像是被捕杀或自然死亡，更像是死于某种宗教仪式。

Cheng Heguang: They're the ones that have been spreading those rumors about the Method of Longevity. Many townsfolk have joined with them. I fear ...
程和光：正巧那游行队伍总在散播“长生之法”的流言，已有不少县民被其蛊惑，属下担心……

Li Huifeng: You would have me redirect men that already stretched thin to chase down a parade.
厉晦锋：也就是说，你想抽调现在最吃紧的城防人力，去盘查一桩民间小教的装神弄鬼之事。

Li Huifeng: Which, so far, has done little more than leave a few dead animals behind. Do I understand you correctly?
厉晦锋：而他们除了遗弃动物尸体外，还未有伤人传言。

Cheng Heguang: ...
程和光：……

Chéng Héguāng's face turns red. He wants to say something, but the words come out in a fluster.
程和光耳尖通红，他似乎想说些什么，但最终只是嗫嚅了两下，什么也没说。

Cheng Heguang: All of these events are linked together with the Stilted Parade, and—
程和光：但属下认为，这桩案子和“高跷巡神”有莫大的——

Li Huifeng: Héguāng, what are the orders I've given you?
厉晦锋：和光，你可还记得你在“高跷巡神”期间领的差事是什么?

Cheng Heguang: To maintain order, keep criminals from the county, and to see our people enjoy the fair in safety.
程和光：维护好县内的治安，严加盘诘，不许奸宄混入，让百姓们过个好节。

Li Huifeng: And how do you judge your performance?
厉晦锋：你觉得你做得如何?

Cheng Heguang: I have done my utmost, Commander.
程和光：守备，属下一刻都未松懈过。

Li Huifeng: Yet there was a disturbance at the gate.
厉晦锋：但我听说，城门那边不太安分啊。

Cheng Heguang: I cannot deny it.
程和光：……属下无可辩驳。

Li Huifeng: The Stilted Parade is the most significant event of the year, an opportunity for people to laugh and be merry after a year of hard work.
厉晦锋：“高跷巡神”是万民同庆的盛会，百姓辛勤整年，就指着这些个节日来寄托来年的盼头。

Li Huifeng: It's our duty to maintain peace so that they may enjoy the festival.
厉晦锋：让他们放心玩乐，本就是我们这些巡捕的职责。

Li Huifeng: But with all the visitors flooding into the county, we are already short on men.
厉晦锋：这段时间，周围的百姓齐齐涌入祝县，巡防弹压的人力已吃紧万分。

Li Huifeng: You know well that they have been working day and night. Many haven't seen their own homes in days.
厉晦锋：县内的捕头们因守夜巡街，已有三天轮班倒，连回家换身衣服的时间都没有。

Cheng Heguang: I know, Commander.
程和光：……我知道，守备。

Li Huifeng: No, you do not. While your men are out dealing with these visitors and all their other duties—
厉晦锋：那你为何不去疏解城门的压力，不去检修那庙会街的古桥——

Li Huifeng: You come to ask that I direct them to another task based on groundless suspicions?
厉晦锋：却想抽出人手去调查那个所谓的谣言，只因为你捕风捉影的怀疑?

Cheng Heguang: My apologies, Commander.
程和光：……属下知错。

Li Huifeng: *sigh* Raise your head. Listen. You are pushing yourself too hard, Héguāng.
厉晦锋：唉，不必如此。和光，你是太心焦了。

Cheng Heguang: ...
程和光：……

Noticing his protégé's dejected silence, the stern commander softens his tone, if only ever-so-slightly.
程和光低头不答，原本严厉的守备见此，口气便放软了一点。

Li Huifeng: I know how eager you are to prove yourself. Any man in your position would be.
厉晦锋：这也不怪你。我知道，你比谁都更想立功。

Li Huifeng: And I know it was I who told you to work ten or a hundred times harder to earn your place, given your father's history.
厉晦锋：我是和你说过，因为你父亲的事，你未来的路不会好走，必须付出比其他人多十倍、百倍的努力。

Li Huifeng: But true diligence must rest in stability. There are no shortcuts.
厉晦锋：但你也不能太操之过急。

Li Huifeng: Many eyes are on you, Héguāng. If you truly wish to wash your family name of its dishonor, let them find no fault in you.
厉晦锋：这一路上，会有很多双眼睛盯着你。要想出人头地，洗刷耻辱，你得做到任何人都挑不出一个错处才行。

Li Huifeng: Do your duty first, then take the next step. That is how things are done.
厉晦锋：既然你领了这差事，就先尽好本分。谁都是这样过来的。

Cheng Heguang: I understand.
程和光：属下明白。

He keeps his face pointed down, averting his commander's stare. Lì Huìfēng thinks for a moment and clears his throat.
程和光仍是低头。厉晦锋想了想，清了清嗓子。

Li Huifeng: Ahem. Your father disgraced himself when he threw his lot in with those bandits, but that does not mean you will follow his path.
厉晦锋：咳，和光啊。由匪入兵，本是一件好事。你父亲会回去与匪类混迹，不代表你也会。

Li Huifeng: You must not let the whispers of others shake your heart.
厉晦锋：有时一些闲话，不必太过在意。

Li Huifeng: Do you remember why I recruited you? Because I saw a young man with the integrity and conviction to truly protect people.
厉晦锋：当初把你招来时，我就看出，以你的脾性，稍加琢磨，便能成为一个还祝县清净的好巡检。

Li Huifeng: I still do.
厉晦锋：现在我仍这么想。

Lì Huìfēng pats the young officer on the shoulder, then returns his hands stiffly behind his back.
厉晦锋拍了拍程和光的肩膀，随即将手背了回去。

Li Huifeng: Héguāng, your future is bright. Work hard, and you will surely rise to the top, and your family name will be cleared.
厉晦锋：只要你不懈努力，有朝一日定能青云直上，洗刷你们程家的污名。

Cheng Heguang: Understood.
程和光：……是。

Li Huifeng: I have other matters to attend to. Think carefully on my words.
厉晦锋：那我便走了，你好好想想吧。

Cheng Heguang: I will, Commander.
程和光：守备慢走。

Watching from the wall, Paper Heron sees the young man standing motionless. For a moment, he seems so stiff that he could be a wood carving.
从墙边望去，只见那年轻的巡检久久的立在墙边，如一尊木雕。

Paper Heron: The other one's left. What's he waiting for, hm?
鹭鸶剪：不是都聊完了吗？他怎么还不走？

Cheng Heguang: ...
程和光：……

Suddenly, Chéng Héguāng lifts his foot and kicks a pebble away.
程和光忽然抬起脚，狠狠地踢开了脚下的石子。

Mule: Whinny?
骡子：咴?!

Cheng Heguang: Who's there?
程和光：谁?

Mule: Whinny?
骡子：咴——?!

Meeting the sound with calm and precise motion, he summons a hundred leaves that circle the mule; in that same instant, they take on a fearsome steel glint.
登时间，百枚树叶化作剑刃飞来，将骡子围了个大概。

Paper Heron: Uh-oh!
鹭鸶剪：啊哦！这可糟了。

Paper Heron: You go ahead, Mayfly. I can't leave that stupid mule behind.
鹭鸶剪：你先走，惠姑，我不能丢下这烦人骡子不管。

She picks up Mayfly's paper form with her left hand. With her right, she makes a gesture to break the incantation, then breathes a soft puff of air that sends her floating away.
鹭鸶剪左手拈起变成纸人的惠姑，右手掐了个解咒的诀。随后，她轻轻吹了一口气，纸人便飘向远方。

Paper Heron watches as her friend drifts out of reach before leaping to the top of a nearby elm and hiding among the leaves.
看着纸人飘出巷外，鹭鸶剪便跳将上旁边的榆树顶，用叶子遮起了自己的身影。

Now only one man and one mule remain.
街道上顿时只剩下了一人一骡。

Mule: Bray—
骡子：咴——

Cheng Heguang: Hmph. That Daoist must be around.
程和光：哼……是那道人的骡子。

Cheng Heguang: But her trail ends here. Where did she go?
程和光：地上只有一串脚印断在了这里，人呢?

Chéng Héguāng looks around. He feigns an attack on the mule but stops mid-gesture as he catches a ripple of air from the elm tree above him.
程和光看了看四周，装作要对那骡子发难，旁边的榆树顶忽然传来一丝波动的气息。

In a flash, Paper Heron stands amidst a newly formed ring of elm-leaf blades.
眨眼间，鹭鸶剪便身处于榆树叶化作的叶刃阵中。

Cheng Heguang: You won't get away!
程和光：哪里跑！

Paper Heron: Oops! Should've been more careful.
鹭鸶剪：哎哟哟！这可失算了！

Paper Heron: Huff, huff. You surely can run, officer.
鹭鸶剪：呼、呼……官……官爷好脚力！

Cheng Heguang: *panting*
程和光：呵、呵……

Cheng Heguang: Why were you eavesdropping, you conniving Daoist?
程和光：你这偷听的邪道……着实难对付。

Paper Heron: You must be mistaken, sir. I merely happened to be there.
鹭鸶剪：官爷定是误会了什么，小道只想寻一个清净处——

Cheng Heguang: You happened to be there, did you? After making a scene at the gate this morning? Do you think me born yesterday?
程和光：上午扰乱城门秩序，下午就做了偷听的贼人，这世间哪有这么多凑巧?

Paper Heron: Ugh, is there any worth in explaining? You're being unreasonable.
鹭鸶剪：哎呀呀，这，现下跟你确实有些说不通……

Cheng Heguang: You can explain in the interrogation room!
程和光：那便跟我的刀说去——！

Paper Heron jumps onto the roof and seizes a straight, even branch, blocking an attack from behind.
跃上屋顶的一瞬之间，鹭鸶剪迅速捡起一根粗细均匀的树枝，以抵挡来自身后的攻击。

Paper Heron: Hey, hey, hey! Your blade's sharp! I might have been hurt!
鹭鸶剪：诶诶诶，刀剑无眼！小心别伤着人了。

Cheng Heguang: Hmph. My blade is no threat to you! If you have nothing to hide, stop this now and follow me to the Yamen!
程和光：少在这里装腔作势，你压根不怕我的刀，问心无愧的话就跟我回衙门！

Paper Heron: Very well, on one condition.
鹭鸶剪：回衙门倒是无妨……但我有个不情之请。

Cheng Heguang: What?
程和光：讲。

At that, Paper Heron's eyes light up as she launches into an eager explanation.
鹭鸶剪一听，眼睛便亮了亮，颇急切地开了口。

Paper Heron: My mule's been limping since it twisted its ankle in the mountain.
鹭鸶剪：我那骡子，自打上次踏过山溪崴了脚，就走不快了。

Paper Heron: Could you teach it how to run? I think with a little training, you could make a champion out of it.
鹭鸶剪：看你轻功好不错，回头我跟你走了，能否教教我的骡子？我总嫌它慢了些。

Cheng Heguang: You ...
程和光：你！

Panicked Voice: Chief! Chief!
惊慌的声音：程巡检！程巡检！

Yang Wu: There's another disturbance at the gate! Come, quickly!
杨武：程巡检！城门那边出乱子了！辛苦您快些过来啊！

Paper Heron: Oh?
鹭鸶剪：哦？

Chéng Héguāng looks over in surprise to find Yáng Wǔ standing in the street, scratching his head, and then back to Paper Heron, who has stopped a short distance away.
程和光惊异望去，杨武正站在街上抓耳挠腮，而再看向鹭鸶剪，她也停了下来，跟自己保持着几丈的距离。

Paper Heron: Told you I'm not the one you should be chasing.
鹭鸶剪：你瞧，不良方士另有其人。

Cheng Heguang: The gate again! Your accomplices, no doubt!
程和光：又是城门，我看定是你的同伙作乱！

He surges forward on a burst of Qi in pursuit of Paper Heron. Yet, with unhurried ease, she drifts back, maintaining her distance precisely.
程和光提气向鹭鸶剪追去，鹭鸶剪施施然地退后相同的距离。

Cheng Heguang: Enough!
程和光：可恨！

Chéng Héguāng spins his blade, and all the leaves on the tree become sharp edges.
只见程和光挽了个刀花，整树树叶便化为利刃。

A humming noise fills the air as the sharp leaves pin Paper Heron against the wall.
嗡鸣声中，鹭鸶剪被这利刃结结实实钉在了墙上。

Paper Heron: Huh?
鹭鸶剪：咦——

Cheng Heguang: I can't let another disturbance reach Commander Lì.
程和光：守备吩咐过，城门处断不能出什么乱子。

Cheng Heguang: You stay here. I will take you and your accomplices to the Yamen on my return.
程和光：我且先把你拘在这里，等我平息骚乱，再将你的同伙与你一齐领回衙门。

Paper Heron: Not to worry, officer. I'll stay right where I am.
鹭鸶剪：官爷放心，小道我说话算话。

Paper Heron: Take my mule if you mistrust me. You know I won't leave it behind.
鹭鸶剪：实在不放心，我那宝贝骡子还在这儿，你尽可以让别人看着，骡在我在。

Paper Heron nods toward the limping mule below. He looks down to it. As if waiting for that cue, the mule brays out a greeting.
鹭鸶剪朝底下那慢悠悠的骡子努了努嘴，程和光看了看，那骡子吭哧地叫了一声。

He looks back to Paper Heron, pinned yet completely serene. He snorts, sheaths his blade, and jumps down from the roof.
他再回头，看鹭鸶剪安静地不再挣扎，便冷哼一声，搁刀跃下了屋顶。

Cheng Heguang: Hmph. There's no time to waste.
程和光：我懒与你作口舌之争！

In a quiet corner of the street, Mayfly stands on her tiptoes, peering around.
街道的冷清一角，惠姑正踮着脚四处张望。

Paper Heron: Hey, Mayfly.
鹭鸶剪：你来啦。

Finding no one, she darts forward still on her tiptoes.
惠姑小心翼翼地看着周围，即使空无一人，她还是踮着脚轻轻地跑了过来。

Mayfly: Are you alright? I played a trick at the gate to distract him.
惠姑：鹭鸶剪，我用了点小戏法把他引走啦。

Paper Heron: Much appreciated.
鹭鸶剪：多谢。

Paper Heron: *blow*
鹭鸶剪：呼——

Mayfly: Wow! You blew those off like dust.
惠姑：你……这就把它们都弄掉啦?

Paper Heron: It's not as hard as you imagine.
鹭鸶剪：这有什么。

Paper Heron stretches while Mayfly watches the leaf blades fall in a clatter. A hint of envy shines in her eyes.
鹭鸶剪松了松筋骨，惠姑看着那些叮当落地的叶刃，眼中生起一丝欣羡。

Mayfly: I knew you'd work things out. Your mastery of arcanum is truly amazing, even if you lose your way sometimes.
惠姑：还好你没事……我就知道虽然你平时分不清东南西北，但关键时候自有神通。

Mayfly: I wish I could be like you.
惠姑：不像我，连应对振气铃都做不到……

Mayfly: Wandering the world, fighting and casting spells, saving my friends from danger ...
惠姑：要是我哪天也能像你一样，能隐身掐诀，应对刀兵，畅快地游走天地就好了……

Paper Heron: Nonsense! You just saved me from the clutches of the constables, didn't you? Our lives shine equally bright.
鹭鸶剪：说的什么话。你看，你解了我的围，我也解了你的围，咱们现在不也很畅快吗?

Paper Heron: Ah, but I know what you mean. You want to learn some of my tricks, eh? I can teach you.
鹭鸶剪：如果你想学这些方术神通，我可以教你，只要你愿意学，可好?

Mayfly: *sigh* No, that's not what I mean. Besides, there isn't time.
惠姑：唉……我不是指这个，就算我想学，时间也……

With a shake of her head, Mayfly swallows the words. They would have been pointless.
惠姑摇了摇头，及时止住了一个无法沟通的话题。

Mayfly: Actually, Heron, I must say farewell.
惠姑：不说这些有的没的了，鹭鸶剪，其实我要走啦。

Paper Heron: Farewell? Why?
鹭鸶剪：走?

Mayfly: Well, I'd planned this even before we entered town. Would've gone sooner if not for being caught.
惠姑：嗯……困在城门的时候，我本想报答一下你路上的照顾就走的。

Paper Heron: But where will you go? I thought you were seeking the Method of Longevity.
鹭鸶剪：你又要去哪里，不是要学“长生之法”吗?

Mayfly: I'm not leaving, just off to find some other herbaceous Yao. You know, plants of a leaf, same belief.
惠姑：呃……我不去哪里，只是去找城里的同族，原本……嗯，我也是这么打算的。毕竟，我们草本精怪待在一起总是自在些。

Paper Heron: I understand.
鹭鸶剪：好，我理解了。

She nods, but there's a strange tug of emotion within it.
鹭鸶剪点了点头。

Mayfly: *sigh* But I worry for you already. For all your wonderful abilities, you're just so careless.
惠姑：唉，虽然你道法高强，但我总觉得你哪里缺根弦。快要分别了，我反倒要担心你。

Paper Heron: Don't you worry about me. I'll be fine. Haven't met any rotten folk in this town thus far.
鹭鸶剪：不必不必，我看这里的人都挺好的，本事也好。

Paper Heron: Let me see. There's you, that gullible constable, the cake seller, and the Yao from the parade. Well, I saw through their tricks. You see, I can take care of myself.
鹭鸶剪：有你，有好糊弄的巡检，还有那卖桂花糕的老板娘……嗯，游行的小妖也不错，只是不抱伤人之心便更好了。

Mayfly: Heh. You make it sound like a tale for the ages.
惠姑：哈哈，这些都是稀松平常的人和事啊……

She wants to say more, but at the sight of Paper Heron's calm composure, she stops herself.
惠姑最后还想说什么，但看鹭鸶剪神色如常，便也不再多言。

Mayfly: Right. This is it then. Farewell.
惠姑：照，那……我们有缘再见吧。

Paper Heron: As it must be, farewell.
鹭鸶剪：好，有缘再见。

Giving a wave goodbye, Paper Heron turns back with a whistle, and her mule trots behind her.
挥别之后，鹭鸶剪转身朝后走，打了个哨，那骡子便屁颠屁颠地朝她跑来。

In the sunset, their shadows stretch long and thin. Paper Heron stops on the road, takes some paper and a brush from her mule's pack. Before long, a slip of paper drifts into the wind behind her.
夕阳下，一人一骡的影子被照得又长又细。鹭鸶剪在路上稍微停了一下，从骡背挂袋里掏出了纸笔，写了什么，随后伸手往天上一抛。

Mayfly: *sigh* I can't tell if she's a fool or a genius.
惠姑：唉，这人啊……

Mayfly: Hmm? What's this in my pocket?
惠姑：等等，口袋里怎么鼓囊囊的，这，这是什么……

She reaches into her pocket to find an object she doesn't remember putting there.
惠姑急匆匆摸向口袋，掏出那不知何时被置入的物件。

It's the same amulet she had trampled, now restored, and beside it, a hastily written note:
原来是此前被她踩碎的草结护符，现在被完整地还原，旁边还附赠了一张写满了歪扭字迹的纸条。

Mayfly: Hold the amulet and chant, "Hide my body behind Zhēnwǔ and my soul in Tongming Palace," then pinch your left thumb and middle finger. That will deceive the Reversion Bell. No cultivation needed.
惠姑：“持护符念‘身藏真武，魂存通明’，后左手拇指掐中指，即可隐真身过振气铃，无需修炼亦可用。”

Mayfly: ...
惠姑：……

Mayfly: W-When did she ...?
惠姑：鹭……鹭鸶剪什么时候?

The warm orange light of sunset bathes Zhu County. Against the busy evening traffic, Paper Heron leads her mule, her back to Mayfly as she waves once again.
橙黄而温暖的夕光洒满了祝县城内，在熙攘的人群中，牵着骡子的鹭鸶剪背对着惠姑，挥了挥手。

仙人抚我顶
The Longevity Ritual SU-08

Stage, Ancient Zhu County
古祝县·戏台

Around the noisy opera stage, bright fish and dragon lanterns surge and dive amidst the crowd, as if breaching out of a living ocean.
在人声鼎沸的戏台周围，火红绯亮的鱼龙彩灯游曳于人群之中，宛若闹海一般。

The festival is reaching its busiest hour.
庙会最热闹的时辰就要到了。

Mayfly: *sigh*
惠姑：……唉。

Mayfly: Where should I go now? I'm all alone.
惠姑：怎么办哇……大家都去哪里了?

Mayfly: So tired, so hungry. Not a wen to my name. Can't even buy myself a bun.
惠姑：脚也走累了，肚子也饿了……到处都是卖东西的小摊，我身上却没一个子儿。

Mayfly: Where are they? Surely I'm not the only herbaceous Yao in town, am I?
惠姑：同族也一个都没碰到，运气真差。

Mayfly leans against a stone pillar at the Paifang and sits down as she looks out at the swirling crowd.
面对着熙攘的人群，惠姑软软地倚到了牌坊的夹杆石上，索性就这么坐了下去。

Mayfly: Well, even if you find no one, you'll manage. You're a reed, after all. You can take root anywhere, and let the earth feed you.
惠姑：找不到同族也没什么……我是一株草，草在哪里都能生根发芽，所以我不管怎么样都能有个落脚的地方……

Mayfly: But I'd prefer food. What time is it now?
惠姑：现在是什么时候了?

Mayfly: If I had known this would be so difficult, I'd have eaten more cakes while Heron was paying.
惠姑：早知道……就应该多吃几口糯米糕……现在也……也……

Mayfly: At least then I wouldn't be here listening to my stomach growl.
惠姑：也不会饿得跟肚子被人窝了一拳一样……

Mayfly: *sigh* If only I were an immortal. I'd never go hungry again. I'll bet their elixirs must taste better than any river water.
惠姑：要是我现在就会仙法就好了……就能像话本里说的那样潇洒快活，还有好喝的甘露……

Mayfly: Hm? Why are people gathering around here?
惠姑：嗯？什么东西这么热闹?

Boy I: Mama! It's the iron flower fireworks! Can I see? Can I see?
男童 I：娘！是打铁花！我不要小金鱼了，我要去看打铁花！

Mayfly: Fireworks, gone in a moment.
惠姑：转瞬即逝……

Mayfly: But so beautiful.
惠姑：可……真好看啊。

Mayfly: If only my life had a moment like that, just one.
惠姑：要是我这辈子，也能……

Du Liu: Yáng Wǔ, what are you smiling about?
杜六：笑得这么灿烂，看什么呢。

Yang Wu: The iron flower fireworks. So beautiful!
杨武：打铁花，好看！

Cheng Heguang: Dù Liù, Yáng Wǔ! Get your men into position! Keep your eyes on the stage!
程和光：杜六！杨武！马上带你们的人去戏台的哨点就位！

Cheng Heguang: This is where the immortal will supposedly arrive to grant longevity. If something happens, I need you all at the ready!
程和光：谣言中提到“仙人授长生”的地点本就是那戏台，你们须得打起十二分精神看好！

Chéng Héguāng stands on an elevated platform, looking down over the happy fairgoers with an unmatching expression, too dark and serious against the joyful night.
人群之外，程和光站在高处，面容凝重地审视着喜气洋洋的百姓们。

Du Liu: But the opera doesn't start for a while yet. What's wrong, Chief? You're looking more serious than ever.
杜六：这才什么时辰啊——小程巡检，你怎么了？怎么感觉今天格外严肃。

Yang Wu: A Daoist gave him the slip this afternoon.
杨武：下午，有个女道士从他手里跑了。

Du Liu: What? Who could escape Chief Chéng's leaf blades?
杜六：唉？倒是还没听说过有谁能在小程巡检的手底下逃脱的。

Yang Wu: It was the lady who cast a spell at the gate, remember? Best keep an eye out for her.
杨武：在城门公然使用妖法的那个嫌犯，也没抓着。

Du Liu: Are these orders from you or Chief Chéng?
杜六：这两件，到底是你负责的，还是小程巡检负责的?

Yang Wu: You asked the question, I answered. No need to be snide.
杨武：你这人，我好心告诉你事情的原委，你怎么还损我呢?

Cheng Heguang: Enough. That Daoist possessed strange arcane skills, the likes of which I have never seen. I take the blame for her escape.
程和光：聊够了吗？那道人使着奇怪的妖法，我从未见过，让她逃脱确实是我的失误。

Cheng Heguang: Her arrival coinciding with this mysterious sect is no coincidence. She's scheming something. Stay sharp!
程和光：在这个节点，县内冒出来这么一个形迹可疑的邪道……此事必然有诈！诸位不可松懈！

Du Liu: You ever wonder why the chief's sword is never blunt? I figure it's because he's always yelling at it.
杜六：你知道吗？小程巡检之前有一张弓，有一天早上断掉了，断之前还喊出一句话来，全府的人都听见了。

Yang Wu: What are you talking about?
杨武：喊的什么?

Du Liu: "Stay sharp! Stay sharp!"
杜六：不可松懈！不可松懈！

Yang Wu: Pfft.
杨武：噗……

Cheng Heguang: Dù Liù!
程和光：杜六！

Du Liu: Yes, Chief!
杜六：是！小程巡检！

Their chief holds a stern face, but his cheeks betray him with a flush of red.
程和光板着脸，耳朵尖却红了。

Cheng Heguang: I wasn't talking to my sword.
程和光：没有发生过这样的事情。

Du Liu: Right, of course, Chief!
杜六：是！小程巡检！

Yang Wu: Tsk tsk, can't believe you're spreading rumors like that.
杨武：杜六在府内传播谣言，属于知法犯法。

Yang Wu: I'd say that warrants a caning. Allow me to carry out the sentence.
杨武：程巡检，你该罚他掌嘴才是。

Their chief grits his teeth, places a hand on his blade, and turns his back.
程和光咬了咬牙，按刀背过身去。

Cheng Heguang: The opera will begin soon. I need everyone in position. No more jokes. If any suspect gets away, you'll face more than a caning.
程和光： 快戌时了，尽快到哨点就位！要是放跑了可疑人员，我再数罪并罚！

Du Liu & Yang Wu: Understood!
杜六 & 杨武： 是！

Cheng Heguang: Follow me, and keep your eyes and ears peeled! We must safeguard the civilians and apprehend any offenders!
程和光： 剩下的人，跟我走，都给我打起精神来！务必要护参加“高跷巡神”的百姓们周全，也不许放跑一个贼人！

Constables: Yes, Chief!
众人： 是！

Night falls. Lanterns dot the river. More black-awning boats appear, each one festooned with candles.
夜幕降临，点点花灯缀于河面之上，秉烛的乌篷船也多了起来。

Boy I: Mama, look! There's a little man dancing on the candle.
男童 Ⅰ： 娘……蜡烛上有小人在跳舞。

Ancient Woman I: Don't be silly. That's just the candlelight flickering.
古代妇女 Ⅰ： 你看错啦，那是烛火在跳动呢。

Vendor II: Come and play pitch-pot! Young lady, dare to try your luck?
小贩 Ⅱ： 投壶！讨个彩头喔！小姑娘，来试试?

Mayfly: I ...
惠姑： 我……

Yang Wu: Make way! Make way!
杨武： 清道了，清道了！

Yang Wu: Make way, please! We need to clear a path for the audience.
杨武： 把这块都让出来，一会儿看戏的时候人都得从这儿走。

Vendor II: Of course, officer.
小贩 Ⅱ： 好嘞，官爷。

Mayfly: Is the opera about to begin?
惠姑： 要开始唱戏了吗?

Yang Wu: Yes, in just a few minutes.
杨武： 是啊，小姑娘，等到戌时戏就开场了。

Laughter and chatter close in as a group of men and women pass Yáng Wǔ.
嬉笑之声传来，一伙男男女女相簇拥着路过了杨武。

Mayfly: Those are the Yao I met at the cake stall.
惠姑： 是在茶摊遇到的那些人……

Hare: Come join us!
兔妖： 来呀～

A parade of joyful Yao passes before Mayfly. They spin around until they seem like a carousel with her in the center, a parade with no beginning and no end.
洋溢着欢愉的精怪队伍从惠姑面前走过，如走马灯般似乎没有尽头。

Mayfly: I ...
惠姑：我……

Entranced by the sight, the procession sweeps Mayfly off her feet, carrying her away as if caught in the current of a flooding river.
在惠姑愣神之际，人群突然拥挤了起来，惠姑只觉自己如同被山洪席卷而去。

Mayfly: Ugh!
惠姑：呃唔——

Yang Wu: Hey! No pushing! Over there! Keep the peace, or we'll keep it for you!
杨武：干什么！不要拥挤！喂！那边的！维持秩序！

Mayfly: Ugh! Eh ...
惠姑：呵……呵……

Mayfly looks back. She's been carried far only to be left in a strange place, sticking out like driftwood after a receding tide.
惠姑回头望去，骚乱已平息，她自己却如浮木般被冲到了万里之外。

Mayfly: The-The stage? How did I—?
惠姑：嗯？我……怎么被挤到戏台这里了？

The music rises fast and loud. An opera singer steps onto the stage with quick steps.
乐曲紧锣密鼓地奏着，戏曲演员踩着碎步上场亮相了。

The singer's melodious voice captures the crowd in a sudden rapture.
台上之人一开口，戏腔绵长悠扬，台下不禁噤声。

Mayfly: This is *Legends of Handan*!
惠姑：是《邯郸记》!

The singing reaches the far end of the stage, where Chéng Héguāng and his men stand eyeing the proceedings suspiciously.
唱腔悠悠然飘到了戏台的另一端，那边正站着程和光和手下一群人，盯梢着这戏台周围的一举一动。

Cheng Heguang: *Legends of Handan*? How could they choose this of all operas with these rumors going around?
程和光：早知道有“仙人授长生”的谣言，竟然还安排唱这出！

Du Liu: What's it about, Chief?
杜六：小程巡检知道这戏的内容?

Chéng's hard stare conveys his disdain even before his words confirm it.
程和光盯着那戏台，眼中全是不加掩饰的不满。

Cheng Heguang: It tells the story of a scholar who was guided into a dream by the immortal Lǚ Dòngbīn. There, he experienced life as an official in the imperial system; he found enlightenment once he awoke and became Lǚ's apprentice to pursue longevity.
程和光：……这戏名叫《邯郸记》，是讲吕洞宾引导一个书生入梦，那书生梦中经历官场沉浮后顿悟，梦醒后便随吕洞宾修道去了。

Du Liu: Hah. No wonder you're so shook up over it.
杜六：难怪这八仙都来劝人学仙，原来是这个意思。

Mayfly: I, eugh, I can't see.
惠姑：看……看不到……

Mayfly stands on her tiptoes, unable to see the stage over the crowd. But though she can't make out the scene, the song, at least, breaks through.
惠姑极力在人群中踮脚，想望到台上的光景。好在声音不会被眼前的人群阻碍。

Mayfly: I must've watched this opera a hundred times.
惠姑： 我可听过千百遍了。

Mayfly: But I've never seen them use candles before. Did they change the story?
惠姑： 只是，戏子们一直拿着那烛台干嘛?

She finds her way to the front of the stage and looks up, captivated at the performance. It pulls the joy and hope of the crowd up like spun silk that gives warmth and color to the night sky.
惠姑痴痴地望着戏台，现在那里是这庙会中最热闹的地方，汇聚着人们的喜悦与向往。

Countless candles ring the stage. Their flickering flames throw dim, dancing shadows on the walls, shadows that seem to sway and bob like a procession of monks in prayer.
戏台周围，无数蜡烛被点燃。跳跃的烛光明灭摇晃着，将人们微暗模糊的身影打在墙上，似求似拜。

Mayfly: It's so warm.
惠姑： 好温暖的烛火……

Fox: Goodness, how beautiful!
狐妖： 哎哟～好美的东西～

Hare: I can't keep myself from staring.
兔妖： 真叫人看得入迷了。

The flames leap out from their wax altars, speaking in a divine and wordless tongue to the people below.
烛火仿佛跳出了蜡做的供台，朝人们开了金口。

Mayfly: Hold on. When did they light these candles?
惠姑： 这是什么时候点起来的？它们一直就在这里吗?

Mayfly: The flames, they're whispering something.
惠姑： 烛火……在说些什么……?

The small lights sway beneath the night sky, alternating between bright and dim. They become a hypnotic flow that those watching cannot turn away from.
点点烛火在夜幕下摇曳，忽亮忽暗，引得人挪不开眼。

The flickering lights seem to laugh, to scold, and then to chant unclear words, venting the pain of their brief lives through the ages.
烛火们嬉笑怒骂，念着不甚清楚的口号，宣泄着千百年来朝生暮死的苦楚。

Mayfly: Yes, I can hear them. They're saying ...
惠姑： 啊，我听清了！它们在说……

Fox: Grant us longevity.
狐妖： 要我长生，要我成仙……

Hare: Grant us longevity.
兔妖： 要我长生，要我成仙……!

Mayfly: Wait. When did I get this close?
惠姑： 戏台……什么时候如此近了?

A hush falls over the crowd. Mayfly looks up at the figure on the stage.
人群的熙攘之声消散，惠姑抬头望着台上之人。

The warm light shimmers. Hearts beat in time with the swaying shadows. This stage feels as if it were instead a refuge, a bastion of light and song calling out to those who might approach it.
烛火盈盈，心随影动，这戏台仿佛是专门为诚心者而设。

Under the cover of night, under the gaze of many hundreds of eyes, a hundredfold stages rise.
夜幕笼罩下，百人的仰望里树起了百个戏台。

Cheng Heguang: Dù Liù! Yáng Wǔ! Where are you?
程和光：杜六！杨武！你们去哪儿?!

Cheng Heguang: Ah. They're using the candlelight to conjure illusions! Avert your eyes!
程和光：不好！这烛火里有能迷惑人心的妖法！别看！

Mayfly: Only a fool would give up such a chance.
惠姑：世上人不学仙真是蠢。

Paper Heron: Do you wish to become immortal?
鹭鸶剪：你想获得长生吗?

Mayfly: Hmm?
惠姑：嗯?

Mayfly: He-Heron?
惠姑：鹭……鸶剪……?

Paper Heron: Heaven and earth bear the essence which forms all life. I shall live as long as the sun and the moon shine.
鹭鸶剪：天地含精，万物化生，日月并明，与我偕终。

故事尽头
The End ...? SU-09

The candlelight fades and is soon replaced by the steady glow of modern incandescent bulbs.
烛火的光焰逐渐隐没，房间内的电灯映亮了芦草结的眼睛。

Reed touches her head unconsciously, feeling blades of grass brush against her fingertips.
她下意识地摸了摸头顶，只有草叶静静地扫过她的指尖。

Reed: So, Mayfly was given the Method of Longevity. Just like she wanted.
芦草结：……所以，惠姑真的求到了长生。

Reed: And that means that Paper Heron was the legendary immortal.
芦草结：鹭鸶剪就是传说里那位仙人……

As if a reminder, another blade of grass tumbles down at her touch.
或许是因为刚才的触碰，又一片草叶飘落下来。

Reed: Hmm ...
芦草结：我……

Reed: Well, true or not, I better get this down before I forget any details.
芦草结：不管这些是不是真的，我必须抓紧时间留下线索！

She tucks the grass into her pocket and practically leaps toward her paper and pen.
随手将草叶揣进口袋，编辑胡乱地翻出纸笔，快速地写下一行行记录。

Reed: "The distinctive melodies of Eastern opera, combined with the magical glow of candlelight, brought the atmosphere to its peak. When the immortal moved her fingers, the audience, including those who had doubts about longevity ..."
芦草结：“东方戏剧的独特旋律和烛光将现场氛围推向高点，当仙人的手指落下，无论参与者是否对此抱有怀疑——”

Reed: "... naturally came to believe in this miracle, including Mayfly, a herbaceous Yao whose life was about to end only a few months later."
芦草结：“他们都开始倾向于相信世上真的有永生的奇迹，尤其是身为一年生草本植物精怪的当事人惠姑。”

Reed: "Based on accounts from local residents and my own experience, I feel I can make a bold assumption."
芦草结：“根据当地居民的叙述，以及笔者的亲身经历，可以在此做出一个大胆的推测。”

Reed: "After the opera was over, Paper Heron, the legendary immortal, taught the Method of Longevity to Mayfly to extend her life. Then, for some reason, she fell into a deep sleep beneath Zhu County."
芦草结：“仙人鹭鸶剪为惠姑授了长生之法，延续了她的寿命。而后，出于某种缘由，沉睡在祝县地下。”

The passage of time goes unnoticed as her pen glides from page to page. The sound of scribbling accompanied first by the silence of night, then gentle birdsong, and finally the bustle of a waking city.
不知过去多久，窗外已经响起了鸟鸣。街面上也渐渐热闹起来。

Reed: *stretch* Another day.
芦草结：呼，又是新的一天了。

One more square in her calendar is crossed out.
笔记本上的方格又被划去一个。

Usually, she would leave a detailed journal of her day, a record for her next iteration. But today, she lets her pen rest.
往常，编辑会在这些记录旁边补充上详细的备注。
但今天，她犹豫片刻，收起了笔。

Reed: Maybe I won't need to leave a note for the next "me" this time.
芦草结：也许这次，不需要下一个“我”来重新记住这一切……

As the morning progresses, the storekeeper pulls up the shop's rolling shutters.
清早，小店的主人例行拉开白铁皮的卷帘门。

Waiting outside, aside from the morning breeze, is a familiar face.
门外除了晨风和空荡的马路，意外还有一位等待已久的客人。

Storekeeper: You're up early today. Did you get enough sleep?
老板娘：来啦。今天起这么早啊！

Storekeeper: Oh, and I was so busy last night, I forgot to give you your change. Hold on. Let me unlock the door first.
老板娘：对了，昨晚忙忘了，少找你三块六，等等啊，我把门口扫了就……

Before she can even finish her words, Reed has returned to her glowing screen.
话音还没落，编辑已经在屏幕前坐好。

Reed: Sleep, shmeep, my article's almost finished. All I really need is a computer.
芦草结：没关系，我的报道马上就能完成了！我赶时间呢，少睡一会儿不要紧。

Reed: Oh. Sorry, I got a little overexcited. I meant, would it be possible to use one?
芦草结：噢，抱歉，忘记问了——我现在可以用电脑了吗?

Storekeeper: I can see that, haha. Go ahead. You can use that one. You know how to turn it on.
老板娘：你这丫头，性子这么急。行，你自己会鼓捣就好，我忙我的去啦。

Reed takes a deep breath before typing the words she spent the night planning.
芦草结深吸一口气，在键盘上敲下思索了一整夜的词句。

The odd pace of the typing draws the storekeeper's attention.
热心的店主从不同寻常的操作声中觉察出了不对劲。

Storekeeper: Are you trying to put a hole in my mouse, or is the network down?
老板娘：你鼠标怎么按得这么急？是不是网卡了？

Reed: Huh?
芦草结：……什么？

Reed: Oh, no, the network's fine.
芦草结：没有没有……电脑很好。

It's only then that she notices that her whole arm has gone numb from the speed of her typing.
她才意识到自己的整条手臂都因为高频率的点触而阵阵发麻。

Reed: Has anyone else come by recently?
芦草结：对了，姨姨，有没有其他人来你这里上过网？

Storekeeper: No, you're the only one. But I'll keep a spot open for you. Don't you worry.
老板娘：最近只有你，位置我都给你留着的。放心啦。

Reed: Oh, thank you!
芦草结：谢谢您！

The frantic typing resumes as soon as their conversation ends.
键盘声飞快地响起。

Central Park, Zhu County
祝县·中心公园

In the daylight, Reed returns to reassess the leafy central park and the bustling construction site nearby.
芦草结在天光下重新打量着眼前绿意盎然的中心公园和旁边正在火热施工的楼盘。

The words "Immortal Residence" decorating the impressive billboard gleam down at her in the sunlight.
巨幅的广告牌如昨夜般昂然站立在那里，升仙上府的打印字体在日照下反射着微光。

Far beneath it, the half-dead Mei tree that lies in the middle of the park looks dull by comparison.
对比之下，公园中那棵半死不活的梅树显得有些黯然失色。

Property Developer: Another journalist? I already told the other ones we're not open for interviews.
开发商：你是……记者？昨天不是说过了吗，不用来了，过来也是白跑！

It seems she's spent too much time staring as a middle-aged man approaches in a huff.
或许是她在附近张望太久，旁边的中年男子忍不住开口了。

Property Developer: I don't care who you write for. Get out of here, will you?
开发商：不管你们是什么杂志，我们不接受采访！同志，你回去吧。

Reed: Oh! No, no, I'm not here for interviews. I'm just having a look around.
芦草结：噢，不采访！我就——我就在附近看看。

Reed: So, someone came around here then? Someone who looked like me?
芦草结：昨天有人来？是看着和我差不多的人吗？

Property Developer: I'm not answering any questions! My building isn't haunted, and that's that!
开发商：你再问也问不出什么，不是闹鬼！现代社会，不兴这一套，什么影子，都是看错了！

Reed: Not haunted? You mean ...
芦草结：你是说……

Before Reed can ask anything more, a new voice draws away their attention.
没等芦草结接着开口，一个声音就吸引了所有人的注意。

Employee: Sir! We've got a problem!
办事员：经理、经理……真出事了！

A young man, breathless from running, cuts her questioning short.
跑得气喘吁吁的年轻人打断了他们的对话。

Property Developer: What, and you want to hand it over to me?
开发商：你才出事了，会不会说话！

Employee: It-It's Professor Zhāng. He said he—
办事员：经理，那个张教授他讲……

The property developer pulls his arm, gives a polite nod to Reed, and walks aside.
经理猛地拽了一下他的胳膊，客气地同芦草结打了个招呼，走到了旁边。

Half a minute later, Reed hears shouting.
半分钟后，芦草结听到了一句脏话。

Property Developer: Would you listen to yourself? What do you mean they were eaten by monsters?
开发商：我去你的，什么叫那些人是被怪物吃了？

Employee: Professor Zhāng said he found this in an ancient book. Should we just ignore him?
办事员：张教授说他们在古籍上查到的……咱们能不能不管他？

Property Developer: Damn him and his book! I go and call it the "Immortal Residence," and then it turns out people died here? If this gets out, I'll never sell the place!
开发商：狗屁古籍，我神仙府的招牌都打出去了，你现在说他们是被吃了，我房子还卖不卖了?!

The developer's voice rises, and Reed catches pieces of their argument on the wind.
开发商的嗓音随着情绪激动渐趋高亢，随风而来的只言片语引起了芦草结的注意。

Employee: He gave us a copy of the book. Said he'd send one to the press unless he receives 100,000 yuan today. Do you want to look at it?
办事员：他还把那个古籍复印了一份给我……他开口就要十万，不然就寄给报社。经理，你要不要看看？

Property Developer: F**k him!
开发商：我看个屁！

While they argue, Reed slips away toward the entrance of the park.
趁着他们争执的工夫，芦草结悄悄地走向公园入口。

Full of hope, she looks up at the Mei tree. Its dry branches hold many buds.
她满心期待地打量着那棵梅树，它干枯的枝上缀着不少花苞。

Under the tree, a mule chews on fresh green grass.
树下，一头骡子安静地啃着新铺的草皮。

Reed: ...?
芦草结：……？

Reed: OneWithFlow?
芦草结：“枯荣自任”……？

She calls out to the mule, not entirely convinced by her own conclusion.
编辑试探地唤了它一句。

Mule: Whinny.
骡子：咴。

The mule, startled, turns to flee. Reed immediately takes notice of the familiar pack, one she knows she's seen before.
骡子受了惊，转身要逃。
芦草结注意到它身上的披挂。她不久前曾在别处见过。

Reed: You traveled with Paper Heron wherever she went!
芦草结：鹭鸶剪进城时就带着你！

Reed: Wait.
芦草结：等等——

A strong wind blows. The rustling leaves drown out the mule's trotting hooves.
一阵风猛然吹来，树叶的沙沙声甚至盖过了骡子的蹄音。

A pale page falls a half step before her.
灰白的纸页不偏不倚，恰好落在她身前半步。

Reed: At the time, the sun and moon hung together in the sky. The earth split in two at the gate of the School of Mei, opening a rift miles long that swallowed souls.
芦草结：其时日月同天，地裂陷人，自梅花教门，隙长数里……

Reed: When the governor had it investigated, they couldn't find a single human dead or alive, only clothes, dead plants, and animals.
芦草结：令尹使人发之，往往空有衣冠及草木花鸟，鲜见尸首……

Reed: Many believed the phenomenon was caused by the earth dragon?
芦草结：时人多以为……地龙噬人？

Reed: ...!!!
芦草结：……！！！

It's not just the records that surprise her.
令她惊讶的不仅仅是这些记载。

Where the page fell, the wind spins in midair, leading her to a precise spot.
纸页落下的地方，风在半空中打着旋儿。为她指示出一个精确的坐标。

Another Wind Knot.
一个系结。

Reed: Only clothes, dead plants, and animals ... The earth dragon ...
芦草结：空有衣冠……地龙噬人……

Reed: No way. Then the Yao didn't really become immortal?
芦草结：难道那些精怪……没有成仙？

乐土
To "Heaven" SU-10

On stage, footsteps move with a light, quick pace.
烛火盈盈，台上踱步如风。

Do you wish to become immortal?
你想获得长生吗？

Mayfly looks up but sees nothing before her.
惠姑抬头，眼前却是空无一物。

Do you wish to become immortal?
你想获得长生吗？

Mayfly: Only a fool would give up such a chance.
惠姑：世上人不学仙真是蠢。

Mayfly: Hm? Where am I?
惠姑：嗯？这是哪里？

Mayfly sits up from a comfy bed and looks around.
惠姑从床上坐了起来，打量着四周。

Mayfly: Eh!
惠姑：嘿！

Mayfly: This place is so luxurious.
惠姑：这里好生气派……

She jumps to the floor and walks around the room, curious about her new surroundings.
飞身下床，惠姑好奇地在房内四处踱步。

Mayfly: The bed's soft, and this blanket's so light and warm.
惠姑：好柔软的床，被子也很暖和……

Mayfly: What a strange dream I had, but, my, do I feel rested?
惠姑：我做了个好奇怪的梦，但是睡得又特别足！

Mayfly: *deep breath* I'm brimming with energy! I haven't felt this good since autumn. With strength like this flowing through me—
惠姑：吸——呼——神清气爽！入秋以后一直都没什么精神，可今天我却觉得自己可以……

Mayfly: I could till a whole field all on my own!
惠姑：可以插一亩地的秧！

Mayfly: That vase is almost as big as me, but I bet I could lift it.
惠姑：说不定，那个跟我差不多高的大花瓶也举得起来！

She finds herself standing in front of the vase in the corner, excitedly stretching out her hands to measure its height and width.
说着，惠姑便走向放置在房间角落的花瓶，跃跃欲试地比画着它的高度和直径。

???: Hello, Mayfly.
???：惠姑，你醒了？

Mayfly: Who-Who's that? Wait.
惠姑：您……您是？咦？

Mayfly: Paper Heron?
惠姑：鹭鸶剪？

???: We were chatting outside your room when we heard your voice. I'm glad to see that you are doing well.
???：刚才我与鹭鸶剪在门外谈些事情，听到房间内有响动，便想应该是你终于醒了。

???: I know what you wish to ask. You are in the School of Mei.
???：你现在身处梅花教内，想必一定有很多疑问。无妨，我们慢慢来。

The lady smiles and nods as she explains further.
身着白衣的夫人微笑着点点头，继续向惠姑介绍。

???: And I am its founder. They call me Master Rén, or Rén the Immortal.
???：我是梅花教的掌门，大家都称我任仙子，你也这么跟着叫便好。

Mayfly: Rén the Immortal.
惠姑：任仙子……

Mayfly: Th-Then, you must be the immortal everyone's been talking about?
惠姑：难道您、您就是那个“仙人”！

Mayfly: Please, Master, teach me the Method of Longevity!
惠姑：请仙人授我长生之法！

Master Ren: Hah hah. Another young soul looking too far ahead to see the truth before them.
任仙子：呵呵……又是一个初见而不知真貌的小家伙。

Master Ren: The immortal you seek is standing right in front of you, but it isn't me. In fact, I was one of her students.
任仙子：你要找的人就在此处，可并不是我。当年，我也是承了她的恩，才习得这长生之法的。

Mayfly: What?
惠姑：……诶?

Mayfly shifts her focus between Master Rén and Paper Heron before resting on the more comfortably familiar face.
惠姑的目光在任仙子和鹭鸶剪之间游移，然后试探性地落在了鹭鸶剪身上。

Saying nothing, Master Rén smiles and follows Mayfly's gaze to Paper Heron.
任仙子不语，也笑着看向鹭鸶剪。

Mayfly: Heron? You mean, she's the immortal?!
惠姑：鹭鸶剪——?！你是说鹭鸶剪她才是仙人?!

Paper Heron stirs the sweet soup in her bowl. The white sugar has sunk to the bottom.
鹭鸶剪搅着碗里的甜汤，里面的白砂糖因为饱和而沉了底。

Paper Heron: I'd prefer if you wouldn't call me that, Mayfly. Makes me feel as though I'm covered in ants.
鹭鸶剪：可以不用这个词称呼我吗？听了只觉得身上有蚂蚁在爬。

Mayfly: But how can that be?
惠姑：这到底是怎么回事?

Master Ren: Do you recall the evening passed?
任仙子：你还记得昨晚的事吗?

Mayfly: Last night, I was pushed out on the stage, and then ...
惠姑：昨晚……在戏台上，我……

Master Ren: Precisely. It was then that Paper Heron held the longevity ritual for you. You fell into a deep slumber for the rest of the night.
任仙子：是了，昨晚鹭鸶剪在戏台上为你以剑抚顶，做了仪式，之后你就睡得十分之香甜。

Master Ren: How do you feel now?
任仙子：你现在感觉如何?

Mayfly: I feel refreshed, energetic, alive. Then, I've gained longevity already?
惠姑：倒是觉得神清气爽，也有力气了不少……我已然长生了?

Master Ren: No. This is but the first step.
任仙子：不，你只是跨进了长生的门槛。

Master Ren: Master Heron altered the flowing pattern of your Qi to imitate that of the Way, laying the foundation for true longevity cultivation.
任仙子：鹭鸶剪初步扭转了你体内的气蕴，使其运行更接近天道，符合继续修行的条件。

Master Ren: But this alone will not extend your life. To achieve true longevity, one must cultivate it through the method of our school. Worry not. I will be your guide.
任仙子：要想真正获得长生，还需在梅花教内用特定的法子继续修行，这法门我会慢慢教与你们的。

Mayfly: I see. No, wait.
惠姑：这样啊，等、等一下……

Mayfly looks puzzled; she counts her fingers, as if attempting to follow the logic to its conclusion.
惠姑疑惑地掰起了手指头。

Mayfly: Paper Heron, if you're Master Rén's master and the founder of the School of Mei ...
惠姑：也就是说……鹭鸶剪是任仙子的师父……是梅花教的师祖……

Mayfly: Then you knew all along? You were just pretending?
惠姑：那你明明什么都知道……一路上还跟我装傻充愣……

Mayfly: Th-Then, you lied too! You know, I felt so guilty about leaving you behind!
惠姑：好啊，原来我也被你骗了，这下我……我不会再内疚啦！

Paper Heron: I didn't deceive you. I had no inkling that it was Rén that you sought.
鹭鸶剪：我没有故意要瞒你啦……原先我也不知你是来找任仙子的。

Paper Heron: I only learned of her ritual on the stage at the last instant. I took her place as its officiator as a bit of fun.
鹭鸶剪：我本不知庙会的安排，后来才晓得任仙子本来要在戏台上传法，我一时兴起便替了她。

Paper Heron: But I looked quite splendid up there, don't you think? Didn't you notice it was me?
鹭鸶剪：怎么样，昨晚我厉害吧？你是不是都没意识到戏台上的人变成我了？

At this pleasant thought, Paper Heron spoons some of the sweet soup into her mouth.
想到高兴之处，鹭鸶剪美滋滋地舀了一口甜汤放进嘴里。

Mayfly: ...
惠姑：……

Mayfly: So it was you who slipped the amulet and the note into my pocket.
惠姑：那……那日临别时，我口袋中的护符和纸条，也是你通过这法子放的?

Paper Heron: Of course. I hadn't cast that spell for some time, so I thought I'd seize the opportunity to give it a spin.
鹭鸶剪：嗯，这法子我很久没使过了，正好这趟出来，不就得着几个机会了嘛。

Paper Heron: Ah, why the glum look, eh? Our performance was a great success. Yao have joined the school in spadefuls.
鹭鸶剪：别苦着脸呀，惠姑，你知道吗，昨天演出的效果可好了！现在有好多小妖怪都在外面排着队要学。

Mayfly: They're here for the Method, not your magic tricks.
惠姑：学也是学长生之法，不是你这乱七八糟的……

Mayfly: Ah, scythe me down. You're the immortal! How could I say such a thing?
惠姑：……啊不，不成，怎么能对仙人这样说——

Before Mayfly can finish, hurried steps outside cut her off.
惠姑还没说完，便被门外一阵急匆匆的脚步声打断。

Mayfly: Hm?
惠姑：咦……?

The footsteps stop at the door, followed by whispers and the rustle of clothes.
那脚步声到了门口，倏地停了下来，紧接着一阵窃窃私语和衣裳摩挲之声传来。

Suddenly, a short, plump hedgehog and a yam with a leafy head peek out from behind the door. Then a gray rat, a shrew, and behind them, a whole parade of other Yao.
突然，门口露出一只矮胖的小刺猬、一只头上长草的山药精，紧接着是一只灰鼠精、一只鼩鼱精，后面还有一群排成长队、乌泱泱的小精怪们……

Noisy Yao: Immortal! Please, forgive our intrusion. We're here to see you and our new schoolmate.
喧闹的小妖：仙人！听说您在此处，我们冒昧来看您……和新来的小师妹了！

Shy Yao: Grandmaster, our greatest thanks for these artifacts. We've brought a token of our gratitude. Though it's not so valuable, I hope it will suffice.
害羞的小妖：师……师祖，晚辈不才，您见面给我们带的那些贵重法器，晚辈没……没有好报答的回礼，若您不嫌弃……

Paper Heron: Oh, think nothing of it. Consider it a gift from your grandmaster.
鹭鸶剪：哎哟，这有什么。咱们都是同脉传人，这是我头次来教门看你们，也是应该的。

Noisy Yao: Thank you, Immor—Uh, Grandmaster. Erm, if it's not too much trouble, could you teach us the spell you used on the stage last night?
喧闹的小妖：仙……啊呸呸，师祖客气了，昨夜您表演完那招后，咱们好多人都说想学呢！

Mayfly: ...
惠姑：……

Paper Heron waves their praise away with her hand, but the smile behind that waving hand reveals her joy.
鹭鸶剪摆摆手，脸上的表情却是很受用。

Paper Heron: Sure, it's not so difficult. Just say what more you want to learn, and I shall teach you.
鹭鸶剪：这有何难！回头我教你们就是，你们还想学什么？

The Yao pour in, talking excitedly with Paper Heron. Mayfly watches as her friend-turned-grandmaster enters the circle and shakes her head.
涌入的精怪们和鹭鸶剪正热闹地攀谈着，惠姑看着被围成一圈的鹭鸶剪，摇了摇头。

Master Ren: Ahem!
任仙子：咳咳！

A few clear coughs cut the clamoring voices short.
几声清响，任仙子用咳嗽打断了这场热闹的师门相聚。

Master Ren: Now, now, students. You ought to show respect in the presence of the grandmaster. Enough playfulness. You must all return to your cultivation.
任仙子：好了，别闹你们师祖了，如此嬉笑，成何体统？该修炼的便回去修炼，其他人各自回位。

Shy Yao: But I hear this is the first time the grandmaster has visited our school in many years. We only wanna talk to her.
害羞的小妖：可……可我听说师祖多年未踏足我们梅花教，昨夜才第一次到来……大家，大家都想多跟师祖说说话……

Paper Heron: And talk we shall.
鹭鸶剪：我也很想和大家多聊聊。

Master Rén smiles.
任仙子微笑了一下。

Master Ren: The grandmaster will be with us for many days. There will be plenty of time.
任仙子：你们师祖将在教门内停留多日，到时有什么问题，尽管问便是了。

Master Ren: For now, we ought to consider our newest schoolmate. You need some time to settle in, isn't that so, Mayfly?
任仙子：只是怕你们现在打扰到新进门的师妹，惠姑，你说是不是？

Mayfly: Err ...
惠姑：诶……

Master Ren: You have just received the ritual. Your body needs time to adapt.
任仙子：你刚刚得法，身体正是需要适应的时候。

Master Ren: Students, will you show Mayfly around our school? A little bit of activity should do her good.
任仙子：你们这些做师兄师姐的，带惠姑多走动走动，了解下咱们教门的环境，如何?

Paper Heron: Ah, right. Best to get some exercise.
鹭鸶剪：哦，对！是得多活动活动！

Noisy Yao: Whatever you say, Master.
喧闹的小妖：师父说得是，咱们确实冒昧了些。

Noisy Yao: Mayfly, is it? We brought you a gift too. Sorry, we got carried away after seeing the grandmaster.
喧闹的小妖：你叫惠姑是吧？其实咱们也给你带了一点礼……嘿，刚刚只管围着师祖转，差点忘了！

The Yao bring out several boxes of herbs and steamers filled with cakes, all prepared in advance—a substantial offering.
这只小妖拿出了早已准备好的数盒药材、几笼糕点放在桌上，份量看着并不轻。

Mayfly: That's alright, and thank you for the gift. I feel so full of energy now. I'd love to look around.
惠姑：啊……谢谢你们的好意！我……我也觉得身体里有股劲儿，十分想出去跑跑跳跳。

Paper Heron: You should spend some time getting to know the other students. Your gift can wait.
鹭鸶剪：前庭那边还挺好玩的，惠姑你可叫它们带你过去看看，等回来再拆礼也不迟。

Mayfly: Alright then. I can save it for later.
惠姑：照，那我们先走一步，不打搅二位大人了。

Mayfly pats her skirt and leaves with the Yao. Soon, she enters a busy courtyard bustling with the voices of other students of the School of Mei.
惠姑拍了拍裙面，便随着小妖们一同离开了厢房，不久后，庭院内便传来了梅花教弟子的惊呼。

Noisy Yao: Stop it, Mayfly! That cauldron's too heavy! You could hurt yourself.
喧闹的小妖：师妹！那可是千斤大鼎，举不得啊——

Master Ren: Heh heh. I was just like her back then. Didn't know what to do with my newfound strength.
任仙子：呵呵……想当初我刚获得长生之时，也是这般，不知力该往何处使了。

Paper Heron lifts another spoonful of her sweet soup to her lips and then sets the bowl down.
鹭鸶剪从碗里舀了一大口甜汤，随后便把碗放在了桌子上。

Master Ren: So, have you retrieved your five senses?
任仙子：你那“五感退化”的毛病，有好些吗?

Paper Heron: Hmm. Mmm.
鹭鸶剪：嗯——嗯——

Master Rén nods and waits for Paper Heron to swallow.
任仙子点点头，等待鹭鸶剪把嘴里的东西咽下去。

Paper Heron: No, it's become worse. Even clear soup is practically tasteless to me now. But enough about that; we have more important things to discuss.
鹭鸶剪：还是那样子，这次回来，连“清白盏”的味道都尝不出来了……还是聊聊正事吧！

Paper Heron: My divinations suggest that Lǎnzhū is waking. I have observed many omens along the road.
鹭鸶剪：近日我夜中起卦望气，险道兽揽诸已醒了五六分，我来的路上也看到了不少异象预兆。

Paper Heron: Birds migrating north, withered grass blackening. Ere long, Lǎnzhū will awaken.
鹭鸶剪：冬天千鸟北徙，枯草变黑……用不了多久，它便会完全苏醒了。

Paper Heron: Unlike other Xiǎndào Beasts, Lǎnzhū is not under Zhènzǐ's control. The quake it wrought brought great suffering to the Huanzhou region.
鹭鸶剪：揽诸与其他险道兽有异，它脱离了侲子的管束，在涣州一带兴风作浪，引发地震。

Paper Heron: The White Horse School once fought it, and I among them, yet we could only force it into a long slumber.
鹭鸶剪：曾经，我白马派以“金丹术”与其缠斗百年，能做的也仅是将其堵塞的气穴打通，使其再次陷入沉睡。

Paper Heron: Until the Way bestowed on us two Swords of Longevity, allowing ordinary students to control the Qi of Yin and Yang in order to pacify Lǎnzhū.
鹭鸶剪：后有了祖师得大道所赐的两把长生剑，才让普通弟子也有了运转阴阳之气、安抚揽诸之力。

Paper Heron: But then ...
鹭鸶剪：但现在……

She pauses.
鹭鸶剪停了停。

Master Ren: You need not say more.
任仙子：我知晓你的意思。

Master Rén draws an array in the air. It glows gold for a moment, then fades as a white sword appears.
任仙子在空中划了一个法阵，那法阵金光萦绕了一阵后便退却，显出一把通体莹白的剑来。

Paper Heron stares intently at the sword. It floats in the air, radiating with a soft white glow.
鹭鸶剪沉重地望着这把剑，空中的长生剑发出温润莹莹的白光，一如既往。

Paper Heron: Now, only one sword remains.
鹭鸶剪：如今，长生剑只余一把。

Paper Heron: And the White Horse School is no more.
鹭鸶剪：白马派亦已不存于世。

Her hands shake as she grips it, as if she were holding it too tightly.
她紧握着剑柄，双手略有些颤抖。

Master Ren: You needn't worry. Since the moment you passed the sword to me, I have been making preparations to face Lǎnzhū.
任仙子：……不必担心，自从你手中接过长生剑后，我便开始考虑镇压揽诸。

Master Ren: I know the consequences if I fail. The earth will split, and beneath the dual sun and moon, disaster and disorder will reign.
任仙子：我知揽诸一旦苏醒，定有天崩地裂、乾坤失序、日月同天之象。

Master Ren: Zhu County, all of Huanzhou, will shatter, causing untold devastation.
任仙子：若镇压失败，不只是祝县，整个涣州都将分崩离析，百姓将面临灭顶之灾。

Master Ren: That is why I founded the School of Mei to gather strength in numbers.
任仙子：于是我便创立梅花教，好广集天下群侠之力量。

Master Ren: Though I wield the last Sword of Longevity, if it should fail, I have prepared a Quelling Array. But I will need their strength to help me activate it.
任仙子：这几十年间，我已做好了万全的打算，既有长生剑作倚靠，又列了“镇殃大阵”以作后手，万无一失。

Paper Heron: Oh!
鹭鸶剪： 哦?

Master Ren: Do I surprise you?
任仙子： 你很惊讶?

Paper Heron looks around the room and answers with a sigh.
鹭鸶剪环视厢房，轻轻地叹了一口气。

Paper Heron: Ah, no. It's just ... You were but a little Yao when we first met beneath that tree. Look how you've grown.
鹭鸶剪： 不，只是感慨那年今日，你还是梅花树下的一名小妖……如今已是一方教派的掌门了。

Master Ren: Heh heh. A Yao's life is shorter than most. We must make every day count.
任仙子： 呵呵……对你来说数旬光阴并无区别，但对我们这些寿命不过几轮圆月的小妖就不是了。

Master Ren: You entrusted this task to me, and I will do all that I must to finish it.
任仙子： 人生苦短。既然你将此事托付于我，我定将全力以赴。

Master Ren: I will allow nothing to get in my way. Not only for the sake of the school, but for the sake of everyone in this land.
任仙子： 镇压之事不会出纰漏，这是为了梅花教，更是为了天下人。

She sees Rén's smile. Paper Heron pauses, then offers an affirming smile to her old student.
看着任仙子的微笑，鹭鸶剪一怔，随后摇头一笑。

Paper Heron: You are more prepared than I could ever hope to be. But mind your students well. I should not like to see your school meet the same fate as mine, eh?
鹭鸶剪： 看来我是多虑了，你的考量比我周全许多。不过我要提醒，好生护着你的徒儿们，别让白马派灭门一事再度重演。

Paper Heron: I will stay here until the task is done. And intervene if need be.
鹭鸶剪： 我会在祝县待到镇压结束，危难之时我也会出手。

Master Rén replies with a solemn nod.
任仙子郑重地点点头。

Master Ren: Grandmaster, you gave me a second life and the Sword of Longevity. I owe my life to you.
任仙子： 当初梅树下，你授我长生，赐我长生剑，才有了今天的我与梅花教。

Master Ren: I swear I will complete the suppression, no matter the cost. For you and for your school.
任仙子： 在此事上，我与梅花教必将全力以赴，定不负你的赐剑之恩，也不负你师门未竟的遗命。你放心。

境遇
Dilemma SU-11

In the dim cell, low chants rise and fall over and over until it almost feels like a natural phenomenon, like the howling of the wind.
阴暗的班房中，时不时传来幽幽的吟诵之声。

Constable I: Chief, all the Yao we've arrested are here.
巡捕 I： 程巡检，这段时间捕获的闹事精怪都关在这里。

Jail, Ancient Zhu County
古祝县·班房

A cell door creaks open slowly. The other Yao stop and look out from their cells at the three who enter.
随着门发出悠长的吱嘎声，精怪们停了下来，在各自的牢狱中齐齐望着于门后出现的三人。

Cheng Heguang: ...
程和光：……

Cheng Heguang: Hmph. This must be the true meaning of being "watched like a hawk."
程和光：呵，我到今天才知道“鹰瞵鹗视”到底是个什么意思。

Cheng Heguang: You may leave. I will have the victim identify the culprit.
程和光：你出去吧，我让苦主问几句就走。

Constable I: Understood.
巡捕 I：是。

The cell is packed with Yao. Afraid, a man presses himself fearfully against Chéng Héguāng.
进了这尽是精怪的班房，程和光身边的平民男子畏惧地瑟缩至程和光身边。

Chéng grips his blade and tells the man not to be afraid, as he takes the first bold step toward them.
程和光握了握腰间的长刀，扭头示意男子莫慌，便稳步踏下台阶。

Cheng Heguang: I trust there's no need to introduce myself.
程和光：你们应当认得我。

Bird: Of course, Chief Chéng. After all, it took us all quite some effort to sneak past you, hahahahaha.
鸟妖：程巡检，我们自然认识，毕竟要从你那城门进来，实在是费了我们不少工夫，哈哈哈哈……

Bird: Let no one say that you neglected your duties. In fact, you did such a sterling job that not even a fly could buzz through that gate.
鸟妖：这可不是说程巡检玩忽职守的意思，是您管理的城门实在是连只苍蝇都难飞进来呀。

Bird: A pity for you that I soar much higher than a fly! Ahahahahahaha!
鸟妖：可惜我飞得比苍蝇要高得多。

The Yao all laugh, leading Chéng Héguāng to raise his blade and strike it against the cell door.
众妖哄笑起来，程和光提刀震了一下牢门。

Cheng Heguang: Quiet!
程和光：肃静！

Cheng Heguang: Look over them. See if you can identify the one that abducted your family.
程和光：你看看，这里面是否有诱拐你家人的那只精怪？可得瞧仔细了。

Even with the cell door between them, the man feels surrounded by Yao; he dodges fruitlessly left then right as if to avoid their gaze.
即使有牢门阻隔，男子仍被精怪环绕，他左躲右躲都不是，只差没顶个竹篓将自己扣进去。

He peeks at the jailed Yao from the corner of his eye. But each glance makes him all the more concerned.
他瑟缩着从眼角瞄着被囚的精怪，瞧上一眼都要缓上三缓。

County Resident I: I-I don't see them.
祝县县民 I：没有……

Bird: My, my, should I call you County Magistrate Chéng now? If I recall correctly, it falls outside of the duties of mere constables to interrogate suspects.
鸟妖：程巡检真有种知县的范儿了，嘶——但我记得按照大明律法，区区巡检没有审讯的权力。

Through the bars, a bird-like Yao leans toward Chéng Héguāng.
隔着牢门，鸟妖尽可能近地凑到了程和光的面前。

Bird: Could it be that you are using this opportunity to learn the Method of Longevity for yourself? Haha!
鸟妖：您莫不是借机找我们讨那“长生”的法子来的?

Cheng Heguang: Enough of your twittering, bird. I am investigating this rumor on behalf of the people, not for myself.
程和光：鼓唇弄舌。我来这里确实与“长生之法”有关，但不是为了与你们同流合污。

Cheng Heguang: Nor is this a formal interrogation. I am within my rights to question any one of you.
程和光：我虽非知县，照例问询的权力还是有的，我迟早将你们查个清楚！

Bird: Heh heh. And if I don't tell you a thing, what then, Chief Chéng?
鸟妖：嘻嘻……我之前不是说了吗，程巡检可审不了我们，我们不说，您又能如何?

Bird: Must you really be so harsh on us? Every Yao in Zhu County is scared to death of you.
鸟妖：巡检为何总与我们过不去？整个祝县，就您让我们提心吊胆。

Bird: But I know that you're not all that cruel-hearted. Could you be persuaded to let us go?
鸟妖：予您黄金万两，予您长命百岁……

As she speaks, she puts both hands through the bars. One holds a gold bar, the other a charm. She waves them before Chéng Héguāng.
鸟妖一边说着，一边将两只手伸出牢门，一手金条，一手符箓，交替着在程和光面前轮舞。

Bird: I can offer you both wealth and health.
鸟妖：您留我们一条生路，尽早放了我们可好?

Cheng Heguang: Fiend! I will not allow you to deceive me.
程和光：妖言惑众！别以为能拿这拙劣的谎话骗我。

Chéng Héguāng pushes her hands aside with the back of his blade. She jumps back, staring at him tensely, then approaches once more.
程和光以刀背拂开鸟妖的手，惊得她向后蹦了一丈，绷着身子望了程和光一阵，才缓缓地走了回来。

Bird: You think it deception merely because you believe the Method of Longevity to be a false rumor.
鸟妖：巡检如此针对我们，不过是觉得长生之法是假的。

Bird: But what if I tell you, it's true, hm? Take a guess at how old I am.
鸟妖：若我说，这不是谣言，程巡检又该如何看待呢？你猜我如今几岁了?

Cheng Heguang: There's no need to guess. It is said that Yao can live over a thousand years.
程和光：我不必做这样的猜测，你本是精怪，就算千岁又如何。

Bird: Whoever told you that knew nothing. Our lives are scarcely longer than our true forms. My own kind live and die within the age of a sparrow. Nothing more.
鸟妖：错了，天行有常，命数已定。我们精怪只是假托大道，化作人形，寿命却不改，普通麻雀活多久，我便活多久。

Surprise flashes in Chéng Héguāng's eyes. He motions for her to continue.
程和光眼里闪过一丝惊讶，示意鸟妖继续说下去。

Bird: We only want a little more time in this world, Chief Chéng. Why must you stand in our way?
鸟妖：我们只是想通过别的法子活得久一点，程巡检，你何故为难我们?

Cheng Heguang: Then should I simply allow you and your people to kill, steal, and bring chaos?
程和光：好让你们继续谋财害命，为祸人间?

Bird: Me and my people?
鸟妖：我们?

She is stunned for a moment, then responds with a burst of laughter.
鸟妖愣了一下，便开怀大笑起来。

Bird: Hahahaha ... I see.
鸟妖：哈哈哈哈……我懂了。

Bird: You believe the Yao to be evil.
鸟妖：程巡检，是以为我们精怪全无好人。

Cheng Heguang: No, not universally. Yet it is Yao like you who spread these dangerous rumors in the county.
程和光：不，是你们这些散播流言的精怪绝非好人。

The Yao stops laughing, her neck jerking in as her feathers rise and puff out.
听闻此言，鸟妖突然止了笑意，缩起脖子，全身的羽毛簌簌抖起。

Filled with rage, she storms toward Chéng Héguāng, ignoring the bars.
也不顾栅门的阻挡，她暴怒着冲向程和光。

Bird: It is no rumor, fool! Even if it were, what harm have we ever brought for speaking it alone? All our kind desire is to live!
鸟妖：你这废物！我们从来都没有害过任何一个人！只是想活下去！

Bird: I've done nothing wrong! Release me! Every moment is precious!
鸟妖：我什么都没有做！放我出去！我等不起了！

Cheng Heguang: You may not have taken part in these abductions, but the rumors you spread surely enticed the ones that did. I will not release you.
程和光：即使你与诱拐之事无关，你也是妖言惑众之人，你被拘在这里，并不冤屈。

Bird: Fine, continue in your blindness, but the School of Mei will bring justice to us all.
鸟妖：你这样对我们……梅花教不会放过你的。

The Yao turns fierce, beating her wings in the cell. Claw marks cover the walls.
鸟妖发了狠，在牢中扑腾起翅膀来，砖墙上尽是抓痕。

Cheng Heguang: The School of Mei. That's the name of your sect, is it?
程和光：梅花教，便是你们那教派的名字?

Her anger has become an incomprehensible mash of threats and insults. Chéng Héguāng stands between her and the scared man, leading him away.
鸟妖不愿再说更多，只是一味地泄愤。程和光阻隔在鸟妖与惊恐的平民男子之间，护着他离开了班房。

Study, Yamen
古祝县·县衙书房

In the Yamen's study, the man sits shaking on a wooden chair.
衙门书房，平民男子颤抖着坐在木椅之上。

Cheng Heguang: Calm down. Have some tea.
程和光：喝点茶水，压压惊。

County Resident I: Th-Thank you.
祝县县民 I：好……好……

He takes the tea, sips a few times, then sets it down.
男子接过茶水，啜饮几口，便放了下去。

Cheng Heguang: No need to worry; our cells are quite unbreakable.
程和光：无须惊慌，它们现在被关在牢中，不会再随意出来害人了。

Cheng Heguang: So, what more do you know of the Yao that abducted your family?
程和光： 关于诱拐你家人的那只精怪，你可还能想起什么来?

County Resident I: It was jabbering on about "longevity." That's all I know.
祝县县民 I： 我只知道它们口口声声说是要长生……

Cheng Heguang: This rumor is a true menace to society.
程和光： 害人不浅。

County Resident I: Please, Chief Chéng, please find my father. You're my only hope.
祝县县民 I： 程巡检……求求你，我只能靠你了……帮我把我爹找回来吧!

He grabs the front of Chéng Héguāng's clothes as if to kneel. But the chief constable catches him by the arms and lifts him to his feet.
男子抓住程和光的衣襟，几欲下跪，程和光只好拢住他的臂肘，将他托起身。

Cheng Heguang: Please, sir. I am merely fulfilling my duty.
程和光： 不必如此，这本就是我分内之事。

Cheng Heguang: I will find the truth. This I swear.
程和光： 我答应你，一定会查明真相。

County Resident I: Thank you.
祝县县民 I： 谢谢……

Cheng Heguang: Rest a while. Best not to overwork yourself.
程和光： 你在这里歇歇再回去吧，切勿过于劳神，伤及身体。

Cheng Heguang: Guard!
程和光： 来人!

Constable I: Chief.
巡捕 I： 程巡检。

Cheng Heguang: Take care of the good man. I must deliver my report on the events at the opera.
程和光： 照顾好这位报案人，我要去旁听“高跷巡神案”的审理。

Constable I: Understood.
巡捕 I： 是。

Chéng Héguāng pats the poor man's shoulder as they walk out.
程和光拍了拍男子的肩，走出门去。

A breeze follows him past the door and scatters far away.
一缕风随着他的动作越过门槛，散往远处。

Hall, Yamen
古祝县·县衙大堂

In the great hall, a report on the case is being given to the gathered court.
衙署大堂内，一场临时汇报正在进行。

Registrar: The female Daoist raised her sword above a woman's head, revealing the latter's true form to be that of a herbaceous entity and shifting her withered leaves into a verdant green.
主簿： ……女道士以剑相抚一名村姑的头顶，女子现出原形，枯黄的根茎重新变为青绿色。

Registrar: The Daoist then proclaimed the ability to bestow longevity upon any who joined her school. This declaration incited the crowd to a frenzy as they stampeded the stage.
主簿： 随后，她对台下众人称可赐人长生，听到此话，场下的精怪与百姓失神一般涌上戏台。

Registrar: Later, the Daoist vanished from the scene together with the herbaceous entity. Several Yao present were detained, and the injured were escorted to the nearest clinic for treatment.
主簿：……之后，仙人与村姑不知所踪。我们抓捕了部分精怪，并救治了十数位在踩踏中受伤的百姓。

Registrar: In summary, the stampede has been determined to be an unforeseen incident arising from the female Daoist's use of arcane skills.
主簿：综上所述，这应该是在“高跷巡神”的戏台上由烛火妖法引起的意外。

With the report concluded, the paper is folded once more and then handed over to the county magistrate.
汇报结束，条陈被重新折起，呈递到知县手中。

County Magistrate: "Unforeseen incident"? Your lack of foresight has seen this longevity rumor spread to every corner of the county!
知县：哼，意外？“高跷巡神”出事后，到处都有那长生之法的谣传。

County Magistrate: Yao are flooding our lands in droves! Never in my life have I received so many reports of missing persons and acts of sedition!
知县：精怪疯了一样往城里挤，东坊报邻里失踪，西坊报妖书妖言，我这桌案几天之内就垒了堪比几个月的本子！

County Magistrate: Make no mistake. This is the result of your errors!
知县：这就是你们干的好事！

The magistrate crumples the paper and throws it at the registrar. In response, the man bows even lower.
知县将条陈揉成一团，直直砸到主簿身上，而堂下的人只是把腰弓得更低了。

County Magistrate: *sigh* We were foolish to put our faith in you.
知县：唉，我知道你们是指望不上了。

County Magistrate: Commander Lì, you are in charge of our defenses. Tell me, how should we proceed?
知县：厉守备，我借调你来管城防，如今……你说怎么办？

Lì Huìfēng had been standing nearby; he pauses, considering the details for a moment, before speaking out in a measured tone.
一旁伫立的男人沉吟片刻，缓缓开口。

Li Huifeng: In these desperate times, I can see only one solution.
厉晦锋：非常时期当用非常之法。

Li Huifeng: I would divide all constables into two shifts and have them sweep the entire county. We will locate and apprehend all Yao hiding among the populace over the next three days.
厉晦锋：官兵吏员分为两班，昼夜盘查，力争三日内肃清所有混入城中的精怪。

County Magistrate: Very good! Do you hear that? All departments will cooperate with Commander Lì! And if I hear of any misconduct, I will show no mercy!
知县：甚好，甚好！都听到了吗！谁若是偷奸耍滑，休怪本县不留情面！

The others hasten to agree as they bow with clasped hands.
众人唯唯诺诺，抱揖称是。

Chéng Héguāng has been wanting to speak. Seeing his chance, he seizes it and steps forward.
程和光几欲开口，如今寻到机会，赶忙上前一步。

Cheng Heguang: Honorable Magistrate, I believe we also ought to consider investigating the School of Mei.
程和光：属下以为，精怪之外，梅花教也需严加盘查！

The other clerks sneak sneering glances toward him, like a discolored bean sifted from the pile.
其余吏员偷偷抬眼，看向这粒被筛落的黄豆。

County Magistrate: And you are? Wait, I believe I recall, Chief Chéng, is it?
知县：你？哦……我对你有印象……你是……程巡检，对吧？

County Magistrate: And this School of Mei? A minor religious sect, yes?
知县：梅花教？可是那活跃于县内的小教？

Cheng Heguang: Yes. Please forgive me. After the report was submitted, I discovered a connection between the sect and the animal carcasses found on the streets.
程和光：是。秉知县，属下正追查动物遗尸的案件，庭审前才顺藤摸瓜寻到了梅花教，还未来得及写到案卷之上。

Cheng Heguang: While in custody, a suspect admitted that the School of Mei was behind the mysterious parade connected to both the rumors and the drained carcasses.
程和光：已有涉事精怪承认，那神秘游行队伍是梅花教在背后指使，而长生谣言和动物遗尸与这支游行队伍又有颇多联系。

Cheng Heguang: I believe this opera was another part of their scheme. If the Yao are the fruit, the School of Mei is the root.
程和光：因此，“戏台授长生”的闹剧极有可能也是出自梅花教的手笔。精怪是叶，梅花教才是根。

The others look away and whisper.
官吏们收回目光，忍不住窃窃私语。

Deputy Magistrate: And who are you to speak? Some upstart boy desperate to clear his family name?
县丞：这就是那个程巡检？次次都抢着出头的那个？

Registrar: That's him alright. Just last month, he was ranting about some thief-catching scheme; the argument could be heard from the streets.
主簿：对，就是他。上个月捕盗还和咱们衙门抢功劳，争得面红耳赤。

Deputy Magistrate: Do you remember last year? This boy nigh on knocked the doors down, insisting we include those deserters he caught in our update to the Imperial Court.
县丞：去岁考核，咱们原本报了无事太平，他抓了几个逃兵，非要年前交上去。

Deputy Magistrate: Hard to believe the magistrate allowed him to leave with his head. It seems he hasn't any sense for his position or his shame.
县丞：你是不知道，当时知县老爷脸都黑了……只想着向上爬，一点处世之道也不会。

Registrar: The son of a bandit turncoat. No wonder he barks like a dog, demanding praise for his every deed.
主簿：他那背景你也知道，急着摇尾巴表忠心呗……

Registrar: He's fooling himself if he thinks he can wash himself clean of his family's past.
主簿：要我看，贼就是贼，终究是上不了台面……

Chéng Héguāng ignores their whispers and stands tall and firm as a noble pine.
程和光对这些低语置若罔闻，只是如松柏一样扎在原地。

County Magistrate: Commander Lì, thoughts on this matter?
知县：厉守备……你看此事……

As all else goes quiet, Lì Huìfēng clears his throat and speaks.
众人安静了下来，厉晦锋干咳几声，开口说道。

Li Huifeng: Ahem. I hold to what I've said before; the Yao pose a serious danger to the people. Our priority must be to expel them from the county.
厉晦锋：不论如何，都不可放任精怪在县内胡作非为，将其驱逐，维护县内治安才是重中之重。

Li Huifeng: What would you have us do, Your Honor?
厉晦锋：知县觉得如何?

County Magistrate: The matter is handed to Commander Lì. Dismissed.
知县：这事便交付给守备了，大家散了吧。

Constables: Understood.
众人：是!

Cheng Heguang: But the School of Mei ...
程和光：可梅花教一事……

The others seem prepared to leave, but Chéng Héguāng looks around anxiously, until finding the familiar shape of his commander waiting under the eaves.
眼看众人就要这么散去，程和光着了急，他四下寻找，仅剩厉晦锋还在廊下等他。

Cheng Heguang: Commander Lì!
程和光：厉守备!

Li Huifeng: Come here, Héguāng.
厉晦锋：和光，你过来一下。

Lì Huìfēng walks from the hall in long, quick strides, forcing his subordinate to hurry to keep pace.
厉晦锋快步走出大堂，程和光不得不后面小步疾走。

Li Huifeng: Are you really so desperate for glory that you forget the chain of command?
厉晦锋：和光，你难道就一刻也等不得?

Li Huifeng: How do you aim to win trust if you refuse to pay respect to your betters?
厉晦锋：你这样不管不顾，如何能破得了案子?

Cheng Heguang: I apologize, Commander.
程和光：守备，我知道我不该隔越奏事。

Cheng Heguang: But this is a promising lead. If we don't act now, we may miss our chance.
程和光：可那梅花教的事，我已经从精怪口中得知确切线索！此时不查，更待何时?

Lì Huìfēng turns, his voice sterner than ever.
厉晦锋转过身来，语气是前所未有的严厉。

Li Huifeng: Do you think you're the only one with a lead on this case?
厉晦锋：你有线索，难道就你有线索?

Li Huifeng: That no one else can do as you have done? Not even those with greater power and resources?
厉晦锋：你区区一个巡检都能知道，其他人能不知道？你能查到，其他人能查不到?

Li Huifeng: Is that why you announced your intentions for all to hear? Your heart may be pure, but others have their own designs. If your words reach the wrong ears, do you think they will sit and do nothing about it?
厉晦锋：你自持正义，便光明磊落袒露线索。可并非人人都是如此。若他人堂上听去，暗中通风。你还能有线索吗?

Chéng Héguāng's tongue twists. He had prepared for a scolding, not this.
程和光徒劳地张开了嘴，他本做好了挨一顿批评的准备。

Cheng Heguang: Commander, you mean ...
程和光：守备的意思是……

Li Huifeng: Keep digging, but do not draw any further attention.
厉晦锋：继续追查精怪，不要打草惊蛇。

Li Huifeng: That's all for today. And if your actions are brought to light, I will tell them I denied your request, understood?
厉晦锋：今天的事到此为止。这些话，当我没有说过。

Cheng Heguang: Yes, Commander!
程和光：……是，守备！

He bows deeply, then straightens his posture.
少年人领略行礼，身姿重新变得挺拔。

Cheng Heguang: I will learn from your wise words.
程和光：守备的教诲，我定会牢记于心。

梦中天台
Castle in the Sky SU-12

Yard, School of Mei
古祝县·梅花教庭院

Master Ren: Come, Mayfly. You ought to familiarize yourself with our school before you begin.
任仙子：来吧，惠姑。正式修行前，我先带你熟悉一下教门。

Mayfly: Yes, Master.
惠姑：照……

Mayfly peeks out from behind the door, watching the others in the front courtyard.
惠姑从房门探出身来，好奇地看向前庭。

Mayfly: It's still early in the morning, but everyone's already up and busy.
惠姑：这才卯时，大家就开始修炼啦……

Master Ren: It is. Soon, you will be practicing alongside them.
任仙子：是啊，你很快也会成为它们中的一员的。

The many Yao she has come to know nod to her in greeting.
看见惠姑，有不少已经面熟的小精怪向她点头致意。

Master Ren: The students live in the side house here, as will you. I believe you've met some of them already.
任仙子：这边是厢房，是弟子们日常起居的场所，你以后也会一直住在这里。有些人你可能已经面熟了。

Quick Mouse: *squeak*
灵巧的耗子：吱吱！

Mayfly: I see, ah! There's a mouse climbing up on that bamboo by the wall.
惠姑：呀——咦？为什么在墙上装一半的竹筒？刚才有耗子钻进去了……

Master Ren: Heh. Don't be alarmed by Brother Mouse. He has taken to staying in his true form most of the day.
任仙子：那是你的一位师兄，他好用真身行走。

Mayfly: F-Forgive me, Brother.
惠姑：师、师兄好！

Master Ren: I'm sure he does not mind. The School of Mei is one of the few refuges for Yao in this region. Our students are free to live in whatever form they wish. You may even choose to live as a reed, if that is what you desire.
任仙子：他已经走了。梅花教是属于精怪们的教门，在这里我们不强制大家化为人形，如果你想的话，作为一根苇草生活在这里也是可行的。

Mayfly: Live in my true form. But I ...
惠姑：作为一根苇草……吗……

Master Ren: One must learn to find fulfillment in their true nature; only then may one discern their path to the Way. It will make sense in time.
任仙子：物各有性，径自分殊，得道的办法不止一种。

Mayfly: Hmm.
惠姑：唔……

Master Ren: Come. Let us speak further in the front courtyard.
任仙子：走吧，我带你去前庭。

Mayfly: Master, where is that music coming from? I keep hearing it, but I don't see anyone playing.
惠姑：仙子，这一路上我一直听见奏乐之声，可是我怎么都找不着是在哪里传来的。

Master Ren: You won't have need of that haste much longer, Sister Mayfly.
任仙子：少安毋躁，很快你就能见到他们。

Master Ren: This is the front courtyard, where students may gather to train or rest as they like.
任仙子：此处是前庭，不论是修炼还是偷闲，大家平日聚在这里多些。

Mayfly: But no one's here.
惠姑：可是现在这里好像一个人都没有。

Master Ren: This way.
任仙子：这边。

The gardens of this land excel at artful concealment. Past the moon gate, after a few winding paths, a hidden world opens up to her.
江南的园林讲究巧妙的遮掩，月洞门之后再走过三两弯小径，又是别有一番洞天。

Black eaves press down upon white rooms that enclose a square. The ground is paved with gravel, into which white marble tiles are set, forming a Bagua array.
乌顶的檐压着洁白的厢房围成了一个正方形，碎砂石铺成的地上，汉白玉制成的长方形石砖被摆成了一个八卦阵的形状。

Students in white stand atop it, playing solemn Daoist music together.
一群白衣弟子正站在八卦阵之上，齐奏着肃穆的道乐。

Yam: There she is, the new student!
山药精：小师妹好！

Hedgehog: Sister Mayfly, are you feeling better?
刺猬精：师妹……身子可好点了？

Paper Heron waits here too. The students occasionally steal small glances at her.
鹭鸶剪也早就等在这里，众多弟子不时会瞅向这边。

She looks around, nodding to the students as she meets their eyes and greeting Mayfly in particular.
她环视周围，见此地聚集人数众多，时不时便向弟子们点点头，见到惠姑也打了声招呼。

Mayfly: Hello, everyone, what are you all doing here?
惠姑：各位……在这里做什么呢？

All Yao: Master Rén is here too!
众妖：任仙子！

All Yao: Greetings, Master! We humbly request your guidance this day!
众妖：请任仙子为我们传道授业！

Master Ren: It's good to see you all. Please, be seated.
任仙子：好，好。

The crowd spreads out and sits in a ring around Master Rén. A female Yao pulls Mayfly in to sit beside her.
众人散开，绕着任仙子围成了一个圈儿坐下。其中一位女性精怪亲切地拉过惠姑，让她在自己身边坐了下来。

Master Ren: Revision always offers new insight. And with a new student among us today, let us begin by reviewing the stages of the Method of Longevity.
任仙子：今日有新的弟子加入，我们便先温故，简单复习一下长生之法的根基，然后再知新。

Master Ren: To master this art, one must attain three stages: the regulation of Qi, concentration and visualization, and the cultivation of the body.
任仙子：修行长生之法的阶段如下，分别为“调气”“存元”和“易筋”……

Master Ren: In the first stage, we focus on the rhythm of the breath. Each of you must find the pace which best suits your constitution and nature.
任仙子：调气，是指练习呼吸和吐纳，具体的姿势和吐纳方式需根据你们个人的体质而定。

Master Ren: Once you reach a state of meditation, we will work to concentrate the mind on an object, opening ourselves to the stimuli of the divine, as for the cultivation of the body.
任仙子：存元，则是需要你们在高度入静的情况下，将意念集中于神内或身外，易筋，便是……

Hearing this, Paper Heron interrupts Master Rén.
听到这里，鹭鸶剪打断了任仙子。

Paper Heron: That wouldn't be for the best.
鹭鸶剪：这不大好。

Master Ren: Whatever do you mean, Master?
任仙子：怎么了？

Paper Heron: Your students are getting ahead of themselves. Teach them the basics first, eh? A pavilion is not built from the roof down.
鹭鸶剪：你这开口非根非基，徒儿们练功岂不是如空中楼阁？从头讲会更好些。

Master Ren: If I am to cover every foundational detail, I would have to start from before the White Horse School was even founded.
任仙子：长生之法渊源已久，从头讲的话，那便涵盖整个白马派的历史了。

Master Ren: Unfortunately, I never walked its halls. All that I know, I learned from you. Would you do us the honor, Grandmaster?
任仙子：我虽能算作白马派的传人，却从未真实在教门中修习过……还是由你来为大家讲述会更好些。

Master Ren: The students would be most grateful to hear it from your lips.
任仙子：若弟子们能因此了解功法传承之脉络，也算幸事一桩。

Paper Heron looks around. The students wait eagerly for her words. The School of Mei seems to be thriving on the high morale of its students, and her heart is warmed by it.
鹭鸶剪环视一圈，见众弟子都对自己的讲解翘首以盼，门派生机盎然，当下心中一阵宽慰。

Paper Heron: It has been quite some time since I last spoke of my old school, but I'd be happy to.
鹭鸶剪：倒是好久没跟人讲过这些了……好，今日便由我来！

She lifts her heels and leaps gracefully into the ring before launching into her story.
鹭鸶剪轻提脚跟，纵身跃进圈中，开始为众人讲解。

Paper Heron: The very first attempts at achieving longevity can be traced back to ancient times, but it's enough to start with the founding of the White Horse School, eh?
鹭鸶剪：“长生之法”最早可以追溯到上古时期，但从白马派听起也算开了个好头。

Paper Heron: It first took shape in the late Tang Dynasty, as our founding master traveled the land collecting many rare and lost scriptures in hopes of preserving the Daoist arts for future generations.
鹭鸶剪：白马派始于晚唐，师祖因注重道法传承，便前往各地搜集经法残章。

Paper Heron: From those arts, he developed a method to balance Yin and Yang, and through it, discovered the secret to a long life.
鹭鸶剪：在研读残卷的过程中，他融会贯通，从中研究出了一套可炼养阴阳之气，从而延年益寿的心法。

Paper Heron: He named it The Practice of Inner Alchemy, and it later became the foundation of the White Horse School.
鹭鸶剪：师祖将其命名为“金丹术”，而此术便成为了我们“白马派”的根基。

Paper Heron: Now, to perform it properly, you must work through these stages in order. Listen closely.
鹭鸶剪：“金丹术”修炼过程是这样的，你们听好。

Paper Heron: The scripture says, "When one's mind is tranquil and free of distracting thoughts, all things between heaven and earth will become one with it." So, the first step is to set aside worldly concerns and seek stillness from within, for only then can one perceive the presence of the Way.
鹭鸶剪：第一步，“人能常清静，天地悉皆归。”你们需得放下世情，去寻求内心的沉静，以此得以揣摩天道的意义。

Paper Heron: Step two is about finding your Qi. "Life is born of the accumulation of Qi. When Qi gathers, we live; when it disperses, we perish."
鹭鸶剪：第二步，感受自己体内的“气”，“人之生，气之聚也。聚则为生，散则为死。”

Paper Heron: Without Qi, we can neither strengthen our bodies nor nourish our spirits, and so we cannot prolong our lives. We must spend years learning its workings, until it becomes as familiar to us as our own hands.
鹭鸶剪：“气”便是我们修身养性，从而延年益寿的关键，我们需要通过漫长的摸索来认识自己体内的“气”，熟知它的流转。

Paper Heron: The third step is to use your understanding of Qi to work its flow, guiding it until it moves in harmony with the Way.
鹭鸶剪：第三步，你们需融会贯通，要学会引导自身的“气”，改变其本来的运转方式，使之融入天道。

Paper Heron: This step is the most crucial—when your body attunes itself to your Qi and allows you to retain it. This may take some time, but it must not be rushed.
鹭鸶剪：而接下来这步是重中之重，你们需得让体内的“气”和身体慢慢磨合，切不可急躁。

Paper Heron: "Without the Qi within, the body stands hollow. And if hollow, how may life endure in it?"
鹭鸶剪：“道炁不居人身，人身则空，人身既空，何得久生?”

Paper Heron: This takes real devotion. You must practice daily until your body is ready to harmonize with the flow of Qi.
鹭鸶剪：你们需日复一日，持之以恒地潜心修行，磨炼自己的肉体凡胎，使它与体内的“气”和谐共存。

Paper Heron: "To retain Qi is to attain the Way; one who has attained the Way may long endure," so the scripture says.
鹭鸶剪：“保气则得道，得道则长存”说的便是这个道理。

Paper Heron: But the path is long and perilous. Stray from it, and both body and spirit may be annihilated.
鹭鸶剪：但这磨合的过程漫长且凶险，稍有不慎，修炼者便会走火入魔，更甚者则会神形俱灭。

Paper Heron: At best, it is a process of decades; at worst, well, I've seen some wait hundreds of years.
鹭鸶剪：快的话，这个磨合的过程一般会持续个几十年，慢的话……修炼了上百年的人我也是见过。

Hedgehog: But, Grandmaster ...
刺猬精：师、师祖……

Paper Heron: Yes? Speak your mind.
鹭鸶剪：嗯，你说。

Hedgehog: Do you really mean it will take a few decades for us to master this method?
刺猬精：您说……这个过程……要经历个几十年，甚至上百年吗?

Paper Heron: To walk the path of longevity is no small feat. But the calmer your mind, the clearer your vision, and the quicker you will progress.
鹭鸶剪：这便是长生，越是静心修炼，不问外界，越是能凝神聚气，形神俱妙。

Hedgehog: But how can I devote myself to a method that takes decades to master when I only have a few years to live? And if what you say is true, wouldn't only the long-lived be able to achieve longevity?
刺猬精：可是……我的寿命也不过数载而已，如何能经历这么久的时间呢？按照师祖所说，岂不是只有长生之人才能修得长生之法了?

Paper Heron: Ah!
鹭鸶剪：这……

She pauses, composing her thoughts for a long while, then walks over to the Gen trigram.
鹭鸶剪沉吟半晌，踱步至艮卦之上。

Paper Heron: Not entirely. The scripture says, "In the pursuit of worldly knowledge, one gains daily. In the pursuit of the Way, one loses daily. Less and less is done, until nothing is done. When nothing is done, nothing is left undone."
鹭鸶剪：并非如此。有道是，“为学日益，为道日损。损之又损，以至于无为。无为而无不为。”

Paper Heron: Don't get so hung up on the path ahead. Nothing stays fixed forever. Live in the moment, and new opportunities will arise.
鹭鸶剪：你们莫陷入执念，活好当下，自然会有你们的机缘出现。

Hedgehog: So we'll just do nothing at all?
刺猬精：难道要我什么都不做吗……

Paper Heron: Not exactly. It isn't nothing but rather "non-action." We let go of all deliberate effort, attending to your purposes, doing only that which is yours to do.
鹭鸶剪：也不对。无为而无不为，并非是要你什么都不做，而是要做你该做的命内事。

Hearing her words, the Yao look at each other. One of them cannot hold back their frustration and rushes up in front of her.
听了鹭鸶剪一席话，底下的小妖们纷纷面面相觑。一只精怪按捺不住自己的性子，突然冲出人群。

Badger: That's absurd!
獾子精：这是什么话!

Badger: If that's how it is, what are we to do? Sit around and wait for death to come? Our lives are much shorter than yours, you know!
獾子精：我们本来寿命相比你们仙人的就要短，我们该做的命内事岂不就是乖乖等着寿命耗尽?

Yam: Now, now, Brother Badger. The grandmaster didn't mean ...
山药精：诶诶，獾兄别着急，万一师祖……

Undeterred by the gentle redirection, the Yao continues his questions anyway.
突然冲出的小妖并未听从同门的劝阻，继续发问。

Badger: "That which is yours to do." What's that supposed to mean? Is this "what's mine to do"?
獾子精：到底什么才是命内事？我投入梅花教，算不算命内事?

Hedgehog: Grandmaster, none of us would be here if we had been content with the time we were given.
刺猬精：师祖，我们……我们来投奔梅花教，也不是想坐着等死啊……

Paper Heron: Ah ...
鹭鸶剪：这……

Paper Heron is speechless. She sees now the crux of the issue; they have been led astray from the very beginning.
鹭鸶剪一时语塞，发现这个问题似乎从一开始就错位了。

The doubting voices grow louder. The Yao become agitated. Paper Heron stands silent above them, lost. Mayfly struggles in her seat, not knowing who to agree with.
眼见不服之声越来越大，众妖的情绪也越来越激动，鹭鸶剪站在人群中手足无措，惠姑亦不知如何是好。

Master Ren: Alright, everyone.
任仙子：好了!

A clear, loud call rings out like a stone dropped in water. The Yao immediately fall silent.
一声清亮的高喊传出，如同石子落入水面，众妖瞬间安静了下来。

Badger: Master.
獾子精：师父……

Master Rén walks into the ring and stands beside her teacher.
任仙子踱步至圈内，站到了鹭鸶剪的旁边。

Master Ren: Each of us approaches the Way differently, for we are all guided by our own nature. The grandmaster speaks only from her own experience.
任仙子：师祖肆意潇洒惯了，为人处世自有她的一番道理在，却并不一定就是天理。

Master Ren: If her words help you, hold them. If they muddle you, do not be troubled. You may understand them in the time to come.
任仙子：你们听了能有启发是最好，也不必因这番话徒增烦恼，只需先记在心里，日后说不定会有顿悟的时候。

Yam: Yes, Master.
山药精：谨遵任仙子教诲。

Master Ren: It's been a long day, and the grandmaster has traveled far. Please, leave her to rest.
任仙子：师祖远道而来实在疲乏，还得陪你们胡闹，还是让她歇歇吧。

Paper Heron looks at her former student and then at the calmed Yao. With a stiff nod, she resigns herself to a stone stool outside the ring.
鹭鸶剪看了看任仙子，又看了看被安抚好的精怪们，随后不自然地点了点头，坐到了圈外的石凳上。

Mayfly: Heron, are you alright?
惠姑：鹭……鹭鸶剪，你还好吗?

She walks over and sits by Paper Heron, whose serene facade now seems ever so subtly broken.
惠姑轻轻走了过来，坐在了稍显不安的鹭鸶剪身旁。

Paper Heron: I'm fine. Should've chosen my words with more care, though.
鹭鸶剪：我还好，只是看样子，我……似乎说错了话。

Mayfly: Well ...
惠姑：那个……

For a moment, the cicada chirps and bird calls sound unusually sharp.
惠姑不知道说什么好，一时之间，周围的蝉鸣和鸟叫逐渐显得刺耳了起来。

Paper Heron looks down, hiding her face.
鹭鸶剪低着头，惠姑看不到她的表情。

Paper Heron: I thought they'd be interested. Back in my time ...
鹭鸶剪：我本以为……本以为大家都会很乐意学这法子的，明明从前……

The words are a faint whisper, so light she barely hears them.
一句小声的咕囔从惠姑耳边传来，声音细微得几乎听不见。

Mayfly: What do you mean?
惠姑：什么?

Paper Heron: Nothing. Just forget what I've said and follow your master's teachings.
鹭鸶剪：……没什么，你们继续跟着任仙子修炼吧。

Paper Heron: Perhaps she's found a better way.
鹭鸶剪：也许……也许她找到了更好的，更贴近天道的法门呢……

Master Ren: The third step the grandmaster spoke of is what we call the "cultivation of the body." Through practice, your body will work with your Qi until they are one.
任仙子：……关于师祖提到的第三步，便是“易筋”，即让肉身与体内的“气”慢慢融汇，最终浑然一体。

Master Ren: Mastering this may take decades, even hundreds of years, but here in the School of Mei, we needn't dwell on that step. Instead, we focus on the regulation of Qi, and concentration and visualization.
任仙子：“易筋”原需数十年，甚至为期百年的修炼，但梅花教的“长生之法”无需特意练习“易筋”，而更注重于“调气”和“存元”……

Paper Heron: ...
鹭鸶剪：……

She looks over to Master Rén as she continues her lesson and resolves herself to what must be done.
鹭鸶剪若有所思地望着正在讲解的任仙子，表情逐渐凝重起来。

Paper Heron: "We needn't dwell on that step"?
鹭鸶剪：“无需特意练习易筋”?

直如弦
Unbending Will SU-13

Constable II: Move! Constables on duty. Make way!
巡捕 II：让道让道！执行公务！

The sun sets in the west. Meanwhile, constables armed with bows and blades march through the streets.
日已西斜，巡捕们却握弓佩刀，气势汹汹地穿越街道。

Like a long, cobalt dragon, they pass by as people watch curiously and whisper to each other, wondering at their destination.
百姓们好奇地望着这一条藏青色的长龙，相视过后寒暄几句，也不知巡捕们是要去向何方。

Two constables hurry to reach the young man leading the grim-faced parade.
长龙之首处，两名巡捕紧赶慢赶地追着带头的青年。

Yang Wu: Chief, there's no trace of that reed girl anywhere. She's disappeared.
杨武：程巡检，那苇草精就像钻进了石头缝里，根本找不着一点踪迹。

Cheng Heguang: I see. Stay sharp and keep an eye out for her. We can't allow any more Yao to escape.
程和光：我知道了。先抓别的，私下留心着她。

Du Liu: News from the west gate: two more Yao have been captured. Do you want to question them yourself like last time?
杜六：西门的巡捕又抓住了两个，过来问巡检是否要去看看。

Cheng Heguang: I'll be there shortly.
程和光：知道了，过会儿就去。

Yang Wu: We've been walking for a while now. Where are you leading us?
杨武：对了，程巡检，我们这是要去——

Yáng Wǔ still wants to speak, but their chief raises his right hand, signaling the marching constables behind to stop.
杨武还欲说些什么，程和光却已经举起右手，示意后面跟随的巡捕停下脚步。

Cheng Heguang: This is it!
程和光：到了！

The house before them lies at the street's end. Its doors are tightly shut, but chanting voices escape out through the cracks.
面前的府邸位于街道尽处，门扉紧闭，难以窥探。然而，若有若无的唱诵声固执地从砖缝里飘出。

???: Withered grass devours bone. On icy plain the spirits moan. When the city falls, the Immortal descends. Longevity granted, no death, no end.
???：黑绒吞白骨，寒原鬼泣呜……城覆仙人现，长生免祸殃……

???: All returns to origin. Longevity draws near. Stars will shift only when the true path appears. Depart from this strange world, and find peace in the immortal realm.
???：一气归元，长生可望。命本可改，道只传人！莫待他朝，永驻仙乡！

Cheng Heguang: Hmph. The source was right. Yao are gathering here.
程和光：哼，果然和线报一样，有精怪聚众修炼！

Chéng Héguāng clenches his fist toward the door, then lifts it in a sharp upward motion.
程和光对着门扉握拳，而后猛地抬起。

The metal bolt falls with a clang.
化为金属的门闩应声而落。

Cheng Heguang: Move in!
程和光：走！

He draws his blade and throws the door open. The constables pour into the small square courtyard, ringing their Reversion Bells.
程和光抽刀撞开府门，众巡捕紧跟着涌入这四四方方的小庭院内，不停晃动手中的振气铃。

Cheng Heguang: Patrol constables! Civilians, stay back!
程和光：巡检司抓贼！闲杂人等退避！

Prominent Local Merchant I: By whose order are you here? Who gave you the right?
富商巨贾 I：你们是谁?!

Cheng Heguang: Hmph, quite the posture for a wanted suspect.
程和光：区区小妖，装模作样。

Cheng Heguang: You're all under arrest. Seize them!
程和光：巡检司办案，统统拿下！

Prominent Local Merchant II: This is outrageous! You jumped-up toll collector! How dare you lay your hands on us!
富商巨贾 II：大胆！小小巡检司，知不知道我们都是谁——

Prominent Local Merchant II: Urgh! What on earth is that noise?
富商巨贾 II：吵死了！

Prominent Local Merchant I: That's enough! I said enough! Stop!
富商巨贾 I：别摇了！别摇了！

The bells ring under the eaves. Those inside cover their ears, but no tails grow, and no bark forms to cover their skin.
振气铃响彻屋檐。人们捂住耳朵，但却没有长出尾巴，或是化为树皮。

Cheng Heguang: They're not Yao?
程和光：……不是妖怪?

The young chief constable is struck still, grappling with the unexpected outcome. These people dressed in fine silks are wealthy merchants, not Yao cultists.
程和光诧异地站定，这些人穿着华贵的绫罗绸缎，更像是达官贵人，而非预想中的精怪流民。

From outside, older, wiser constables peek in, while the newer, oblivious recruits continue to ring their bells as ordered.
门外，稍有资历的巡捕们正小心翼翼地窥视着。只有些刚来报到的新人还拼命地摇着振气铃。

Cheng Heguang: Stop the bells!
程和光：都先停下！

The constables stop, and Chéng Héguāng looks over the crowd before sheathing his blade.
巡捕们停下摇铃，程和光将人群左右扫视一遍，而后将刀收入鞘内。

Cheng Heguang: I am Chief Constable Chéng, acting under orders to investigate the Yao involved in the Stilted Parade. I have been instructed to bring them to justice without delay.
程和光：我奉命调查扰乱“高跷巡神”的教门精怪，相关之人一律严拿究办。

Cheng Heguang: The verses you were reciting are identical to those the Yao chanted at the parade. If I am mistaken, I humbly ask for your forgiveness in advance.
程和光：你们刚刚所唱的，正是精怪教门在“高跷巡神”前后宣扬的长生妖法。如有得罪，还请莫怪。

Prominent Local Merchant II: Can you believe this petulant boy? He thought we were Yao gathering for some evil ritual!
富商巨贾 II：你的意思是，我们是修炼妖术的妖怪?

Prominent Local Merchant II: Watch yourself, "Chief Constable." Slandering a respected merchant like myself could get you in serious trouble!
富商巨贾 II：岂有此理，你可知道这叫诬告！

Cheng Heguang: All are equal before the law. I only act in accordance with it. I ask your presence at the Yamen, so please, gentlemen, come with us.
程和光：律法面前不分贵贱，我也是依律行事，还请各位大人理解，和我回衙门一趟，将事情解释清楚。

Cheng Heguang: Should you be proven innocent, I will offer my deepest apologies.
程和光：若各位大人念诵的并非教门经文，下官自会赔礼道歉。

Prominent Local Merchant III: Do you know who you're speaking to, boy?
富商巨贾 III：好大的口气，你可知我们是谁？

Prominent Local Merchant III: I won't leave this house unless your superior comes and explains everything in person!
富商巨贾 III：把你的上司叫出来，我倒要听听他下的是什么令——

Cheng Heguang: I ...
程和光：这——

The air feels heavy as lead. The constables look at each other, no one daring to speak.
气氛如千钧沉重，巡捕们面面相觑，谁都不敢开这个口。

For a moment, the standstill feels as if it might go on forever, until the tension is at last cut by a voice from outside.
若不是门外传来那道声音，这场对峙还不知何时才能收场。

Li Huifeng: Gentlemen, I'm afraid there's been a misunderstanding.
厉晦锋：——这是个误会。

Cheng Heguang: Sir?
程和光：……守备？

The constables part respectfully as Lì Huìfēng marches into the courtyard, followed by a plump middle-aged man in brocade.
巡捕们让出道路。厉晦锋疾步走入院内，身后还跟着一位身穿锦缎的发福中年男子。

Li Huifeng: Those honorable gentlemen are simply studying the classics and cultivating their minds.
厉晦锋：各位大人只是来此唱诵经典，修身养性。

Li Huifeng: It has nothing to do with the turmoil on the streets, nor with the Yao's evil deeds.
厉晦锋：与“高跷巡神”的风波绝无相关，妖怪妖法更是无稽之谈。

Prominent Local Merchant IV: You speak the truth, Commander. These classics the gentlemen were reciting are scriptures transcribed by His Eminence Zhāng himself! They serve only to enlighten the mind.
富商巨贾 IV：厉守备所言极是！这是张真人手抄的三卷经典，念诵可使人神智通明，绝非什么长生妖法。

Prominent Local Merchant IV: But no doubt our young Chief Constable here only intended to perform his duties and perhaps leaped to judgment. Is that so, Commander?
富商巨贾 IV：定是这位巡检急于捉妖，被奸诈精怪哄骗，这才不慎冲撞了各位大人，是吧，厉守备？

Li Huifeng: I thank you for your understanding and your timely message, else this could have been an even greater humiliation. Héguāng, apologize to the honorable gentlemen.
厉晦锋：幸好您派人来及时相告，场面才没有弄得更加难堪，我之后一定会严厉斥责他。和光，给各位大人说声不是。

Chéng Héguāng remains silent and stares at the scripture scroll in the man's hand.
程和光却未接话，只是定定看着那男子手中的经文书卷。

Li Huifeng: Chéng Héguāng! Do you not hear me?
厉晦锋：——程和光！你还不知错?

Cheng Heguang: I acted thoughtlessly. For that I am sorry, Your Excellencies.
程和光：……是卑职鲁莽了，请各位大人海涵。

Li Huifeng: Do you think that an acceptable apology? When we return to the Yamen, you'll suffer sixty strokes for your insolence!
厉晦锋：你这是什么态度？回衙门领六十大板！

Prominent Local Merchant IV: Please, no need to be so harsh, Commander. I'm certain the chief acted with the best intentions. Young men often rush to judgment. We've all done the same.
富商巨贾 IV：唉，厉守备，这是何必？程巡检想必也只是急于捉妖。年轻人嘛，血气方刚，莽撞些也正常——

Speaking back and forth, Lì Huìfēng and the middle-aged merchant ease the tension at last.
厉晦锋和这中年男人一唱一和，气氛已然缓和了不少。

A look passes among those in the courtyard. The obvious leader among them speaks.
院内的几人交换了一个眼神，地位最高的那个终于松口了。

Prominent Local Merchant I: No real harm has been done to us; do not punish him for doing his duty.
富商巨贾 I：念在没出什么事，这次我们就不计较了。

Prominent Local Merchant II: Just be sure to keep your officers in line, Lì!
富商巨贾 II：厉晦锋，管好你的手下！

Li Huifeng: Of course. Your generosity is greatly appreciated, gentlemen. We shall take our leave.
厉晦锋：是是，我们这便离开。

Lì Huìfēng says no more and signals for the constables to leave the courtyard.
厉晦锋并未多说什么，只是领着众人离开了庭院。

A wounded cobalt dragon retreats back to its cave in the form of a slow and dreary procession of downcast faces.
巡捕们耷拉着脸回到县衙，如同烂布沿街拖了十里。

Lì Huìfēng stands ahead, unconcerned with the sour faces of the lower ranks behind him.
不断有人用埋怨的眼神看向程和光。尤以跟得最近的杜六和杨武为最。

Cheng Heguang: ...
程和光：……

With their commander present, the constables dare not even speak as they pass through the doors of the Yamen and file away to the mess hall.
碍于厉晦锋在场，巡捕们也不敢多话，只是作鸟兽状散向饭堂。

Only Chéng Héguāng remains by the entrance, struggling to hold his head high. The result is something stiff and strange but proud.
唯有程和光还直挺挺地站在原处。

Li Huifeng: Why are you standing there like a statue? It's time to eat.
厉晦锋：不去吃饭，是有话要说?

Cheng Heguang: I'm awaiting my sixty strokes.
程和光：属下在等自己的六十大板。

Lì Huìfēng puts down the case file and looks at him with a complex expression.
厉晦锋放下了手中的案卷，眼神复杂地看了一眼程和光。

Li Huifeng: *sigh* There won't be any coming. Now, go eat.
厉晦锋：并没有这六十大板。你回去吧。

But he still does not move.
程和光依然分毫未动。

Cheng Heguang: If you've elected to spare me, then allow me a question, Commander.
程和光：既然没有这六十大板，那属下还想问一事。

Cheng Heguang: The man who came with you had a scroll in his hand. Where did it come from? There's a Bagua array on it, formed by a Mei tree and a jade sword.
程和光：和守备一起进来的男子，他手中的经文典籍从何而来，为何上面有梅树和玉剑的八卦阵图案?

Li Huifeng: Héguāng, if I spare you the punishment, you ought to at least do me the courtesy of sparing me the questions.
厉晦锋：既然没有这六十大板，这便不是你该过问的。

Cheng Heguang: Then I would rather take the punishment.
程和光：那属下便站在这里等着领六十大板。

The evening wind blows through the hall, and the candlelight flickers in response.
晚风吹过冷清的衙门大堂，让案前的烛光闪烁了几分。

Li Huifeng: Do you really have no inkling of who you offended tonight?
厉晦锋：你知道你今晚得罪的是谁吗?

Cheng Heguang: I do not.
程和光：属下不知。

Li Huifeng: The Chén family, respected gentry with three Imperial Scholars in only a few decades. Lord Lù, a corps leader, his family have served in the military for generations. And the Lǐs—I needn't remind you who they are.
厉晦锋：陈氏，本地乡绅，一代出了三个进士；陆总兵，更是在此地世袭武职；李家更不必说，你于祝县生长，也该听过他们的名号。

Cheng Heguang: I am but the son of bandits. I don't know any of these high lords.
程和光：属下本是兵贼出身，门楣低微，自然不知。

Li Huifeng: Now you know.
厉晦锋：那你现在该知了。

Lì Huìfēng looks away and reads from the case file.
厉晦锋不再看向程和光，只是翻阅手中的案卷。

Cheng Heguang: The man with the scroll—is he of noble birth, too?
程和光：那手持经文的男子，也是其中一门显贵?

He does not receive an answer.
厉晦锋不答。

Cheng Heguang: Am I right to assume that you've kept me from investigating the School of Mei, not because you feared I might alarm them, but because you are aware of the school's prestigious background?
程和光：你不让我查梅花教，并非惧怕打草惊蛇，而是因为你早就知道?

The words are pointed but do not break his commander's grim silence.
厉晦锋仍是不答。

Cheng Heguang: You know they're responsible for the turmoil in the county, yet you permit these men to walk free, allowing the common Yao to take the fall—
程和光：你早就知道，城中混乱根结在梅花教，但他们有权贵撑腰，所以只是抓些流散精怪，做些表面功夫——

Li Huifeng: Enough!
厉晦锋：闹够了没有——?!

Lì Huìfēng rises with an expression as fiery as a lit rocket as he throws the files to the ground.
厉晦锋猛然站起，将手中的案卷摔到地上。

Li Huifeng: Are you so naive? Do you truly have no clue as to why you were spared today?
厉晦锋：你知道今天还能站在这里，靠的是谁吗?!

Cheng Heguang: Because of your connection to the man with the scroll.
程和光：……靠的是守备和那持经文男子的关系。

Li Huifeng: Then you do have some inkling of what's going on!
厉晦锋：你也知道！

Li Huifeng: You did well capturing those Yao, and I had planned to speak highly of you before Lord Lù. But after your actions today—storming into a civilian's home, attempting to arrest all present—how can I possibly recommend you!?
厉晦锋：你这几日捉妖有功，我本打算事后向陆总兵推荐你——可你今天却跑去抓他的亲戚。这让我怎么开口?!

Li Huifeng: Have you forsaken your vow and decided to live in your father's disgrace forever?
厉晦锋：还是说，你已经忘了你曾经发的誓，甘愿永远带着你父亲留下的污点?!

Cheng Heguang: I would never!
程和光：……属下不曾忘却！

He grits his teeth but does not give an inch.
程和光咬了咬牙，但并未退让。

Cheng Heguang: But Commander, this is more important than my name. This is for the safety of the townspeople!
程和光：可是守备，我追查梅花教，并不仅是为了立功升级。只是想避免酿成大祸！

Li Huifeng: Alright. Then tell me exactly what harm the School of Mei has done and what crime you accuse them of.
厉晦锋：好！不愧是祝县的好巡检。那我想问问，梅花教造成了什么危害，触犯了哪条刑律?

Cheng Heguang: As my prior report states, they are practicing sorcery and other forbidden arts.
程和光：正如我之前汇报，诸多煽动蛊惑之举该坐师巫邪术一条——

Li Huifeng: They fabricated the descent of a deity at the parade, yes. But have you caught any of the offenders from that day?
厉晦锋：那游行的确假降邪神，扶鸾祷圣，可抓着了游行的人，可有画押口供?

Cheng Heguang: Not yet.
程和光：……此无实证。

Li Huifeng: And has any member of the school actually committed a crime? Or have you found some scripture that proves their evil intention?
厉晦锋：那可抓到了梅花教的人，或收缴了什么妖书?

Cheng Heguang: ...
程和光：……

Cheng Heguang: I have not.
程和光：亦无实证。

Li Huifeng: So you have nothing. You wish me to convince the magistrate to act against the School of Mei, risking the anger of officials and high lords based on nothing? Hm?
厉晦锋：这也无实证，那也无实证，你要如何说服我——说服知县老爷为了你得罪那些府衙官员?

Li Huifeng: The school will claim that they were only teaching the methods to strengthen the body and enrich the mind, and that the Yao were foolish and greedy to think their practices could grant longevity.
厉晦锋：他们会说，梅花教不过是个民间修身养性的教派，游行只是幻术。妖怪愚笨，才信了什么长生。

Li Huifeng: We cannot act on hearsay and rumors, especially when it may anger the high lords!
厉晦锋：而为了一个谣言冲撞上级，只会显得我们捉妖不力，推卸责任。

Cheng Heguang: You're right. I lack the evidence to refute your words.
程和光：我暂时没有物证，反驳不了守备的话。

Cheng Heguang: But if it is the lords that worry you, I will investigate in secret. Three days is all I need. I will find the proof.
程和光：但我可以避开官员，先盯梢别院。三日内，定能抓出切实线索!

Li Huifeng: Enough.
厉晦锋：不必了。

Another cold blast of wind sweeps through the hall, rustling the papers on his desk.
一阵风吹入堂内，将桌案上的纸张带得簌簌作响。

Lì Huìfēng uses a paperweight to smooth the files and sits back into his chair.
厉晦锋拿镇纸将案卷压平，坐回木椅。

Li Huifeng: Go now. Get some rest.
厉晦锋：回去休息吧。

Li Huifeng: Your men are to be placed under the captain, Zhāng; he knows the county well. You will remain, but only as his backup.
厉晦锋：你手下的人我会调给张捕头，他对城里更熟悉。以后，你就负责支援吧。

Cheng Heguang: Why? I've done nothing wrong!
程和光：——为什么?!

Li Huifeng: *sigh* Then you've not listened to a word I've said.
厉晦锋：——你还是不知道。

The water in the pot boils, the lid rattles, the steam whistles, and Lì Huìfēng pays it no attention.
炉里的水烧开了，咕噜噜地喷着盖子。厉晦锋并不理会。

Steam fills Chéng Héguāng's sight.
热气逐渐填满程和光的视野，在眼前晃动不止。

The pot at last boils over.
水就要溢出来了。

Cheng Heguang: Commander!
程和光：守备!

Cheng Heguang: Must the people's blood be spilled before we act?
程和光：难道一定要等梅花教害死了人才重视吗!

Li Huifeng: Watch your tongue!
厉晦锋：注意你说话的分寸!

In the tea bowl on the desk, weak ripples form.
案上的茶碗里，激起了一丝微弱的涟漪。

Cheng Heguang: ...
程和光：……

The young man stands solid, silent for a long time, rooted like a tree as the steam fades from him.
年轻人在堂前久久立着，直到热气和呵斥一并散去。

At last, he breaks the roots and turns.
良久，他才终于挪动生根的脚步。

Cheng Heguang: Perhaps I have not listened, Commander.
程和光：……守备的意思我明白了。

Cheng Heguang: Goodnight.
程和光：告辞。

Cheng's House, Ancient Zhu County
古祝县·程宅

The cool moon shines like a lantern over a dark lake.
深夜时分，凉月如水。

Chéng Héguāng puts down a book and rubs his tired neck.
程和光放下手中的书卷，疲惫地揉了揉脖颈。

Cheng Heguang: *sigh* It's getting late.
程和光：已不早了。

He lights a blackened torch with a candle, holding the light as he steps into the dark.
他借烛火引燃了斜搭在桌腿上焦黑的火把，举着这点光明步入了夜色中。

Cheng Heguang: Zhòngní said, "One of virtue follows the course of the Mean; one of cunning turns from it."
程和光：仲尼曰：“君子中庸，小人反中庸。”

Cheng Heguang: "Following the Mean, the virtuous acts in due measure. Turning from the Mean, the cunning moves without restraint."
程和光：“君子之中庸也，君子而时中。小人之反中庸也，小人而无忌惮也。”

He stops at the door, deep in thought.
程和光站在门口处思索着什么。

Cheng Heguang: Fortunately, it's still not too late.
程和光：不早了，但也不算晚。

A street cat cries out nearby.
不远处忽然传来野猫的叫声。

Cheng Heguang: Hm? That's ...
程和光：嗯……？那是……

Night Watch: Fire! Fire!
更夫：走水啦！！走水啦！！！

A man runs in panic. Behind him, plumes of smoke leap and billow into the sky.
一名县民慌张地奔走着，他身后是熊熊火光。

Night Watch: There's a fire at Chief Constable Chéng's house!
更夫：是程巡检家——！程巡检家走水啦！！

未烧尾
A Sow's Ear SU-14

Side Room, School of Mei
古祝县·梅花教厢房

Inside the room, a few Yao gather around Mayfly, helping her trim the fresh herbs she picked from the mountains.
厢房内，几名小精怪正围着惠姑摘刚从山上采下来的药材。

Yam: Now that you know the path, you can go up the hill at your leisure and gather the elixir ingredients yourself. A little walk in the forest will do you good.
山药精：惠姑，你记住上山的路没？以后有空的时候你就上山采采药，还能锻炼身体呢。

Mayfly: Thank you. I know the elixir helps with the practice, but isn't it a little unsettling, harvesting these herbs like this?
惠姑：我懂得修炼“长生之法”搭配药石进度会更快些，只是……看着这些草药，你不会觉得瘆得慌吗？

Yam: What's the matter? They're only plants, too young to form any spirit yet. It's not as if you're cutting down one of your own.
山药精：这有什么，它们还未成精，也不算作我们的同类，惠姑你大可放心。

Paper Heron: Mayfly! Oh, uh, I mean Sister Mayfly, I thought that I should come check on you. See how you're getting on.
鹭鸶剪：惠姑……！咳咳，我来看看你现在如何了？

Mayfly: Look at that. Someone finally discovered the door. Though not much of a knocker, are you?
惠姑：哎哟，窗户封了，我才知道你还是个不敲门的主。

Yam: Good day, Grandmaster.
山药精：师祖。

Paper Heron nods to the Yao, then walks around Mayfly, looking left and right.
鹭鸶剪朝小妖点了点头，随后便围着惠姑转了一圈，左看右看。

Mayfly: What? What is it? You're giving me the withers.
惠姑：有话你就说，别这样，看得我心里毛毛的……

Paper Heron: You've followed Rén's teachings for a few days now, hm? How do you feel?
鹭鸶剪：……你按照任仙子的法子练了也有几日了，身体怎么样？没出什么事吧？

Mayfly: Heron, you've asked me this a few times already.
惠姑：鹭鸶剪，你都问了我好几日，好几遍啦。

Mayfly: I'm well, just as I was yesterday and the day before that. My strength's improving. I feel light and full of energy, even after a long day in the mountains.
惠姑：不仅昨日无事，今日也无事！最近更是觉得神清气爽，上山下河的，连身体都轻松了许多。

Paper Heron puts her hands behind her back and circles Mayfly two more times, nodding each time.
鹭鸶剪背着手，又围着惠姑转了两圈，随后轻轻点了点头。

Paper Heron: That's good. That's good then. Are you certain everything's fine? Nothing feels strange at all?
鹭鸶剪：这种效果倒是好的……你确定近日身子没有任何异样？

Mayfly: Absolutely!
惠姑：当然！

Mayfly pats her chest as if to prove her health.
惠姑仿若做保证般拍了拍胸脯，向鹭鸶剪展示自己的身体无碍。

Mayfly: Why do you keep asking? Is something troubling you?
惠姑：怎么，你好像巴不得我出点什么岔子。

Paper Heron: Nothing makes me happier than seeing you well. But may I ask have you felt anything out of place while practicing Rén's methods?
鹭鸶剪：无事自然是最好，只是……我问你，任仙子的功法，你练着觉得有奇怪之处吗?

Mayfly: Out of place? I don't know. But I've moved on to the second stage, "concentration and visualization."
惠姑：奇怪？哪里奇怪？你看，我已经学到第二阶段了，“存元”。

She sits in a meditation pose and makes a hand gesture to cast an incantation.
惠姑摆了个打坐的样子，手掐了个诀。

Mayfly: Master Rén said that to meditate, I must sit in silence, concentrating my mind on an object and visualizing the inner deities until I find their presence. With consistent practice, the path to longevity will reveal itself.
惠姑：任仙子讲，“存元”便是在高度入静之时，将意念集中于神内或身外的神灵，念念不忘，以至长生不死。

Mayfly: That Mei tree nearby really is an ideal object to focus on. It seems to have been there for over a thousand years. Maybe it really does have a connection to the spiritual world.
惠姑：而祝县那棵梅花树乃千年神树，冥冥有灵，是十分不错的寄情对象。

Paper Heron: Are those her words?
鹭鸶剪：任仙子是这么教你们的?

Mayfly: Her exact words! I meditate about that tree day and night. I even see it in my dreams sometimes.
惠姑：对啊，我现在是日思夜想，有时做梦还能梦到那棵梅花树呢。

Mayfly: And Master Rén has been most generous. She even helps the other students using the power of her sword. How did she explain it?
惠姑：仙子真是好人，我听小妖们说，仙子还会用长生剑帮它们修炼，说是……

Mayfly: Something like using the sword to clear the blockage in their body, freeing the flow of Qi, so they can advance more quickly with their training.
惠姑：嗯——说是会用长生剑帮它们疏通“气穴”，这样能修炼得更快一些。

Mayfly: The first time I saw it, I almost thought she was about to poke a few holes in me. But instead, she just swiped it above my head, just like you did at the parade.
惠姑：当初我可吓死了，以为要用剑在身上捅几个窟窿，但实际上，仙子只是在我头顶轻轻一扫……就像当初你给我“授长生”时那样。

Mayfly: I even asked Brother Yam to teach me something from the third stage. You should see how well I can do it already.
惠姑：而且啊……我还让山药精偷偷教我第三阶段的功法，我学得可好了！

Mayfly: Posture one, "Breeze in the Lungs." Face north, feet spread as wide as the shoulders.
惠姑：第一式，拂肺式……面北而立，两足分开同肩宽……

She chants the words and shows Paper Heron what she has learned.
惠姑一边念诀，一边在鹭鸶剪面前展示起她新学的长生之法。

Mayfly: Master Rén told us that we must cultivate our bodies to align with the movement of Qi. Only then can our mortal flesh be prepared for longevity.
惠姑：任仙子讲，我们需得在这个阶段磨炼筋骨，使肉体适应“气”的变化，才能“脱胎换骨”，达到真正的长生。

Mayfly: She said the cultivation would take about two months.
惠姑：第三阶段啊，练它两个月就差不多了。

Paper Heron: Two months? Those were her words?
鹭鸶剪：两个月……这也是任仙子说的?

Mayfly: That's right.
惠姑：对啊。

Hearing Mayfly's words, Paper Heron's face changes. A hint of sternness cuts across her brow.
听完惠姑所说，鹭鸶剪脸色似有动容，一股难以察觉的严肃之色凝聚在她的眉间，仿佛若有所思。

Butterfly: *panting*
小蝶虫：呵……呵……

Butterfly bursts in, panting and waving his hands.
小蝶虫气喘吁吁地跑进屋内，手舞足蹈地，像是有什么话急着跟大家说。

Butterfly: Wonderful news! Karma finally came for that heartless Chief Constable Chéng!
小蝶虫：太好啦！那个姓程的巡检遭报应啦！！！

Paper Heron: Chéng?
鹭鸶剪：姓程的巡检……?

Hearing this, the other Yao gather around.
闻言，其他的精怪也都凑了过来。

Hedgehog: You mean that grumpy, self-righteous constable that's been hunting us night and day?
刺猬精：就是那个守在城门……天天试图抓我们的家伙?

Yam: I heard that he's been interrogating Yao, plucking his captive's hairs one by one.
山药精：我有亲戚落在他手里，听说他审讯的手段残酷至极，会把精怪的毛发一根一根地拔下来……

Butterfly: Yes, that's him. What a pig! No offense to pigs!
小蝶虫：呼……就是他，这家伙真是坏透了！

Butterfly: I guess brutality must run in his blood. His family used to be bandits until they worked their way into the military. Not that they lasted long as soldiers. His own father turned out to be a crook!
小蝶虫：听说他家本是盗匪，杀敌有功入了军籍，不料贼就是贼，过了三代，就原形毕露了！

Butterfly: He cut ties with his father to keep his post. But I don't believe it. If he's willing to throw us all behind bars just to make himself look good, then he's just as bad as the rest of them!
小蝶虫：他急着和他爹划清界限，立功晋升，就拿我们当垫脚石，无所不用其极。真不是什么好东西！

Yam: I'll bet he's rotten to the core. But what do you mean by "karma came for him"? Ah, tell us what happened.
山药精：真可恨呐……你说他遭到报应是怎么回事？快快细说！

Butterfly seizes the moment with excitement as he proceeds to describe the fire at the chief constable's home.
小蝶虫等的就是这句话。他眉飞色舞，将程和光家中走水一事说得绘声绘色。

Mayfly: Isn't that the man we met at the gate?
惠姑：鹭鸶剪，这个巡检是不是和我们打过交道的那个……

Paper Heron: I believe so.
鹭鸶剪：……嗯。

Her response is quick and muted, intending not to interrupt the clamor of the Yao.
鹭鸶剪未置一词，只是听着众妖喧哗。

Mayfly: I just don't understand why he hates us so much. We haven't hurt anyone. We just want to spread the Method of Longevity.
惠姑：不过……我们就只是想多活几天而已，也没做什么坏事，他们为什么一定要这么为难我们呢……

Hedgehog: Hardly a surprise. Those with long lives seldom care for the short-lived.
刺猬精：倒也不稀罕……本来就活得长的人怎么舍得让我们学长生之法呢……

The words bring a harsh chill to the air as the other Yao look at each other and then to Paper Heron.
场面突然冷了下来，众妖你看看我，我看看你。

Yam: Hedgehog! The grandmaster is still here.
山药精：你说什么呢，师祖还在这里呢……

Paper Heron: Please, speak your mind. It is every creature's right.
鹭鸶剪：无妨，你们爱说什么就说什么。

Her words do little to break the sudden chill until Butterfly steers things back on topic.
场面一时冷寂，直到小蝶虫忽地想起了什么，崇拜般地开口。

Butterfly: Oh! I nearly forgot that awful chief had nearly locked up our grandmaster!
小蝶虫：——对了，这姓程的还冲撞过师祖！

Butterfly: Grandmaster, did you start the fire to avenge us?
小蝶虫：师祖，该不会是您偷偷出手的吧?

Paper Heron: Haha. No, I didn't. Though if anyone questions you on the matter, you may give them my name.
鹭鸶剪：哈哈……那倒不是，但若有必要，也可以说是我做的。

Butterfly: Grandmaster ...
小蝶虫：师祖……

Hearing this, all the Yao look at Paper Heron with awe.
众妖听闻，都纷纷崇拜地望向鹭鸶剪。

Butterfly: It is a great honor to study under an avenging hero like you.
小蝶虫：有师祖这般的真仙人给我们撑腰，能加入梅花教，真是三生有幸啊！

Butterfly: Please accept our humblest gratitude.
小蝶虫：师祖受小的一拜！！！

Yam: Thank you. Thank you for your heroic deeds.
山药精：师祖受小的一拜！！！

Paper Heron: Aha ...
鹭鸶剪：这……

Their undeserved praise lands somewhere between funny and vexing, yet she can't help but realize the situation is growing beyond her control.
鹭鸶剪哭笑不得，但场面早已不受控制。

Yam: The grandmaster has taken our interests to heart, and we must repay her with our greatest effort. We must achieve longevity and spread the school's name.
山药精：师祖如此关爱弟子！咱们更得勤加修炼，早日修得长生，将教门发扬光大！

All Yao: Achieve longevity! Spread the school's name!
众妖：早日修得长生！将教门发扬光大！

The room has become a hubbub of cheers and excitement. But Mayfly does not seem to be participating. She stares up blankly, spots dancing in her vision like fireflies at dusk.
众妖在厢房内喧哗，惠姑一时之间觉得头晕脑胀，眼前似有无数小黑虫在翻飞。

Mayfly: Huh, I ... What's going on?
惠姑：呃，等等……我，怎么……

Yam: Mayfly? Are you alright?
山药精：惠姑？你怎么了？

In a moment, Mayfly feels the world spin beneath her feet.
须臾之间，惠姑突然感到天旋地转。

Paper Heron: ...!
鹭鸶剪：……！

As she tumbles, she sees Paper Heron glide toward her. Then all goes dark.
在天旋地转的世界里，惠姑看到鹭鸶剪的身影正朝自己倾斜而来，随后便是一片黑暗。

Yamen, Ancient Zhu County
古祝县·县衙

The next day's sun rises as usual, but the Yamen's constables have a new topic to discuss.
第二日的太阳照常升起，衙门的巡捕们却有了新谈资。

Constable I: Did you hear? Those gentlemen we met yesterday have all fallen ill.
巡捕 I：喂，听说了没。昨天咱们放走的那些大官，今天好像都发病了？

Constable I: It seems they've all been taken by a strange fever. Some fainted in an instant, while others went running and yelling on the streets in their undergarments. It was chaos.
巡捕 I：听说他们突发热疾，有的忽然在家中昏倒，还有的穿里衣跑到大街上乱叫，引来不少人。

Constable I: The chief was right. Whatever they were doing must have been dangerous.
巡捕 I：看来程巡检还是没抓错人，那长生功法还是练不得。

Constable II: But I heard they hired a Daoist who cured them with nothing but water and a pinch of talisman ashes.
巡捕 II：但我听说他们请了个方士，喝喝符水就好了。

Constable I: Hmph. Well, that was easy. Shame the chief wasn't so lucky. To think a man could lose his home simply for doing his duty!
巡捕 I：呔，他们倒是好得轻松，巡检的房子都被那些贼人烧光了！

Constable II: Well, we don't know what caused the fire, do we?
巡捕 II：现在还不清楚失火原委吧？

Constable I: What else could it be? You were there. I think the chief found something important, and now they're desperate to get rid of him.
巡捕 I：除了那些妖贼还能有谁？巡检那天的行为你也看到了。说不准就是查到了点儿什么，才会被杀人灭口。

Constable II: I'm just glad I was on guard duty.
巡捕 II：好险好险，幸好我昨天没有跟着冲进去……

A shadow passes before the two men. They're struck silent with fear. But Chéng Héguāng does not even seem to notice them as he walks straight into the Yamen hall.
一个影子挡在了二人面前，二人瞬间噤了声，但程和光没有停留，而是径直走入衙门大堂。

From his high seat, Lì Huìfēng looks at a plaque on the wall.
高堂之上，厉晦锋正望着衙上挂着的牌匾。

Li Huifeng: Héguāng, I understand it was your house that caught fire last night.
厉晦锋：和光，你家昨夜走水了？

Cheng Heguang: It was.
程和光：是。

Li Huifeng: It's a great relief to see you unharmed.
厉晦锋：人没事就好。

Li Huifeng: But I'm sorry for your loss. Take a few days. Find another place to stay and get some rest, will you?
厉晦锋：出了这么大的事，我准你几日假，你回家收拾收拾，也歇息一下。

Cheng Heguang: Much appreciated, Commander. That is precisely why I came.
程和光：我正要和守备禀报此事。

Chéng Héguāng bows and then pours out his prepared words. It's clear immediately that he's had little rest.
程和光作了一揖，随后便像连珠炮一样倒出了陈辞。

Cheng Heguang: I was up late reviewing some case files. As it happened, the arsonists startled a cat as they approached. I was able to spy them from my window. Though I couldn't stop them in time.
程和光：当时我正在家中读案卷，被野猫叫声惊扰，及时注意到贼人身影，方才幸免于难。只是我寡不敌众，只能眼睁睁看着房屋被烧毁。

Cheng Heguang: They were all Yao. I'm quite certain of it, as retaliation for the arrests I've made.
程和光：它们皆为精怪所化，所作所为，无非是为打击报复。

Cheng Heguang: Commander Lì, if I, a trained officer, couldn't protect my home from their schemes, what hope do the ordinary townspeople have?
程和光：我尚有能力自保，但县民呢？梅花教今日敢在城内纵火，刺杀官员。明日便敢在城内抢夺财物，攻击百姓。

Cheng Heguang: Please, permit me to bring them to justice and anyone else who shields them!
程和光：我必须彻查此案，把他们绳之以法！谁庇护他们谁就是同党！

Li Huifeng: You—
厉晦锋：你——

Cheng Heguang: I know the Yamen is short-staffed. I won't ask for anyone's help until I have solid evidence.
程和光：请守备放心，我理解县里到处都需要人手。没有明确线索之前我会自己查，不会调动部署。

Cheng Heguang: Now, I must take my leave. Good day, Commander!
程和光：属下告辞！

He does not wait for Lì Huìfēng to say more and turns to leave.
未等到厉晦锋再开口，程和光已经转身离去。

High above them, the Yamen's bell is stirred by the wind, ringing out a long, clear note.
脊兽下的檐铃被寒风催动，晃出一声悠长的脆响。

公无渡河
Into the Fire SU-15

After breakfast, several Yao gather around Mayfly's bed.
早饭刚过，惠姑的床前便围着几名精怪。

Yam: Mayfly, you were out for the whole day!
山药精：惠姑，你睡了一天啦。

Hedgehog: Brother Yam told me you were unwell, so I brought some sweet cakes. I thought you might like something to eat after your fall.
刺猬精：惠姑，听阿山说你晕倒了，我带了些甜糕来看看你，等你醒了便能吃上了……

Mayfly: Hmm. Thank you.
惠姑：嗯……

Still half-asleep, Mayfly responds in a weak voice.
惠姑还不太清醒，有些疲惫地应着声。

Paper Heron: Mayfly, it's me again.
鹭鸶剪：惠姑，我又来了！

Paper Heron: I've brought herbs to replenish your Qi. Don't worry. I checked. All cut from plants. No Yao were harmed.
鹭鸶剪：我给你带了点补气的黄芪、党参……放心，都是未成精的草木，不是精怪。

Yam: Greetings, Grandmaster!
山药精：师祖好！

The Yao greet her enthusiastically. She nods to each of them in turn, then sets a bundle of herbs on the table.
看到鹭鸶剪，精怪们纷纷热切地向她问好。鹭鸶剪一一点头回礼，随后轻轻地将一堆药材放在桌上。

Paper Heron: Ah, no need for those formalities, please. Would you give Mayfly and me a moment in private?
鹭鸶剪：大家不必多礼，自在些便好……只是我有些话要和惠姑说，你们可以行个方便吗?

Yam: Of course. We'll leave you two alone.
山药精：那是自然！我们这就离开！

Yam: Don't you hear the grandmaster? Come on, let's go.
山药精：愣着干什么，师祖都发话了，快走啊！

The Yao nudge each other out of the room. Before long, only Paper Heron and Mayfly remain.
众精怪你推着我，我推着你。不出一会儿，厢房里便只剩下了鹭鸶剪和惠姑两人。

Mayfly: Paper Heron?
惠姑：鹭鸶剪……?

She senses something unusual about the moment and turns her head to find Paper Heron wearing a dour expression.
惠姑也意识到了今日的异样之处。她扭过头去，看见鹭鸶剪的表情是未曾见过的凝重。

Paper Heron: Mayfly, you must stop practicing Rén's method.
鹭鸶剪：惠姑。我来这里就是想告诉你，别再练任仙子的功法了。

Mayfly: Why?
惠姑：……为什么?

Paper Heron: Your Qi is too unstable. At times, it surges like a boar, and at others, it falters. Haven't you noticed?
鹭鸶剪：你没有感觉吗？除了会昏厥外，你时而会心火亢盛，气冲如奔豚，时而会头晕目眩，脚底如软泥。

Mayfly: I ...
惠姑：我……

Paper Heron: You know I'm right, don't you? Your fall before was a warning. Your Qi is in decline.
鹭鸶剪：都有，对吧？你之所以会晕倒，是因为你身上的“气”出现了亏空。

Mayfly: But I've felt so much more energetic lately. Even my mind feels clearer than before.
惠姑：可……我确实也觉得近日身体轻快了不少，就连头脑也清晰了许多……

Paper Heron: Yes. You have learned a great deal about how to control your Qi. You'd be in great shape, if that were all you were practicing.
鹭鸶剪：因为“调气”本就是休养生息之法，只是“调气”的话自然会强身健体。

Paper Heron: For you to advance further, your Qi must align with the Way, and your body must be strong enough to carry it.
鹭鸶剪：但“存元”需要你将体内的“气”与天道调和，若是你的身体不够强健，如何承载与天道相近的“气”？

Paper Heron: But if you're too weak, your Qi can become too great a burden. It could consume you.
鹭鸶剪：因此你“存元”越深，对身体的负担就会越大，长此以往，自会亏空。

Paper Heron: In the White Horse School, we always ensured our physique was strong enough to handle each step along the path.
鹭鸶剪：而我们白马派的功法，注重的是磨炼身体，以身载“气”，因此会在“易筋”这一步耗费很长时间。

Paper Heron: But Rén is moving too fast, pushing you forward with the power of the Longevity Sword. It's possible you may still succeed in the end, but ...
鹭鸶剪：任仙子跳过了这最难的一步，加上“长生剑”的加持，这才使得你们这些本来没时间练功的小妖怪也有可能练成长生之法。

Paper Heron: You're risking both body and spirit for a tiny possibility.
鹭鸶剪：……但这极其微弱的可能性，是以你的全部为代价，无论是你的肉身，还是你原本的“气”。

Paper Heron: You could end up with nothing. Your body destroyed, your spirit extinguished. You need to stop and allow your body to recover.
鹭鸶剪：再练下去，你怕是会直接形体坏灭……暂且别练了，先好生休养。

Mayfly: For how long? Days? Weeks? Months?
惠姑：休养……？养几日？三天？三周？三个月？

Paper Heron: Given your condition, I'd say two months before you resume any training.
鹭鸶剪：以你现在的身体状况……休养两个月再继续修炼为佳。

Mayfly: Two months?
惠姑：……两个月？

Mayfly: Do you realize how little time I have? Winter's coming. I can't wait that long.
惠姑：你知道我的寿命还剩多久吗？冬天就要到了，我等不了那么久。

Paper Heron: I know.
鹭鸶剪：……我知道。

Paper Heron: But if you continue in this fashion, I fear you may not live to see the winter.
鹭鸶剪：但你再修下去，恐怕连两个月都撑不到。

Paper Heron: I can't stand by and watch you destroy yourself. Not just you. All the Yao. This isn't the right path for any of you.
鹭鸶剪：我不能眼睁睁看着你落到这般地步，也不想看到其他小妖如此……这并非天道。

Mayfly: Heron ...
惠姑：鹭鸶剪……

Mayfly: I know, to you, two months may seem like nothing. I suppose it may seem like years pass you by in the blink of an eye, don't they?
惠姑：我想知道，两个月……不，一年在你心里，是不是眨眨眼就过去了？

Paper Heron: ...
鹭鸶剪：……

Paper Heron gazes at the girl propped halfway up in bed. Her lips tremble faintly before she finally speaks.
鹭鸶剪看着这个半倚在床上的姑娘，嘴唇微微翕动，半晌后才吐出一句话。

Paper Heron: It's not quite as fleeting as a blink of an eye.
鹭鸶剪：不是这样的，时间……它不慢，但也绝不是这样快的。

Mayfly: What would you do over the course of a year?
惠姑：……鹭鸶剪，假如给你一年时间，你会去做哪些事？

Paper Heron: I—
鹭鸶剪：我——

Mayfly: Wander the roads on your mule, through cloud-covered mountains, across gentle streams, beneath fragrant blooming peach trees.
惠姑：……像你这样的仙人，一定会慢悠悠地骑着你的骡子，去登那白云浮绕的山，踏进桃花飘落的小溪。

Mayfly: And when the year ends, you'd go to Huanzhou for the temple fair, feeling the warmth of the flames dancing against your face, savoring the floral sweetness of sticky rice cakes.
惠姑：到了年尾，你便来涣州庙会，感受吐火人表演时拂过脸上的灼热，尝尝甜滋滋的桂花糯米糕。

Mayfly: Next year you'll travel further still, to see snow-covered plains, brush the fur of a moose, taste wine so strong that it burns your throat.
惠姑：看完庙会，你还能计划来年去更新鲜、更远的地方，比如翻山越岭去看那长白雪，摸摸毛茸茸的驼鹿，品尝那温热辛辣的曲酒……

Mayfly: You never worry about the days you spend on the road or whether you have enough time to experience all the world has to offer.
惠姑：你不需要考虑路程远近，不需要担忧在这世间看不尽，玩不够……

The words hang bitterly on her lips, soon accompanied by wet tears flowing down her face.
最后一句语毕时，鹭鸶剪听见床上女孩压抑的一声哭腔。

Mayfly: But I won't live a full cycle of seasons.
惠姑：……而我，连一个完整的春夏秋冬都活不完啊……

One drop, two drops, three drops. The bedding covering her grows damp with a steady flow of tears.
一滴，两滴，三滴……惠姑身上的被褥被打湿，眼泪从女孩的脸庞不受控制地滴落。

Paper Heron can do nothing to stem their flow. So, she simply waits, watching her friend in tender silence.
在这寂静的哭泣中，鹭鸶剪默默地站着，望着，直至那抽泣声渐渐止息。

Mayfly: To you, a day, a month, a year, it means nothing.
惠姑：……所以，在你眼里，时间是最不重要的东西。

Mayfly: But for Yao like me, a year is a lifetime—our only lifetime.
惠姑：但我不是，我一生不过一稔。

Mayfly: I want to live, even just a little longer, to see more, feel more. I can't allow myself to waste even a moment.
惠姑：我只想活下去，比别人多活一点，多看一点，多闻一点……一刻都等不得！

Mayfly: In a thousand years, my name could still be carved on that stone. But I won't live to know if it's there next spring. So, why must you stop me?
惠姑：你随手在石头上的刻痕能残留一万年……而我只剩这两个月。你为什么要来阻止我呢?

Paper Heron: ...
鹭鸶剪：……

There are barbs on the question, too sharp to swallow, too true to ignore. She chews on it a long while, hoping to reach an answer.
鹭鸶剪沉默了，久久不再开口。

Paper Heron: I didn't intend to hurt your feelings when I carved that stone.
鹭鸶剪：给你在石头上刻字的时候，我并没有想那么多……

Paper Heron: Is it your wish then? To live as long as the stones?
鹭鸶剪：那么，你想和石头一样长久吗?

Mayfly: What? What do you mean?
惠姑：……像石头一样?

Paper Heron smiles, but a trace of sorrow lingers at the corners of her mouth.
鹭鸶剪笑着点了点头，那笑容中却有着一丝悲哀。

Paper Heron: Besides Inner Alchemy and Rén's method, there is a third way to escape the flow of time, one that has been kept a secret.
鹭鸶剪：还有一种长生之法，这是白马派的秘密，也是在金丹术和任仙子的法门外的第三种长生。

Paper Heron: It doesn't take hundreds of years of training, nor does it endanger your Qi. All it costs is your school, a sword, and a hundred years sealed in a tree.
鹭鸶剪：它不要求修炼者投入经年累月的时间，也不需要亏空先天俱来的气，只需失去一个门派，一把宝剑，在树中冰封近百年。

Paper Heron: When the seal breaks, all you once knew will be gone—friends and enemies alike. You will no longer laugh nor hate, and your senses will dull.
鹭鸶剪：时过境迁，故人与敌人都逝去了。而那求得长生的人孑然独活，食不知味，无悲无喜。

Paper Heron: Sweet or sour, salt or spice, it will all taste the same.
鹭鸶剪：虽然走遍了东坊西头，但再也吃不出桂花糯米糕和椒盐麻饼的区别。

Paper Heron: People will cheer at the blazing fire flowers, yet to you, the flames will be as mild as a passing breeze, their excitement like a language you no longer understand.
鹭鸶剪：明明那杂耍的火焰让众人欢呼，但却感受不到那火应有的热度，亦不知众人欢呼的原因。

Paper Heron: Your memories will stay. You'll always recall how the morning mist felt on your face, the crispness of spring water as it flowed through your fingers, but you will never feel them again.
鹭鸶剪：摸不到云雾的凉爽，亦触不到流水的清冽，冷热软硬，一概消失，仿佛一具活尸……

Paper Heron: You will become like a stone. Is that what you want?
鹭鸶剪：这就是那块石头的故事。现在，你还欣羡它么?

Mayfly: Is that how the world feels to you?
惠姑：你……原来是这样的吗?

Paper Heron: ...
鹭鸶剪：……

She doesn't reply.
一向潇洒的道人停了停，不再继续叙说。

Mayfly lowers her head, her fingers twisting together as if trying to hold the weight of her tangled thoughts.
惠姑垂下头去，手指因心绪繁杂而交叉了起来。

After a moment's consideration, she takes something from her pocket.
一阵思索后，惠姑从口袋里拿出了一个物件。

It's the amulet that was trampled by her and repaired by Paper Heron.
那是当时她踩碎后，又被鹭鸶剪修好的那个草结护符。

Mayfly: But Heron, you've already shown me a way.
惠姑：……鹭鸶剪，其实……当时你已经给我答案了。

Mayfly: This amulet—I spent every coin I had on it, just for a chance to get through the city gate.
惠姑：这个护符，也是我花了全部身家买来的，只是为求通过城门的检查，有机会接触到长生而已……

Mayfly: It didn't work like I'd hoped, and I felt so foolish for believing in it. But you repaired it, even improved it, so that I could make it through.
惠姑：我恨自己被骗，甚至一度厌恶这护符……但你修好了它，告诉我它能用，我能够拿着它去看更多地方。

Mayfly: I may be just a wind-tossed reed, but that doesn't mean I'm unworthy of the wonders of this world. Isn't that what you wanted to tell me?
惠姑：即使我们弱小无力，但也有追求这世间善好的权利……这是你教我的，不是吗?

Mayfly: I'm willing to take the chance to lose everything or gain the world.
惠姑：所以……我依然欣羡这块石头。我依然想尽一切办法求得长生。

Mayfly: You once said that fate presents an opportunity to every one of us.
惠姑：鹭鸶剪，你讲过，每个人有自己的命内机缘。

Mayfly: You've had yours, and I need to take mine.
惠姑：你有属于石头的机缘，而属于我的机缘，就是现在了。

Paper Heron: You mean that you want to follow Rén's method no matter the danger?
鹭鸶剪：……所以，你会继续追随任仙子?

Mayfly: Yes.
惠姑：……是的。

Mayfly: *cough* She-She has shown us a way to live beyond our years.
惠姑：咳咳、咳……你们给了我们一条道路，一条跳出既定命数的路……

Mayfly: Even if it's dangerous, I want to take the chance to truly live.
惠姑：那我，我要自己去试，去体会，这才是我要的生!

Paper Heron: ...
鹭鸶剪：……

Paper Heron: I understand.
鹭鸶剪：……好。

She knows it won't be useful to argue her point any longer. She rises to her feet and taps the herbs on the table.
鹭鸶剪不再反驳，她站起身来，拍了拍桌上的药材。

Paper Heron: Just remember to drink my herbal brew, eh?
鹭鸶剪： 这药，你记得吃。

The door stands ajar. Other Yao peer inside with curiosity. Paper Heron walks past them without a word.
门板虚掩，精怪们正好奇地向门内张望。鹭鸶剪不再理会它们。

In the dazzling morning light, she walks straight toward the courtyard.
在大片洒落的眩目晨光中，她径直向庭院走去。

登天阶
To Heaven! SU-16

Morning light renders the Mei petals nearly translucent under the sun. Beneath the Mei tree, young Yao practice in formation.
晨光照得梅花花瓣半透，梅花之下，小精怪们正列队练功。

Paper Heron: Where is your master?
鹭鸶剪： 任仙子呢?

School of Mei Believer I: Grandmaster Heron, I believe she left to attend to some personal matters.
梅花教信徒 I： 秉师祖，仙子她有事出去了。

Paper Heron: Erm, I think it best you no longer call me that. Your master has taken a path away from my teachings. I am now nothing more than an ordinary Daoist to you.
鹭鸶剪： 任仙子自创了一门功法，非我白马派的传承，我可不是你们师祖，以后叫我道人就行。

School of Mei Believer I: Oh, I see.
梅花教信徒 I： 啊……是！

They exchange worried glances, but seeing the pain beneath her smile, they choose not to trouble her.
小妖们惶恐地对视一眼，但瞧见鹭鸶剪笑意盈盈的表情，又按下了心中的疑问。

Paper Heron: When she returns, please tell her that I want to have a word with her here. Is there a place we could speak?
鹭鸶剪： 我有话要在这里和你们师父说，能行个方便不?

School of Mei Believer I: Certainly, Grand, uh, I mean, Master Heron.
梅花教信徒 I： 是……师……不，道人！

White clouds drift past the sun, casting shadows eastward.
白云掠日，树影东斜。

After roughly half a day, Master Rén returns to the school. Before the Mei tree, Paper Heron stands alone.
约莫半天，任仙子终于回到了教门。梅花树前，只有鹭鸶剪一人独立。

Master Ren: You wish to speak with me?
任仙子： 鹭鸶剪，听说你找我?

Paper Heron: I do. The day's been quiet, and I've found myself reminiscing on the old days. Would you join me for a chat beneath the Mei tree?
鹭鸶剪： 是啊，我今日得了闲趣，想在这梅花树前和你叙叙旧。

She smiles as she gestures toward the tree in the courtyard.
鹭鸶剪笑着指了一下院中的梅树。

Master Ren: This tree?
任仙子：这棵树？

Master Rén glances at the red Mei tree. It's scrawny for its years. Staring up at it, she can't help but laugh coldly.
任仙子瞧了一眼那棵再普通不过的红梅，瘦弱细小，不免引得她哂然一笑。

Master Ren: Why? There isn't much to it. It could take a thousand years before it rivals the largest Mei tree in town.
任仙子：虽都是红梅，但这棵有什么好聊的？假以千年，待它像城外那棵一般枝繁叶茂，还算有些意思。

Paper Heron: Let's just talk about the old days, eh?
鹭鸶剪：就聊聊往事。

Paper Heron: When the White Horse School attempted to subdue the Beast Lǎnzhū, they were taken by surprise by rival schools. We lost all our most capable masters in the battle.
鹭鸶剪：洪武年间，揽诸苏醒。白马派镇压揽诸期间遭他人围攻。致使满门皆灭，揽诸亦受重创。

Paper Heron: Seeing no other way, my grandmaster shattered one of the two Longevity Swords, releasing the Qi within to create a seal. The last student of the school and the beast were frozen in that moment, sealed inside a Mei tree.
鹭鸶剪：师祖为保众生，折断一把长生剑，放出剑中储藏先天之炁，将最后一名白马派弟子和揽诸之魄一并封于梅花树中，一去百年。

Master Ren: A hundred years later, a Painted-Skin Yao faced her celestial tribulation under the same tree. Lightning struck both her and the tree, and the seal was broken.
任仙子：直到一只画皮小妖渡劫时无意经过，引天雷劈开了梅花树，白马派传人方重新现世。

Master Ren: The lightning nearly destroyed the Yao. The White Horse student, freed from the seal and surprised by such a turn of fate, saved the dying Yao and taught her the Daoist arts. We both know the story.
任仙子：而画皮小妖则被天雷击中，或将殒命。白马派弟子感叹因缘，遂传授这只小妖门派术法——后来的事，便不用说了。

Paper Heron: Yes, you remember every detail of it.
鹭鸶剪：是的，你记得很清楚。

Master Ren: I could never forget.
任仙子：——从未忘却。

Paper Heron: I gave you the remaining sword and taught you the way of Inner Alchemy, but I never asked you to take the name of a White Horse student. I knew the school was lost to history.
鹭鸶剪：你拿了长生剑，也学了金丹术。我并不要求你拜入白马派，因为白马派已去。

Master Ren: The school is gone, yes, but their duty to control the Xiǎndào Beast was unfinished.
任仙子：只是镇压险道兽一事，还需有人去做。

Master Ren: What's the purpose of this, Heron?
任仙子：——鹭鸶剪，你究竟想说什么？

She shakes her head, gazing out into the distance toward another giant Mei tree far beyond their sight—a sister of the school's own centerpiece.
鹭鸶剪摇了摇头，看向远处，于此望不到的巨大梅花树。

Paper Heron: What is your purpose, Rén?
鹭鸶剪：——任仙子，你究竟想干什么？

Paper Heron: You told your students to channel their Qi into the Mei tree. Why?
鹭鸶剪：你让所有精怪将“气”存在那棵梅花树上……到底是在谋划什么？

Her old student looks at her and simply laughs.
听闻此言，任仙子忽地笑了出来。

Master Ren: So you've found out about that.
任仙子：你发现了？

Paper Heron: I'm not easily fooled.
鹭鸶剪：你骗不过我。

Master Rén lets the words roll over her as she settles herself at the stone table beneath the tree's shadow.
闻言，任仙子懒洋洋地在梅树前的石桌前坐下，并不在意鹭鸶剪投来的眼光。

Master Ren: I know you disagree with my methods, but whether you agree or not, this is what is best for the students.
任仙子：鹭鸶剪，我知你对我所授功法存有疑虑。但我跳过“易筋”，确是为了弟子们切身考量。

Master Ren: They're not like you. None of them have the talent or lifespan to properly cultivate longevity.
任仙子：教门的精怪们，没有哪个有你当初的资质，也没有寿命允许它们度过练习“易筋”的漫长岁月。

Master Ren: Had you been in my place, you likely wouldn't have taken them on at all. But I want to give them a chance.
任仙子：相比你的无所作为，我至少给了它们一条能长生的路。

Master Ren: After all, what would a talented master like you know of the life of a lowly Yao, of our struggles and desires?
任仙子：你不是精怪，又怎知精怪之心？我们别无选择！

Paper Heron: I do not mean to question your teachings, Rén. I only need to know why you've focused their Qi there, of all places.
鹭鸶剪：我问的不是“易筋”，任仙子。我问你的是你引导它们将气“存元”于梅树上，意欲何为？

Master Ren: My, my, when did you become so impatient, Heron?
任仙子：不要着急，我正要解释。你什么时候是这样着急的性格了？

ching
“铮——”

Master Rén casts a familiar incantation, and the white sword reappears in the air.
任仙子轻捏手诀，那柄通体莹白的剑便呈在了空中。

Master Ren: You trusted me with the sword, and I have endeavored to honor that trust by sharing it. I was once a short-lived Yao myself. It is only natural that I wish to help my kind.
任仙子：当年你将长生剑托付于我，我便设法将它弘扬。我曾是短命精怪，自然想要造福同袍。

Master Ren: Combining Inner Alchemy with the power of the Longevity Sword, I developed a method for our kind to overcome their disadvantages.
任仙子：我授予它们的，便是结合了金丹术和长生剑的便捷法门。

Master Ren: The sword can hold and release Qi. It gives, and it takes. Through it, I work to bring the Yao the lives they deserve.
任仙子：长生剑可储存气，也可放出气。它能给予，也能收走。全靠这柄法器，才能使短命精怪速成长生之法。

Master Ren: Should they succeed, there will be one more Daoist master to carry the Method forward.
任仙子：如果它们成功，自然再好不过，世间又多了一个长生之法的传人，我将发自内心欢喜。

Master Ren: And if they fail, their remaining Qi is gathered within the Mei tree to aid us in subduing the beast when it next awakens. Either way, the outcome is favorable.
任仙子：如果它们暴亡，我也能回收它们的气，投入镇压揽诸的大业之中，两全之事，岂不美哉?

Master Ren: And either way, their deaths will not be in vain.
任仙子：如此，它们的死也值了。

Paper Heron: You lay it out so plainly. Do your students know?
鹭鸶剪：你倒是毫不避讳，可你的徒弟们知道么?

Paper Heron: Do they know their master sees them as mere fuel for her designs?
鹭鸶剪：知道师父把自己带在身边，不过是一个丹炉的备用材料?

Master Ren: Hahaha ... Does it matter? Each one of them knows longevity comes at a price.
任仙子：哈哈！知道又如何？要想修得长生，怎能不付出代价！

Master Ren: Do you think any of them would have joined me if they were not willing to risk their lives?
任仙子：来到这里的精怪，哪个没有赌命的觉悟?

Master Ren: Does any price we pay matter if it means subduing the beast?
任仙子：和镇压揽诸的大业相比起来，这又算得了什么?!

She laughs again, but there's no joy in it. Paper Heron turns her head away.
任仙子疯狂地大笑起来，鹭鸶剪轻轻别过了头。

Master Ren: "No matter the cost," I said. I gave you my word. This is but a small portion of the sacrifices I am prepared to make.
任仙子：我承诺过你，镇压揽诸将万无一失。这便是那万无一失的后手。

Paper Heron: You also promised to do your best to care for your students.
鹭鸶剪：你也答应过我，尽可能护着你的弟子。

Master Ren: If the beast breaks free, every one of them will perish, whether on that fateful day or any other, they have the same choice: aid me, or else die a pointless death.
任仙子：此话怎讲？揽诸若是镇压失败，我们都会殒命，不如将这命聚在有用的地方。到了那天，我自会亲口告诉它们，让它们自行选择。

Master Ren: I should hope you know me well enough to trust that I do not undertake this selfishly. Do you not see that I am doing only what must be done?
任仙子：我这么做并非皆是私心，实为你我之愿景。你再三叮嘱我镇压揽诸并非易事，我岂敢怠慢?

Paper Heron: Keeping Lǎnzhū subdued will not require nearly this much Qi.
鹭鸶剪：可镇压揽诸并不需要这么多气。

Paper Heron: With the Qi you've gathered, the lives you've sacrificed ...
鹭鸶剪：用这么多命堆出来的气，你甚至可以……

Paper Heron: You could kill the beast.
鹭鸶剪：——杀死揽诸。

At some point, the wind in the courtyard had stilled completely.
不知何时，庭院的风已经完全停了。

Master Rén raises her head and fixes Paper Heron with a mocking stare.
任仙子抬起头来，戏谑地看向鹭鸶剪。

Master Ren: You were given a weapon of magnificent power—the capability to sense the cycle of all things and even manipulate the wax and wane of life itself.
任仙子：手持长生剑，可感悟天地万物流转，甚至可影响生命之气的荣枯。

Master Ren: Yet the White Horse School merely used it to clear the blockage of Qi in Lǎnzhū. An all-powerful sword reduced to a tamer's whip.
任仙子：白马派多年来却只用它来打通揽诸气穴，不是浪费么？既有此等神器，何苦自甘为一方牧人？

Paper Heron: Because Lǎnzhū must not die.
鹭鸶剪：揽诸不能杀。

Master Ren: Paper Heron, you of all people, are the last I expected to say such a thing. You lost your school, your friends, your masters, to this beast, and you would have it remain a threat forever?
任仙子：真没想到是你这么说，鹭鸶剪。你们白马派为这个早无侜子看管的活天灾全数折损，如今你还要为它说话？

Master Ren: What good would come of that?
任仙子：这种祸患不除，要留到什么时候？

Paper Heron: The Xiǎndào Beasts play a necessary part in the workings of Heaven. A far greater danger may come of its death, one that extends far beyond Huanzhou. Have I not taught you as much?
鹭鸶剪：天行有常。险道兽是大道运行之象征。杀死险道兽，会引发更大的灾难，远非一个涣州陷落所能比拟。你不可能不知道。

Master Ren: And why should I follow your teachings, hm? Why should I bind my students, and their students alike, to an endless cycle of subduing the beast?
任仙子：那你就让我走你的老路吗？让所有徒子徒孙，都不断地折损于镇压险道兽的循环之中，永无止境？

Paper Heron: ...!
鹭鸶剪：——！

Master Ren: Humans have a strange attachment to their "legacies." But to be Yao is to be defined by one short life. I intend to make mine echo through the ages.
任仙子：我并非人类，也无人类的传承观念。我只活这一世，也要活出这一世。

Master Ren: Lǎnzhū will perish and the cycle will end, and all for a small price.
任仙子：我会花费比你们更小的牺牲，让揽诸在我这里完全断绝。

Master Ren: No more endless duties passed from hand to hand, no more deaths in service of legacy. Our school will never suffer as yours did.
任仙子：此战过后，再也不会有人为了揽诸而死，白马派的悲剧不会重演。

Master Ren: As for me, I will share the power released from the dead beast with my students, and together, we will ascend to immortality!
任仙子：而我，也将带领我的徒弟们，吸取揽诸的气，成为真正的仙人！

Paper Heron: ...
鹭鸶剪：……

She takes a deep breath. As she opens her eyes again, her voice is cold as winter.
鹭鸶剪深呼吸一口气。再次睁开眼睛时，她的声音骤然冷了下来。

Paper Heron: This goes against the Way. It isn't natural.
鹭鸶剪：你这是在逆天而行。

Master Ren: What does it mean for a thing to be natural?
任仙子：什么是天？

Master Ren: Would it not have been natural for you to let me die under that Mei tree?
任仙子：当年，我本该被雷劫劈死在那棵封住你的梅花树下，是你救了我。

Master Ren: But you didn't. My very life is proof that the Way can be defied.
任仙子：我还活着站在这里，本就是逆天而行。

Master Ren: Perhaps there is risk in diverting the cycles of Heaven. But how much greater are the rewards?
任仙子：这世间从来如此，有多大灾祸，便成就多大机缘！

Master Ren: If there is risk, I take it gladly. I will slay the beast and free Huanzhou and its people from its threat.
任仙子：所以，我来杀死揽诸，我来承受天道，我来拯救涣州。

Master Ren: Then, I will ascend.
任仙子：我，将升仙。

Paper Heron: And if you fail? What will happen to the people?
鹭鸶剪：你若失败了，涣州的百姓该如何?

Master Ren: I won't fail.
任仙子：我不会失败。

Silence follows, broken by the returning wind as it rustles the Mei tree's branches.
良久无言，只有梅树的枝条沙沙作响。

Master Rén doesn't betray a hint of doubt, but her former master's reply comes like a sharp cut.
任仙子成竹在胸，却只听鹭鸶剪诉出冷冷一句。

Paper Heron: Your pride has blinded you.
鹭鸶剪：你太自负。

Suddenly, arcane light flashes before Master Rén's eyes.
骤然间，术法的光芒已至任仙子眼前。

She raises her brush in defense but is driven back a dozen steps.
任仙子提笔相抗，却被击退几丈。

Master Ren: Hahaha. Are you really the same woman I called Master? All I have done is speak honestly, yet you answer with a lethal strike!
任仙子：哈哈，我与你掏心掏肺，和盘托出，你却出招便下死手！

Master Ren: You lecture me about pride, then dare to take my life?
任仙子：究竟是谁太自负，鹭鸶剪！

Master Ren: But if you choose to stand in my way, then I must take yours!
任仙子：既然你执意要拦我……那便是你找死！

Master Ren: Heh! Hah!
任仙子：呃！呃！

Paper Heron: Have I trained you so poorly?
鹭鸶剪：拿命来！

Paper Heron strikes at Master Rén's weak point, but her opponent abandons resistance, instead raising the Longevity Sword like a hostage.
鹭鸶剪攻向任仙子死穴，岂料任仙子竟放弃了抵抗，仅以长生剑护在胸口。

Paper Heron: What?
鹭鸶剪：什么！

Caught off guard, Paper Heron is forced to withdraw her attack mid-strike. She barely retrieves the Longevity Sword, leaving a scar on the sheath. Yet she cannot escape the backlash of her own arcane skill.
见势，鹭鸶剪只得半路撤劲，勉强将长生剑捞了回来，但也不免在剑鞘上留下了伤痕，自己也被来不及撤走的术法反伤。

Master Ren: Hahahaha ...
任仙子：哈哈哈哈……

Master Ren: Why do you stay your hand, Heron? Strike me down, if you truly believe it to be just! Or is it that you care more for this sword than any living thing?
任仙子：鹭鸶剪，你不是要杀我吗，收手做什么？我就知道，你在乎的只有这把剑！

Master Ren: You have lost more than your senses, Master. Make whatever claims you like, but I see your empty heart. All that matters to you is your legacy, your mission! And I was only a tool.
任仙子：你的心历来是石头做的。在你眼里，谁的命又能比得过“师门遗命”？我也不过是你用来完成遗命的工具。

Master Ren: Are you now too blind to see how deep your hypocrisy runs?
任仙子：还打着百姓的旗号……事到如今，何必再假惺惺？

Paper Heron: Enough.
鹭鸶剪：住嘴。

Master Ren: *cough*
任仙子：咳……

Master Rén clutches her chest and coughs up blood.
任仙子紧捂胸口，吐出了一口鲜血。

Master Ren: All the decades I have given in preparation. You cannot stop me now, not when I am this close to success!
任仙子：鹭鸶剪，我谋划数十年……现只欠东风，怎么会败于你的临时起意？

She raises her brush, gathering energy as veins bulge on her forehead. At last, she lunges at her in a furious charge.
任仙子提笔蓄气，额头的青筋也暴起，狰狞着飞身扑将过去。

Paper Heron: What?
鹭鸶剪：不好——

Paper Heron retreats a step but fails to evade the attack entirely. Sharp pain tears through her chest.
鹭鸶剪后撤一步，却未能躲开，胸口一阵剧痛。

Seeing that Master Rén shows no sign of relenting, Paper Heron has no choice but to cast another incantation.
眼见任仙子毫无消停之意，鹭鸶剪只得反手掐出一诀。

Master Ren: Hmm?
任仙子：嗯？

The smoke clears. Before Master Rén stands only a paper figure clutching a sword.
烟雾散去，任仙子眼前只留下了一个抱着剑的小纸人。

Master Ren: Hmph.
任仙子：哼……

All Yao: Master! Should we go after her?
众妖：师父，要追吗？

Master Ren: Go. Whether dead or alive, she must not escape with the Longevity Sword. Bring it to me intact!
任仙子：追。不管她人如何，长生剑必须完好无损地回来！

All Yao: Yes, Master.
众妖：是！

The Yao scatter.
众妖随即散去。

She casts one final sneering glance at the scrawny Mei tree in the courtyard, then flicks her sleeves and leaves.
任仙子最后看了一眼庭院中的梅树，而后拂袖离去。

东方式诺言
An Eastern Promise SU-17

Night Watch: The night is dry. Beware of fires!
更夫：天干物燥，小心火烛！

Night Watch: The night is dry. Beware of fires!
更夫：天干物燥，小心火烛！

The night watch's gong reverberates into the night. Only then does Chéng Héguāng jump from the tree, studying the alley before him intently.
更夫的铜锣声渐渐远去，程和光这才从树上跳下，凝神观察起眼前的巷子。

Cheng Heguang: This is where that strange parade was last seen. Hm?
程和光：那游行的队伍，最后一次出现在这里……嗯?

Yang Wu: Hey, you! What are you doing out here at this hour?
杨武：站住！三更半夜闲逛什么?

Du Liu: Wǔ! It's her.
杜六：诶，杨武，她就是那个——

Chéng Héguāng turns toward the source of the sound. Yáng Wǔ and Dù Liù have cornered a wounded woman.
程和光循声望去，杨武和杜六正堵住了一个受伤的女子盘问，语气颇为不善。

Cheng Heguang: Yáng Wǔ, Dù Liù, what's going on?
程和光：杨武，杜六，出什么事了?

Seeing him, the two exchange an awkward glance.
看见程和光，杜六杨武二人极不自然地对视了一下。

Paper Heron: Well now, fate always finds a way to put enemies in your path, eh?
鹭鸶剪：哎……这可真是不是冤家不聚头啊。

Yang Wu: Chief! We were on patrol duty. We ran into the Daoist. She was the one with the School of Mei.
杨武：程巡检？我们在巡逻中碰见了那个梅花教的仙人……

Chéng Héguāng narrows his eyes as he spots the woman. His right hand falling instinctively to his blade.
程和光把目光转向鹭鸶剪，右手自然而然地摸上了刀柄。

Cheng Heguang: What are you doing here?
程和光：你怎么在这里?

Paper Heron: Long story.
鹭鸶剪： 说来话长。

He ignores her response, instead, sweeping his eyes over the woman's bloodstained robes.
程和光没接话茬，只是看着鹭鸶剪身上的血迹沉思。

Du Liu: Chief?
杜六： 小程巡检?

Cheng Heguang: ...
程和光： ……

Cheng Heguang: Return to your patrol. I will take her to the Yamen later.
程和光： 把她交给我吧，之后我会带她回衙门。

Yang Wu: But Chief, the commander ordered us to—
杨武： 可、程巡检，之前厉守备已经交代过我们……

Dù Liù gives his partner a prod with his elbow and takes over the conversation.
杜六轻肘了杨武一下，接过了话头。

Du Liu: Let's go, Wǔ. I'm sure the chief has his own score to settle with her.
杜六： 这道人与梅花教关系匪浅，现在梅花教行事日益猖狂，甚至还有纵火之举……想必小程巡检是想问点什么吧。

Yang Wu: His own score ... Aah.
杨武： 纵火……

Yáng Wǔ at last realizes what's going on and nods knowingly.
杨武仿佛才想起来什么，也不再阻拦杜六。

Cheng Heguang: Just a few questions. Is that alright?
程和光： ……确实有不少事情需要盘问清楚。

Du Liu: Of course. Take your time, Chief. We were never here.
杜六： 小程巡检放心，往日的此刻，我俩正在别街巡逻，今日亦是这样。

The two cup their fists in a salute and hurry away.
杜六杨武随意抱了抱拳，便匆匆离开了此处。

Paper Heron: Much appreciated. Seems you and I just can't seem to avoid each other.
鹭鸶剪： 多谢。没想到我落难关头，遇到的还是你……

Paper Heron leans against the wall. She coughs, and a small trickle of blood escapes her lips.
鹭鸶剪倚向墙壁，咳嗽两声，吐出一口血沫。

Paper Heron: Would you be willing to hear what I have to say? I need a favor. It's about the safety of this city.
鹭鸶剪： 有件事关全城百姓生死的事得拜托你。你能稍微听一下么?

The believers hold torches, gathering in the square beside the pond.
教徒们手持火把，聚集在池塘边的广场。

Master Ren: As difficult as it is to believe, we must face the truth: Paper Heron has turned against us.
任仙子： 我知道大家不愿相信，可仙人的确背叛了我们。

School of Mei Believer II: But wasn't she your guide to longevity? Why would she turn her back on us after all her efforts?
梅花教信徒 II： 可她不是教授我们长生之法的仙人吗？长生在即，她为什么要这么做?

School of Mei Believer III: She's been kind to us, and we have paid her our respect. How did it come to this?
梅花教信徒 III： 她对我们很好，我们对她也很好啊。她有什么背叛我们的理由?

Master Ren: Her long life has hardened her heart to us.
任仙子：可她毕竟已然长生。

Master Ren: But when we succeed and join her in longevity, her status and authority will be challenged.
任仙子：她不愿让我们飞升成仙，成就不世之功，以免危及自己仙人的地位！

Mayfly: I can't believe this.
惠姑：什么……

Master Ren: The moment she learned of our goal, she chose to become an obstacle. Now that she has taken the Longevity Sword, her position is clear.
任仙子：自从她知道我们的打算，便开始百般阻挠。如今更是夺走了门中的长生剑，彻底做了我们的敌人！

Master Ren: Remember, the Qi from that sword is instrumental to our success. Without it, we will not survive.
任仙子：大家应该记得，长生所需的“气”，正是由长生剑所传。若无长生剑，长生只是空谈。

The Yao below the platform grow restless. Emotions flash across their faces—surprise, sorrow, and anger.
台下的精怪骚动起来。各不相同的表情出现在教徒们的脸上，或是惊讶，或是悲伤，或是愤怒。

Hedgehog: I knew it. At first, I thought she cared when she gave us those amulets, but when she challenged Master Rén, I realized it was all a farce.
刺猬精：果然……当初她送我们那些法器，我还以为她是真心对我们……后来她说那些话时，我便知她只是表面如此……

Badger: All that talk about the "right path" and serving the Way, as if we had the time to do any of that!
獾子精：我早就看出那鹭鸶剪只是虚情假意！不然怎么会教授一些根本用不上的大道理呢！

Badger: We sacrificed so much for longevity. We can't fail now!
獾子精：大家为了长生付出了一切，决不能功亏一篑！

Master Ren: Without the sword, the Quelling Array will weaken. I can still subdue the beast with elixirs, but it will leave me without the strength to shield you from harm.
任仙子：少了长生剑，“镇殃大阵”的效力便会降低……我虽有仙丹和功法，但恐怕力有未逮，纵使降服了揽诸，也难护得所有精怪长生。

Master Ren: But we still have a chance. I wounded her when she wrestled the sword from me. We must take it back before she recovers.
任仙子：但如今，大家还来得及夺回这把剑。她刚刚被我打伤，正是虚弱的时候。

Master Ren: So I bid you: go forth and find her. Secure the sword at any cost!
任仙子：你们现在便上街寻找她的踪迹，一旦发现，生死不论，只以夺剑为要！

Master Ren: But before you risk your lives this night, hear these words: The path before us is set. We will slay Lǎnzhū and draw upon its power to ascend. If you do not share our purpose, you may still leave.
任仙子：我知今夜行动凶险异常，这天下还从未有人杀死过揽诸，原地升仙。你们谁现在就想离去的，我不会阻拦。

The crowd erupts, heated protests and arguments drowning out all else.
台下一下子炸开，热烈的吵嚷逐渐占了上风。

School of Mei Believer IV: My family is long gone, and I wouldn't have made it this far without Master Rén's teachings. I will stand with her and bring the sword back!
梅花教信徒 IV：我家人都已经过世，只有我因修炼“长生之法”得活。我愿追随仙子长生，誓死夺回长生剑！

School of Mei Believer V: I traveled all the way from Liaodong, and I'd have died last month if not for Master Rén's help. I'll do whatever I can to return the sword!
梅花教信徒 V：我从辽东而来，若不是仙子传授“长生之法”，上个月便已经死去。我愿夺回长生剑，追随仙子长生。

School of Mei Believer IV: Either we die tonight, or we live forever! I stand with Master Rén!
梅花教信徒 IV：今夜八成是死，不如放手一搏！我们愿追随仙子长生！

Yam: It seems this is the only path left for us.
山药精：……看来，看来只能放手一搏了……

Butterfly: Everyone else agrees.
小蝶虫：大家……大家这是……

Mayfly and Butterfly exchange a meaningful glance. Lost amid the fervent crowd, they join their growing cries, hesitant and then wholeheartedly.
惠姑和小蝶虫面面相觑，两人茫然地看着周围人陷入狂热，有些无措，但也迟疑地与它们齐声呐喊。

Butterfly: Then, I, too, will stand with Master Rén!
小蝶虫：我愿追随仙子长生！

Mayfly: I-I stand with Master Rén!
惠姑：我……我愿追随仙子长生！

All Yao: We all stand with Master Rén!
众精怪：我们愿追随仙子长生！

Oaths and shouts of support spread like waves in a stone-lined pond, pouring back over themselves until the once tranquil courtyard is a cacophony of sound.
誓言和呼喊声如浪潮一般荡开，彻底打碎了园林的平静。

Then their master raises her hand, signaling the believers to quiet down.
任仙子摆了摆手，示意教徒安静片刻。

Master Ren: You have my thanks.
任仙子：任仙子谢过各位！

Master Ren: Do not let fear get the better of you. The final hour approaches; the array is ready. I shall do all that is in my power to enact our plan.
任仙子：但诸位也不必太过惊慌。时辰将至，我已布好阵法，可以尽力一试。

Master Ren: With or without the sword, meet me under the Mei tree at the first double-hour this night. Together, we will seek our ascension to longevity!
任仙子：无论是否拿到法剑，诸位都务必于子时前往梅树之下，与我共待长生！

A century-old tale can be told in mere sentences.
百年的故事，讲起来也不过寥寥几句。

Chéng Héguāng looks at her in astonishment, fitting the scattered fragments of his investigation into a clear picture at last.
程和光有些震惊地看向鹭鸶剪，意识到一些散乱的碎片终于可以串联起来。

Cheng Heguang: So then, those dead animals were the Yao who failed in their pursuit of the Method.
程和光：你是说，那些动物遗尸，是修炼“长生之法”失败的精怪……

Paper Heron nods.
鹭鸶剪点点头。

Paper Heron: Lǎnzhū will soon awaken. If we don't stop Rén, her actions may throw the balance of life out of order and put all of Huanzhou in danger.
鹭鸶剪：揽诸马上就会苏醒，若任仙子执意升仙，那时不光会乾坤失序，日月同天，整个涣州都会分崩离析，毁于一旦。

Paper Heron: We need to evacuate the townsfolk as soon as we can. Time's running out.
鹭鸶剪：不可再耽搁，必须马上疏散民众……时间不够了。

Paper Heron: But I'm wounded. It will be a while before I can move again.
鹭鸶剪：但我被任仙子打伤，此刻急需调气，难以行动。

Paper Heron: Will you aid me in this?
鹭鸶剪：你可愿助我?

His mouth opens in surprise, but the words don't come. After a moment's deliberation, he makes his decision.
程和光惊异地张了张口，一时无声。思忖片刻，终是下了决心。

Cheng Heguang: This is no small favor. It'll take the effort of every soldier and constable in town to evacuate the people in time.
程和光：此事绝非儿戏。全城疏散，需要衙门通力配合。

Cheng Heguang: Even if I believe you, my superiors won't be so easily convinced.
程和光：空口无凭。纵使我信，光凭我一人之力，如何能够助你?

Paper Heron: Then how about this?
鹭鸶剪：……那这样如何?

She bows her head and draws the Longevity Sword from within her robes, channeling a thread of Qi into it.
鹭鸶剪微微低头，拿出怀中的长生剑，将一缕气注入其中。

The white blade emanates a cold bright light. It seems almost alive for a moment.
白莹的剑身冒出幽幽寒光，一时间好似活物。

Paper Heron: Long ago, when His Eminence walked the land, two white horse tails were bestowed upon him as a reward for his service to the Way. Those tails were forged into a pair of jade swords.
鹭鸶剪：当年真人魂游世间，得大道所赐白马尾，炼为两柄白玉剑。

Paper Heron: I carry only one of them. A rare Daoist implement passed down to me by my master, from his master before him. It means more to me than my life.
鹭鸶剪：这是世间罕有的上古法器，也是白马派的师门遗物，梅花教的长生宝剑，我平生最重要之物。

Paper Heron: I swear on it. I have told you nothing but the truth.
鹭鸶剪：我以此物起誓，我所说绝无一字虚言。

Paper Heron: Were you to present this sword to your people, might they ...?
鹭鸶剪：你将此物示与他人，兴许……

Cheng Heguang: It'll do.
程和光：……足够了。

He fixes his sharp gaze over the Mei pattern and the Bagua array.
程和光目光如炬地看着剑鞘上的梅花和八卦图样。

Cheng Heguang: The high lords of this town have close ties with the School of Mei.
程和光：涣州高层中，不少官员机要都与梅花教有所来往。

Cheng Heguang: They will recognize this sword.
程和光：他们定识得此剑。

Paper Heron: Then take it. Look after it well.
鹭鸶剪：……那，此剑便托付于你了。

She sheathes the sword and offers it to him.
鹭鸶剪收剑入鞘，小心翼翼地将长生剑放到程和光手中。

He receives it with both hands, feeling the blade's weight.
程和光双手接过，感受到了剑身厚重的分量。

Cheng Heguang: You-You're leaving the sword to me, just like that?
程和光：它对你如此重要……你……就这样把它给我?

She lowers her eyes, managing a weak smile.
鹭鸶剪垂下眼，虚弱地笑了一下。

Paper Heron: This sword means more to me than my life, yes. But I once valued it so greatly that I lost sight of what is truly important. In the end, it's only a sword.
鹭鸶剪：的确，它曾是我最看重的东西。我把它看得如此之重，以至于有时候忘记了，它也只是一把剑而已。

Paper Heron: And what purpose does a sword have if it is not used to protect?
鹭鸶剪：若它不能护人，还算什么剑?

Cheng Heguang: Well said!
程和光：……好！

Cheng Heguang: You have my word. I will protect it with my life.
程和光：我答应你，我程和光，定会尽我所能，护好这把剑。

Cheng Heguang: Should anything go wrong, I will bring my head to you.
程和光：报信之后，定将它分毫无损地交还到你手上，如有差池，提头来见！

In the deep darkness of the night, Paper Heron cannot see the young man's face, but his resolute tone paints a picture the light could not.
夜色深沉，鹭鸶剪看不清少年的面容，但听他决然的语气，脑中也能想出几分。

She lifts herself just enough to reach his shoulder.
她笑笑，宽慰似的拍了拍程和光的肩。

Paper Heron: Now, what would I do with a young man's head, eh? Worry not. I'm a Qi reader. I can trace the sword wherever it goes.
鹭鸶剪：别头不头的，年轻人。我有望气之法，就算这剑丢到天涯海角，我也找得回。

Paper Heron: Now go. Rén won't give up the sword easily, so be careful. I'll find you once I'm back on my feet.
鹭鸶剪：你快走吧，任仙子定不会放弃寻剑。我寻一僻静处调气，休养好后自会来找你。

Distant screams and wails drift through the air. Across the county, fires burst and flicker against the night sky.
远处传来模糊的嘶鸣与哭喊声，城内已经燃起了隐隐的火光。

Yao shadows slide across the wall. Any doubt that Paper Heron speaks the truth vanishes from him.
精怪的黑影在墙上一晃而过，鹭鸶剪所言非虚。

Cheng Heguang: What if ...
程和光：你……

Paper Heron: Just go!
鹭鸶剪：——走！

Chéng Héguāng grits his teeth, takes the Longevity Sword to his side, and leaps onto the high wall.
程和光咬咬牙，终究还是拿上了长生剑，跳上了高墙。

Paper Heron: Chéng! I owe you for this.
鹭鸶剪：……有劳你了。

Paper Heron: For setting aside grudges and helping me. I know the School of Mei burned down your home. If we survive this, I'll help you build a new one.
鹭鸶剪：你与梅花教有烧屋之仇，却仍愿鼎力相助。若涣州能幸免于难，我定帮你重建老屋。

Cheng Heguang: The School of Mei?
程和光：……烧屋之仇?

At these words, the young man atop the wall turns around, his usually stern face broken into a rare, wild-eyed smile.
闻言，墙顶上的青年转过身来，罕见地露出了一个笑容。

Cheng Heguang: To tell you the truth ...
程和光：实话告诉你吧!

Cheng Heguang: I set that fire myself.
程和光：那夜——火是我自己放的。

Paper Heron: Wait, what?
鹭鸶剪：什么——?

Her eyes widen in surprise, but the tiles stand empty before she can respond.
鹭鸶剪错愕望去，但青瓦上已经空无一人。

Before her, Yao surge from the shadows in their true forms, eyes gleaming green beneath the moon.
眼前，一群显出原形的精怪于暗处涌来，眼睛在月色的照映下发着绿光。

Paper Heron: Well now, never judge a book by its cover, eh?
鹭鸶剪：哎呀，真是人不可貌相……

School of Mei Believer IV: Heron! Return the sword at once!
梅花教信徒 IV：鹭鸶剪，还剑来!

Paper Heron: And if I refuse?
鹭鸶剪：我若是不，又能如何?

Paper Heron: Come, let me see how Rén trains her students!
鹭鸶剪：来吧，让我试试任仙子的徒弟!

Yamen, Ancient Zhu County
古祝县·县衙

The Yamen is silent. The bell beneath the roof's beastly guardians has not moved.
衙门内十分安静。

Chéng Héguāng crosses over the gate. In a few strides, he reaches the still-lit study and extends his hand toward the door.
程和光跨过大门，几步掠到仍亮着灯的书房前，伸手便要推门。

???: Commander Lì ...
???：……守备……

The unfamiliar voice stops him in place.
陌生的声音使他停下了动作。

Cheng Heguang: There's someone else inside?
程和光：有其他人在……?

After a moment's consideration, he crouches and places his ear up to the door.
思忖片刻后，程和光在门前蹲下，专心聆听门内的一举一动。

???: Haha! It truly was a masterstroke.
???: 哈！守备真是好计策。

???: Had it not been for your arrests, the Yao wouldn't have turned to me so quickly, or in such numbers.
???: 在厉守备下达抓捕的命令后，精怪们走投无路，果然都被迫逃入了教门。

Li Huifeng: As an otter drives fish into the lakes and the eagle leads birds into the woods, heh heh, the hunter must know where his prey will run.
厉晦锋: 为渊驱鱼，为丛驱雀……我不过是反过来利用罢了。

???: You have honored your word. I will keep your efforts in mind when I next speak to your superiors.
???: 你对我们梅花教助力颇多，陆总兵那边，我绝不会忘记我们之前的承诺。

???: I have one more favor to ask.
???: 只是如今，还有一事要拜托守备——

The conversation grows indistinct as fury clouds Chéng Héguāng's focus.
后面的话渐渐听不清了，因为血气已在眼前翻涌。

Clarity returns. But only after he finds himself standing resolutely behind a door that has been kicked wide open.
回过神来时，大门已经被一脚踢开。

Cheng Heguang: Lì Huìfēng!
程和光: ——厉晦锋！

有舍有得
Pain and Gain SU-18

Study, Yamen
古祝县·县衙书房

Cheng Heguang: Urgh!
程和光: ——唔！

The door swings back toward him, and he instinctively pushes it aside. Ink droplets fly across his face.
程和光推开门扉，眼见几滴墨点直冲着自己面门飞来。

He sidesteps, revealing the Longevity Sword strapped to his back.
他下意识侧身躲避，露出了系在身后的长生剑。

Master Ren: You do indeed work wonders, Commander. My lost sword has shown up at your door before I even asked for it.
任仙子: 哦……？厉守备真是手眼通天啊，我还没开口，这剑竟就自己送上门了。

The elegant woman in Daoist robes withdraws her brush mockingly, looking over to the commander.
道士打扮的清丽女子戏谑地收回了笔，目光看向一边的厉晦锋。

He offers no response; instead, his eyes linger on the blade Chéng Héguāng now holds half-drawn.
对方并不表态，只是看着程和光出鞘一半的长刀。

Li Huifeng: Héguāng, take a seat.
厉晦锋：和光，坐下吧。

He gestures toward a chair in the room. Chéng Héguāng doesn't budge, his hand trembling over the grip of the sword.
厉晦锋指了指屋内的一把椅子。程和光分毫未动，手因为握刀太紧而有些微颤。

Li Huifeng: Pardon the intrusion, Master Rén. This is Chéng, that subordinate I've mentioned, a promising young man. He has proven to be of great use.
厉晦锋：仙子，我向你介绍。他便是程和光。本领高强，办事利落。在“高跷巡神”时，也出了大力气的。

Chéng Héguāng makes it clear he will not offer a greeting. Lì Huìfēng decides not to insist before introducing him to the woman as if his arrival had been nothing more than a social visit.
见程和光并不领情，厉晦锋也不作坚持，只是扭头向二人介绍起来人。

Li Huifeng: Héguāng, this is Master Rén, the head of the School of Mei and a respected friend of Lord Lù. I have told her of your hardships, and she has expressed her sympathies.
厉晦锋：和光，这位是任仙子，梅花教的掌教，也是陆总兵的座上宾。我曾和她提起过你家里的事，仙子甚是同情。

Master Ren: Well met, Chief Constable Chéng. Your commander speaks highly of you. I hope you do not bear me any ill will. I understand some blame my school for your unfortunate fire.
任仙子：原来你就是程巡检，我还没见过你的时候，就有人问过我是不是烧了你的房子。

Master Ren: You have suffered a great deal of troubles. I can only imagine how far your star would rise if it weren't for your unfortunate parentage.
任仙子：你父亲的事，我已知晓。你极力证明自己，却总被缚住手脚，真是可怜可怜！

Master Ren: If fate has led us to meet this day, it must have its reasons. I cannot do much, but I may offer some aid to your career.
任仙子：今日在此相见，也算你我有缘，我便助你一程。

She removes a token from her waist and tosses it before the young constable.
任仙子解下腰间的一枚令牌，随手扔到程和光面前。

Master Ren: A personal gift from the venerable Lord Lù. His influence carries quite far, I'm sure you know. I wonder how he might look upon the constable that returned my sword to me.
任仙子：这是总兵给我的信物。你寻剑有功，长生剑给我，我自会替你去总兵面前美言。

Master Ren: With our recommendation, a promotion would certainly follow.
任仙子：届时，你想谋什么职位，都任你挑选。

Chéng Héguāng maintains his grip on the blade, not sparing the token on the ground even the courtesy of a glance.
程和光仍是紧紧握着手里的长刀，目光并未看向地上的令牌。

Cheng Heguang: You-You've been conspiring all along. All that talk of evidence, hmph, it was just an attempt to stall me.
程和光：原来你们早就串通好了……证据、上级、关系，都是借口。

Cheng Heguang: You've been in their pocket from the start!
程和光：你一直都和梅花教狼狈为奸，从最开始……！

Li Huifeng: Héguāng.
厉晦锋：和光。

His commander interjects, attempting to douse the young constable's fiery accusations.
厉晦锋冷不丁地出声，打断了年轻巡检激动的陈辞。

Li Huifeng: Pick up the token. Is this not what you've always wanted? To redeem your family name?
厉晦锋：把陆总兵的令牌捡起来吧。你不是一直想要尽快擢升，用功名洗刷程家的耻辱吗?

Li Huifeng: Take it. Your long-cherished wish can come true.
厉晦锋：捡起它，你一直以来的心愿便达成了。

His voice drips out at a measured pace, as always.
对方的声音不疾不徐，一如往常。

Chéng Héguāng stares in disbelief. The blade's shadow on the wall wavers.
程和光难以置信地望去，刀光在墙上的投影晃了一晃。

Cheng Heguang: Lì Huìfēng! Have you lost your senses?
程和光：厉晦锋！事到如今，你还和我说这些?!

Cheng Heguang: Do you hear yourself? If she takes this sword, she will bring calamity upon us all!
程和光：你知道你到底在做什么吗？若任仙子拿剑升仙，涣州将有大灾，城镇将全部陷落，百姓将流离失所!!!

Cheng Heguang: Not only do you act as an agent of evil, allowing her to harm your people, but you even dare to profit from their suffering! You—
程和光：你身为守备，却助纣为虐，为虎作伥，任由梅花教草菅人命！现在你不去疏散百姓，却在这里为自己谋前程好处。你——

Master Ren: Hahaha ...
任仙子：——哈哈哈哈哈！

The Daoist woman begins to laugh, as if their exchange had only been an amusing story.
任仙子忽然爆发出阵阵大笑，打断了这场对话。

Master Ren: "Agent of evil"? "Profit from their suffering"? Have you looked at yourself, Chief Chéng?
任仙子：助纣为虐，为虎作伥？为自己谋前程好处？程巡检，你在说谁啊?

Master Ren: Haven't you been arresting Yao day and night for the sake of your own glory? Are you not the very reason they sought refuge at my door?
任仙子：最急着抓拿精怪，换取功名的，不就是你么？给这城中小妖带来最大恐惧，逼它们入我梅花教的，不也是你吗?

Cheng Heguang: That is a perversion of the truth! Hah! I should've seen it before—the Reversion Bell. How else could our town have come by a Daoist relic? The parade itself was your doing!
程和光：血口喷人！我早该想到，衙门怎会有振气铃这种道门法器……“高跷巡神”从一开始就是你们自导自演!

Master Ren: For all of the Yao you imprisoned and interrogated, you still had no knowledge of our designs, did you?
任仙子：哈哈？你当真能早想到？你抓捕精怪时，眼里当真有其他吗?

Master Ren: Those poor, pitiful Yao, only wanting another day to live, crushed beneath the chief's boots, in his hunger for power.
任仙子：那些短命精怪不过是想要给自己搏一条活路，却被你做了立功的筹码!

Cheng Heguang: Lies! They were arrested for deceiving the people, not for my benefit!
程和光：胡说！它们妖言惑众，诱拐百姓，本该受罚!

Master Ren: Hah! Deceiving the people! And what lie was it that drove them to beg for the Method of Longevity?
任仙子：笑话！自我建了教门，不知多少人想混入其中！口口声声说自己被精怪引诱，却私下削尖了脑袋，要与我等精怪为伍!

Master Ren: Were they deceived, or did they only accuse me out of spite after being turned away? Some "investigation"!
任仙子：究竟是遭遇蒙骗，还是怕传出去面上无光，信口胡说，你可有真问个清楚？你又可曾真正见过实证！

Master Ren: As you strode through that prison, did it ever cross your mind that the truth may be the very opposite?
任仙子：你在班房巡检那一个个战果时，心中可有它想?!

Cheng Heguang: ...!
程和光：……！

Bird: We only want a little more time in this world, Chief Chéng. Why must you stand in our way?
鸟妖：我们只是想通过别的法子活得久一点，程巡检，你何故为难我们?

Bird: Only a few borrowed days! We never hurt anyone!
鸟妖：我们从来都没有害过任何一个人！只是想活下去！

Bird: I've done nothing wrong! Release me! Every moment is precious!
鸟妖：我什么都没有做！放我出去！我等不起了！

Cold sweat drips over Chéng Héguāng's temples. He realizes with some pain that this woman speaks the truth.
冷汗从程和光的额角上滴落，他忽地意识到任仙子确有实话。

Master Ren: Hmph. You needn't trouble yourself, Chief Chéng. In fact, I should thank you.
任仙子：不过，我倒要谢谢你。

Master Ren: Were it not for your diligence, I'd have never gathered so much Qi in such a short time.
任仙子：要不是你这般问心无愧，我未必能这么快攒到足够的气。

Master Ren: Hmph. Whether Huanzhou is saved or meets its ruin this night, much of the credit shall be yours.
任仙子：涣州若是陷落，其中也有你一份力啊，程巡检。这令牌给你，值当。

Cheng Heguang: You—
程和光：什么……?!

He glares, eyes raging with fury, but the Daoist Master no longer seems willing to entertain him as she drifts to Lì Huìfēng's side.
程和光怒而瞪目，任仙子全然不在意，飘至厉晦锋身侧。

Master Ren: You humans are odd indeed. Have you not spent your entire life attempting to cleanse yourself of your father's dishonor?
任仙子：我真是不懂。你一生汲汲营营，所谋所求就在眼前，还要装什么?

Master Ren: Why shy away from your actions now, when they might finally be rewarded?
任仙子：畏葸不前，还不如那些坦荡小人来得痛快！

Cheng Heguang: That's not why I did it! I didn't—
程和光：不是这样的……！我不是为了这些——

Li Huifeng: Héguāng.
厉晦锋：——和光。

Before he realizes it, Lì Huìfēng has already retrieved the token from the floor.
不知不觉间，厉晦锋已捡起了地上的令牌。

Chéng Héguāng sees it clearly for the first time. A symbol of power, inlaid with gold and silver.
程和光第一次看清它。令牌镶金嵌银，明晃晃书写着总兵的名号。

Li Huifeng: Pick up the token, and put down the sword.
厉晦锋：拿走令牌。放下剑。

Li Huifeng: You have heard too much; you can't stay here any longer. Take the token and go. Find a new life for yourself elsewhere.
厉晦锋：你知道太多，留不住你。离开涣州。自有广阔前程。

He brushes away the dust and extends the token toward Chéng Héguāng.
厉晦锋拂去令牌上的灰尘，将它递了过来。

Li Huifeng: Or have you forgotten the vow you made to me?
厉晦锋：你忘了，你曾经在衙门堂下，是怎么立誓的吗?

Cheng Heguang: I ...
程和光：……我……

Li Huifeng: What is your want?
厉晦锋：你想要什么?

Cheng Heguang: My father brought shame not only upon himself, but upon those who placed their trust in him. I swear I will not make the same mistake.
程和光：……我知家父与匪类同流合污，已成一桩耻辱。但我绝不会重蹈覆辙。

Cheng Heguang: It is said that a warrior is a warrior, and a bandit is a bandit. But I am not my father, and I will remove the stain on my family name!
程和光：兵就是兵，贼就是贼。我绝对会与我父亲划清界限，洗刷程家的污名，不让别人再嘲笑我的家人!

Cheng Heguang: Commander, all I ask is one chance!
程和光：请守备给我一个机会!

Master Ren: *sigh* Chief Chéng, I pray you would not hold my words against me. They were spoken in the heat of the moment.
任仙子：唉，程巡检也不要太介怀小道那番话。

Master Ren: *sneer* You are human, and we are Yao. Beings of different kinds are never of one mind. Our natures simply do not align.
任仙子：毕竟，妖就是妖。非我族类，其心必异。

Master Ren: So your interests clash with ours. Why blame yourself for what was bound to happen?
任仙子：借此立功，更是人之常情。你何错之有啊?

Between truth and lies, their voices grow distant, then near, back and forth like a swinging pendulum.
虚虚实实间，二人的声音忽远忽近，如钟摆轮回。

Though the autumn wanes outside, inside the air feels thick and stifling.
虽是秋末，却觉得置身于浓稠的热气里，几乎无法呼吸。

Cheng Heguang: A warrior is a warrior, and a bandit is a bandit.
程和光：兵就是兵。贼就是贼。

Cheng Heguang: Beings of different kinds are never of one mind.
程和光：人就是人。妖就是妖。

Cheng Heguang: So that's how it is. Hahaha, hahahaha.
程和光：到头来，这竟是一回事……哈哈哈，哈哈哈哈……

He's been backed into the corner.
程和光已至角落。

No escape remains.
他已无路可退。

Cheng Heguang: Commander, for the last time—
程和光：……厉守备，我最后问你一次。

Cheng Heguang: Are you aware that Huanzhou now lingers at the edge of destruction?
程和光：涣州将有大灾，你不知道吗?

Under the lamplight, his mentor's expression remains unclear. But his voice holds steady and darkly calm.
灯火下，那人的表情却不分明。只是声音依然毫无波澜。

Li Huifeng: Yes and no—
厉晦锋：我知，或是不知……

Li Huifeng: Does it even matter?
厉晦锋：又有什么分别?

Cheng Heguang: Hahahaha, fair point! A fair point!
程和光：……哈哈，好！好一个没有分别！

All his rage, shock, and disappointment dissolve into a single bitter laugh.
所有的愤怒、诧异和失望都化作了一声大笑。

In that instant, Chéng Héguāng's blade leaves its sheath as ink strikes toward his waist.
言语间，刹那间，程和光长刀出鞘，墨点也直刺向了他的腰间。

In a flash, several oil lamps are extinguished. The token shatters into worthless scrap under the ink's force.
弹射间，屋内油灯的火光灭了数盏，令牌也被墨点击成废铁。

Cheng Heguang: I should have known.
程和光：我早该知道。

Cheng Heguang: For years, I worked to prove myself to you, hoping my merits would prove the strength of my character. I was so fixated on my goal that I failed to see the truth.
程和光：我一心想在衙门谋求一个证明，一个关于我是何种人的证明。却忘了这里是哪里，也漏看了它的规矩。

Cheng Heguang: Now I see it clearly. Seeking favor from people like you only led me deeper into dishonor.
程和光：在一个错误的地方谋求胜利，也许本身就是一种助纣为虐。最终徒增的，只有错误罢了。

He shakes his head ruefully, mourning years of wasted effort.
程和光轻轻摇了摇头。

Cheng Heguang: I never cared about promotions or power. I only ever wanted to do what was right.
程和光：可到头来，我真正想要的，并不是功名。只是一份公正而已。

Cheng Heguang: If I picked up that token, I would be betraying all that I believe in.
程和光：若拿这令牌意味着失去公正，我何须拿它?

He tears his Chief Constable's token from his waist and throws it to Lì Huìfēng's feet.
程和光扯下巡检的腰牌，扔到了厉晦锋的脚下。

Cheng Heguang: Commander, you claim that it doesn't matter what you know. You think that I should be a soldier and follow what you say.
程和光：厉守备，你说没有分别，可兵就是兵，贼就是贼!!!

Cheng Heguang: But I see now, I am a bandit, and I always will be!
程和光：我是贼，我从来都是贼!

Cheng Heguang: I want no place among your kind!
程和光：——这个官，我不做了!!!

In the flickering lamplight, Lì Huìfēng's blade flashes forward before his eyes.
灯火摇曳时，厉晦锋的刀刃已至眼前。

Li Huifeng: Your father was once my friend. After what happened, I took it upon myself to aid you through your difficulties.
厉晦锋：程道官和我有过交情。他出事后，我是真想帮帮他的儿子。

Li Huifeng: But it seems you're too stubborn to be helped.
厉晦锋：——可你实在油盐不进。

The two men meet in a furious clash of blades and incantations, reducing the room around them to shambles.
二人缠斗在一起，将屋内劈砍得一片狼藉。

But at the height of their deadlock, Master Rén intervenes, suddenly striking Chéng Héguāng with her palm, forcing him back several steps.
相持不下时，任仙子骤然出掌，将程和光震退几步。

Master Ren: You hopeless fool! Surrender the sword at once!
任仙子：凡夫俗子，着实恼人！还不把长生剑交出来！

Cheng Heguang: I gave my word to protect it.
程和光：我答应过别人护好这把剑。

Cheng Heguang: I've made many mistakes. I will not make another.
程和光：我已错了太多，好在如今，我还有一个承诺能守。

Cheng Heguang: If you want the sword, you'll have to kill me first!
程和光：——你若想得剑，便先杀了我！

The Daoist flicks her sleeves dramatically as her shadow on the wall transforms like a serpent shedding its skin.
任仙子径直拂动衣袖，她的影子在墙面上如蛇一般蜕皮变形。

Her gentle facade shatters, falling away like a cascade of ash.
那副温和可亲的旧皮囊寸寸碎裂，顷刻便焚作灰烬。

Cheng Heguang: —?
程和光：——?!

Master Rén draws her iron brush and closes the distance in mere strides.
任仙子甩出铁笔，几步之间再次攻到程和光身前。

Cheng Heguang: Ugh! Can't hold out much longer.
程和光：呃……！这般下去，坚持不了多久……！

Dazed by her assault, he nearly misses the slip of red paper drifting past him.
恍惚间，他看见空中飘过了一缕红纸。

Cheng Heguang: ...!
程和光：……！

Master Ren: Eyes forward. There's no escape now!
任仙子：你在看哪里?!

Cheng Heguang: Ugh!
程和光：呃！

Paper Heron: Chéng!
鹭鸶剪：程和光！

Cheng Heguang: Take the sword!
程和光：接剑！

Paper Heron: My thanks!
鹭鸶剪：多谢！

Paper Heron: I hope I'm not too late!
鹭鸶剪：希望我来得不算迟！

区区
Significance of the Insignificant SU-19

Paper Heron catches the sword midair, using its edge to deflect the ink droplets surging toward her from the side.
鹭鸶剪得了剑，顺势将剑锋一偏，挡下了斜刺里飞来的墨点。

Seeing this, Master Rén lunges forward half a step, barring the doorway.
见此架势，任仙子猛然往前半步，拦在门前。

Master Ren: Return the sword to me.
任仙子：鹭鸶剪，把剑给我。

Paper Heron: Not while I yet breathe.
鹭鸶剪：休想。

Master Ren: So be it. It will spare me from listening to another of your worthless lectures.
任仙子：好，好……！你如这般坦诚，倒也是一桩好事！

Master Ren: You entrusted that sword to me long ago. Why not simply hand it over and return to your carefree wandering?
任仙子：你既已将一切托付给我，何不爽快将剑拿来，继续过你的逍遥日子？

Master Ren: Perhaps you aren't so free from desire!
任仙子：哈，鹭鸶剪，你究竟不是真仙人！

Amid the flames, blades flash. Paper Heron and Master Rén remain locked in combat.
火场之中，刀光剑影，鹭鸶剪仍在与任仙子缠斗。

Beams blaze above them. Chéng Héguāng dodges as collapsing timbers fall nearby, only now realizing that his commander has vanished within the smoke and fled into the night.
房梁在大火中熊熊燃烧，程和光警惕躲避着坍塌的木条，而厉晦锋早已不见踪影。

Suddenly, as if ten thousand drums were struck at once, the earth trembles and quakes.
突然间，如万人擂鼓，伴随着巨大的响动之声，地面如鼓面般震动起来。

Cheng Heguang: What's going on?
程和光：怎么了？！

Paper Heron whips around toward the patch of sky visible through the study's courtyard.
鹭鸶剪急忙望向书院天井那角天幕。

Paper Heron: Lǎnzhū.
鹭鸶剪：……是揽诸。

Paper Heron: The beast has awakened.
鹭鸶剪：险道兽醒了。

Master Ren: The moment has come at last. You are weak, Heron. Your Qi will not be enough to contend with Lǎnzhū.
任仙子：终究是我的时辰到了。鹭鸶剪，以你现在负伤的程度，甚至无法为揽诸调气——你什么都做不了了。

Master Ren: Keep the sword if you must. I will ascend with or without it!
任仙子：你便抱着这把剑，看我如何成就大业吧。

Her triumphant laughter rings out as she leaps away over the growing fires.
任仙子振臂大笑，提步跃出了火场。

Cheng Heguang: She—
程和光：她！

Paper Heron: Don't, Chéng. *cough*
鹭鸶剪：程巡检，别追了……咳……

Paper Heron: It's too late.
鹭鸶剪：来不及了。

Darkness engulfs half the sky, devouring the moonlight. The earth trembles as if it were breathing. Panicked civilians flood the streets.
昏天黑地，月光被浓雾吞噬，大地如微鼾般颤抖，无措的民众涌上街头。

Fire-lit columns of smoke rise over the other half. Beams collapse, bricks crumble. The calamity has arrived.
烈火烧融了半边天际，房梁坍塌，砖石崩解，灾劫已至。

County Resident II: Earthquake! It's an earthquake!
祝县县民 II：地震！大地震！

County Resident II: The ground is splitting apart! I saw someone fall into it. Help! Get help!!
祝县县民 II：地裂开了——救命！有人掉进地缝里去了！救命啊！

County Resident III: My house!
祝县县民 III：房子塌了——我的房子——

Cheng Heguang: This-This is Lǎnzhū's power.
程和光：这……这就是揽诸带来的灾殃……

Paper Heron: Rén has agitated it, forcing its Qi to surge just so she can siphon it for herself. She is inviting a disaster greater than any known before.
鹭鸶剪：任仙子开始便打算激化揽诸，夺气升仙。揽诸造成的浩劫将更甚往日。

Against the swirling trample of the helpless civilians, a parade advances, chanting above the panicked din around them.
而在混乱无措的民众中，一列行队整齐的游行队伍正喊着洪亮的口号走来。

School of Mei Believers: Withered grass devours bone. On icy plain the spirits moan.
梅花教信徒众：黑绒吞白骨，寒原鬼泣呜。

School of Mei Believers: When the city falls, the Immortal descends. Longevity granted, no death, no end.
梅花教信徒众：城覆仙人现，长生免祸殃。

County Resident II: What-What on earth is happening?
祝县县民 II：这到底是怎么了……

School of Mei Believer II: The path lies untraveled, but the end has begun!
梅花教信徒 II：命数未尽！末日已至！

School of Mei Believer II: Seek salvation in longevity!
梅花教信徒 II： 唯有长生可得救赎！

County Resident II: Salvation? Longevity? How?
祝县县民 II： 救赎？如何长生？

County Resident II: Help us, Immortal One!
祝县县民 II： 仙人救我！

Cheng Heguang: Hmph. They think Rén is here to save them. Ridiculous!
程和光： 呸……那妖怪，现在倒真成百姓眼中的救世仙人了！

Paper Heron stands amid the wreckage of a street, feeling strangely helpless despite herself.
鹭鸶剪站在这混乱的街头，一时间也有点无措。

She holds the Longevity Sword, bows her head, and lets out a deep sigh.
她抱着手中的剑，低下头，深深地叹了一口气。

Paper Heron: This is all because of me. I brought all of this upon us.
鹭鸶剪： 归根结底，这一切是因我而起。

Paper Heron: When the White Horse School collapsed, I couldn't bear to see the Method of Longevity disappear. I believed that sharing it with Rén would be for the benefit of all.
鹭鸶剪： 我知白马派已亡，却不忍心师门术法失传，竟以为广传此法能造福众生，也是一桩好事。

Paper Heron: But I forgot that with fortune comes disaster, and how easily a well-intended deed can lead to peril.
鹭鸶剪： 可我忘记了祸兮福所倚，福兮祸所伏，天大的好里自然带着天大的恶。

Paper Heron: The Method itself is not wicked, and those who put their faith in Rén are not evil in nature, but I-I entrusted a dangerous tool to the wrong person.
鹭鸶剪： 法门无错，众生所求亦无错。是我轻视了人心，忤逆了天道，托付错了人，方才酿下此等大祸。

Paper Heron: I am the one to blame.
鹭鸶剪： 错全在我。

It's difficult to read her expression. He cannot help but see the hellish disaster reflected in the depths of her eyes.
程和光看不清鹭鸶剪的神情，但清楚生灵涂炭的景象已映在鹭鸶剪眼底。

Paper Heron: And I must be the one to end it.
鹭鸶剪： 事情因我而起，也应因我而终。

Paper Heron surveys the scene ahead of her.
鹭鸶剪缓缓地环视着这场灾劫。

Paper Heron: You need to leave.
鹭鸶剪： 你快走吧，离开这里。

Cheng Heguang: Leave? Where to?
程和光： 去哪儿？

Paper Heron: Anywhere but here. If you go now and run day and night, you may yet survive.
鹭鸶剪： 去哪儿都行，以你的脚力，日夜兼程奔离涣州，兴许能躲过这次灾殃。

Cheng Heguang: Why?
程和光： 凭什么？

She looks up, surprised at the fury in Chéng Héguāng's tone.
鹭鸶剪有些惊讶地抬头，程和光的语气是毫不掩饰的愤怒。

Cheng Heguang: If I flee now, how am I any different from those cowardly lords?
程和光：大灾当前，我若是见死不救，只顾自己，与那些贪图名利、弃城而走的高官又有何分别?!

Cheng Heguang: I may no longer be Chief Constable, but I still answer to my conscience!
程和光：我程和光从来只想不昧本心，求得一个公正。如今我已不是巡检，更不必在意什么名利规矩!

Paper Heron: You don't fear death?
鹭鸶剪：你不求生路?

Cheng Heguang: I fear living in regret.
程和光：我只求无悔。

He clutches his fists. The fire in his eyes burns brighter than any mere reflection.
程和光握紧了他的双拳，火光在他的双目中熠熠生辉。

Cheng Heguang: You trusted me with your sword. I cannot repay you with abandonment.
程和光：你曾借剑助我，我尚未回报。此时离去，便是无信无义。

Cheng Heguang: Lì Huìfēng has fled, but I still have his token to command the other constables.
程和光：厉晦锋虽弃城而走，但我仍可用他的腰牌暂时调度巡捕，营救灾民。

Cheng Heguang: I will aid you in any way I can.
程和光：我会留在这里，做我力所能及之事。

Paper Heron: But this is no ordinary crisis. I cannot guarantee your safety.
鹭鸶剪：此事非同小可，你若要来，九死一生。

Cheng Heguang: All the more reason.
程和光：我会来。

Cheng Heguang: I'll come find you once I instruct the other constables to evacuate the townsfolk.
程和光：安排好这边，我便会去找你，你要保重。

Seeing the young man's resolve, Paper Heron nods.
面前的青年字字决绝，鹭鸶剪便也不再劝诫。

Paper Heron: Be careful.
鹭鸶剪：保重。

They exchange a quick glance. Chéng Héguāng turns and leaps back into the burning ruins. Paper Heron casts an incantation and vanishes from the spot.
短暂的相视过后，程和光毅然转身踏入了废墟与火焰，而鹭鸶剪伸手掐诀，消失在了原地。

不复还
No Turning Back SU-20

Mei Tree, Ancient Zhu County
古祝县·梅花树下

Lightning tears through the thick clouds, shaking the earth with each strike.
道道闪电劈开厚重的云雾，激得大地战栗。

Master Rén stands before the Mei tree, unmoved by the clashing of earth and sky. Her students sit around her in a ring with muted, fearful reverence. Mayfly is among them, sitting at the front.
即使天地变色，任仙子仍挺立于梅花树前，而以惠姑为首的梅花教众则安然围坐于梅花树下。

Master Ren: This Mei tree has ever been the root of our school, and now, it is the key to our greatest triumph.
任仙子：立教以来，这棵梅花树便是本派之根基，也是你们长生之寄托!

Master Ren: We must protect it at all costs.
任仙子：你们要不惜一切代价看护好它。

Master Ren: Now, on my command: Form the array.
任仙子：现在，听我号令——起阵！

School of Mei Believers: By nature's might, evil be purged!
梅花教信徒众：天地自然！秽气分散！

School of Mei Believers: By nature's might, evil be purged!
梅花教信徒众：天地自然！秽气分散！

As the believers channel their energy into the array, the ground shakes violently and a massive sinkhole opens around them, swallowing sand and stones. Soon after, water wells up from the pit, forming into a lake.
随着信徒们催动法阵，大地猛然颤动，随后凹陷成天坑，砂石如被巨口吞没，天坑内竟显出一个湖。

Golden rays shoot out from the lake, projecting daylight onto the clouds like a rising sun.
那湖射出金光，如在云上又映出了一个太阳。

Master Ren: Ahahahaha. "The balance will be broken, and the sun and moon shall share the sky," so that's what the warning was about.
任仙子：哈哈，日月同天，原来是这么回事。

Master Ren: The beast has battled with the White Horse School for a millennium. But today, it will die by my hand.
任仙子：揽诸与那白马派缠斗千年，何曾想到今日会了结于我手！

Yam: But where is the beast?
山药精：可……揽诸，在哪里呢?

Master Ren: Its body has long merged with the land. This very lake is its eye, the only part we may yet reach.
任仙子：那揽诸早与涣州大地融为一体，这个湖便是它的瞳孔，是我们唯一可以接触它的地方。

Master Ren: The time has come. Let it begin.
任仙子：时候到了！起阵！

Master Ren: Through the might of all eight powers, we harness the flow of Qi!
任仙子：八方威神，以气化形！

Master Rén begins an incantation and chants. A typhoon erupts around her, whipping their new lake into a frothing whirlpool.
任仙子掐诀念咒，飓风骤起，吹得湖面掀起涟漪。

Beneath the golden shimmer, a Bagua array appears at the lake's edge, locking it down like a cage of light.
金光熠熠，湖的外围现出一个八卦阵，如天罗地网般死死地扣住了湖。

Master Ren: This Quelling Array has been the work of decades. Once it begins, there will be no escape for Lǎnzhū. Its death is certain.
任仙子：我花数十年研究出这“镇殃大阵”，只要阵成，揽诸便会毙亡！

Master Ren: With it, I will reach my goal, even without the sword.
任仙子：无需长生剑，我也有万无一失的后手！

Suddenly, Yam vanishes. In the smoke, a red light breaks through.
山药精兀然消失，烟雾之中，一道红光破空袭来。

Paper Heron: Begone!
鹭鸶剪：开！

Master Rén leaps to dodge the attack, but Paper Heron's paper slips prove faster, and a few pieces tear at her robe's hem.
任仙子身形一跃，但鹭鸶剪的剪纸骤然散开，仍有几片割破了她的衣角。

Master Ren: Stop her.
任仙子：拦住她！

Badger: Yes, Master.
獾子精：是！

Several students form a defensive line. Long swords pointing out at the two.
言罢，几名弟子施剑摆出防御的法阵，数柄长剑刺向两人。

Hedgehog: You'll have to get past us first, Heron.
刺猬精：我们不会让你们妨碍任仙子！

Paper Heron: Stand back. I'm not here to fight you.
鹭鸶剪：退下，我无意伤害你们！

Yet the Yao don't move. They stare at Paper Heron expectantly.
但精怪们纹丝不动，只是紧盯着鹭鸶剪。

Cheng Heguang: Take this!
程和光：——还有我！

Silver streaks flash in, breaking the standoff. The Yao are helpless to deflect the sudden barrage of needles.
对峙间，数道银光射来，精怪们反应不及，即使拨落大部分的铁针，还是漏了几根。

Master Ren: Aghh!
任仙子：呃啊！

Hedgehog: Master!
刺猬精：仙子！

Though it was only a brief moment of distraction, Master Rén staggers against the immense pressure crushing down on her.
仅是分神一瞬，任仙子便觉得身上猛然负压千钧之力。

Badger: Hold the line!
獾子精：固防！

Before the Yao can react, Chéng Héguāng drives his blade into the Quelling Array, seeking an opening to strike its core.
趁群妖还没回过神来，程和光操纵着铁刃刺穿“镇殃大阵”的阵型，寻机靠近阵眼。

Master Ren: Agh! Protect the array!
任仙子：啊————护阵！

Paper Heron: Stop this now, Rén! If the array shatters ...
鹭鸶剪：任仙子，收手吧！若是阵破……

Paper Heron: It will bring about your annihilation.
鹭鸶剪：你只会被反噬，神形俱灭！

Master Ren: Enough talk.
任仙子：闭嘴！

Master Ren: There's nothing you can do to stop me. Get out of my way!
任仙子：鹭鸶剪，你不能理解我等之伟望，就别来坏事！

With an earth-shattering scream, Master Rén's body shrivels up like a burst grape. Blood-stained fragments scattering apart like Mei petals. The wind reveals her human form and buries the fallen believers.
破天的长啸中，任仙子的身形急速地萎缩。染血的碎屑如梅花般漫天飘散，风吹出了她人类的模样，也埋葬了逝去的教徒们。

Paper Heron struggles to reach Mayfly.
鹭鸶剪勉力近到惠姑身旁。

Paper Heron: Mayfly, you mustn't feed any more of your Qi to the array. You're draining yourself away.
鹭鸶剪：惠姑！你的气已接近亏空，再渡下去，会透支你自己的性命！你会死！

Mayfly: I ...
惠姑：我……

She reaches out desperately, trying to pull her little friend to safety.
鹭鸶剪急切地伸过手去，想将惠姑带离。

Yet Mayfly doesn't move.
惠姑却仍是立在原地。

Mayfly: I can't turn back now, Heron.
惠姑：……太晚了，鹭鸶剪。

Struggling, she pulls the amulet from her pocket and lays it beside her along with that wrinkled note.
她艰难地从口袋里掏出草结护符，和那张皱巴巴的纸条一同放在了身侧。

Mayfly: Thank you for helping me get this far.
惠姑：这一路上，谢谢你曾经帮过我。

Mayfly: I-I wanted this. I wanted to try. I have no regrets.
惠姑：我……求仁得仁，不后悔走上这条路。

She slumps over, unable to even pull herself up, yet she raises her head and looks toward Paper Heron.
惠姑几近支撑不住，但依旧坚持抬起头，望向鹭鸶剪的方向。

Master Ren: Good, sister. Let go now. Your wish has been fulfilled.
任仙子：——走吧，孩子，你已求得了长生。

Master Rén struggles to her feet, clinging to the array, unwilling to abandon her chance at ascension.
任仙子挣扎起身，却仍是不愿放弃成仙，苦苦维持着阵法。

The wind whips and howls around the lake. Then, as her Qi at last runs out, Mayfly's body collapses.
湖周围的飓风愈加猛烈，在气被渡尽的瞬间，惠姑身子一晃，倒下了。

The amulet and note are swept up in the typhoon and torn to shreds.
护符和纸条被尽数卷入飓风中，撕得粉碎。

Paper Heron: Mayfly!
鹭鸶剪：……惠姑！

Cheng Heguang: Heron, watch out!
程和光：鹭鸶剪！

She loses focus for only a moment, but it's enough time for several blades to strike at her. Chéng Héguāng whirls around and blocks them with the sheath of his blade.
在鹭鸶剪闪神的瞬间，数把剑围攻了过来。程和光反身，以刀鞘扛下这击。

Her strength fails her. Paper Heron suddenly feels as if the sword in her hand were as heavy as a mule.
望着这一切，鹭鸶剪觉得自己手中的剑仿佛千斤沉重，再也抬不起来。

Paper Heron: I ...
鹭鸶剪： 我……

Black clouds press down against the sky. Thunder rolls. The earth tears open and slams shut. Sheets of coarse sand billow through the air. Huanzhou is lost.
黑云压境，天雷滚滚，地面裂开又合上，砂土如面粉般被扬起，涣州已涣。

Cries of anguish fill the streets. Even the constables can barely protect themselves. There is no place left to run.
哀鸿遍野，巡检们亦自顾不暇，这世间早已无一处是安宁之地。

Behind Master Rén, more Yao fall. Fox, Hare, Butterfly ...
任仙子的身后不停地有人在倒下，狐妖、兔女、小蝶虫……

Paper Heron looks to Mayfly's spot. Nothing remains there but a tuft of reeds, trampled by other frantic Yao.
鹭鸶剪望向惠姑倒下的地方，那里早已没了人形，只剩下一根芦草，被无序的众妖踩踏着。

What is lost can never be recovered.
一切生死，都已无可回转。

Paper Heron: ...
鹭鸶剪： ……

Countless torn fragments swirl around, caught in the raging typhoon.
在席卷天地的飓风中，飘荡着无数的、被撕裂的碎片。

They drift past her like everything in the world always has, leaving nothing marked on her stone heart.
这些碎片像往常一样自她的世界飘过，却没有在石头上留下任何波澜。

Paper Heron: Why?
鹭鸶剪： 为何?

Paper Heron: Why come all this way in seeking to extend your life, only to give it up so easily?
鹭鸶剪： 为何你们要到这里来……？为何你们如此孤注一掷，本是追求长生，又反而为此抛却性命?

Paper Heron: Why must you come to this world, only to leave it so soon?
鹭鸶剪： 为何你们要短暂热烈地来到世上，然后又如疾风骤雨一般死去……?

A question that might as well be asked to all living things.
天地万物。芸芸众生。

She stands alone in the air, holding the Longevity Sword. The world around her has become a void of darkness.
她静默地抱着长生剑，独立于空中。四下皆是空濛的虚无。

Paper Heron: I spent so long trapped inside that tree that I forgot what it felt like to be a part of the world.
鹭鸶剪： 我在那株梅树中待得太久，久到退化成了一颗石头。人间的声色，从此与我无关。

Paper Heron: Joy, sorrow, and pain became like distant memories.
鹭鸶剪： 可石头应是无喜无悲、无知无觉的。

Paper Heron: But what is this bitterness that racks my heart now?
鹭鸶剪： 若我真是一颗石头，我为何总是感到如此痛苦，以至于一刻都不能忍受?

She lowers her head and examines the sword in her hands.
鹭鸶剪低下头，看向手中莹莹的白玉剑。

Some of the Qi stored inside the Longevity Sword flows out into the array, pulled through the air like silk drawn from a cocoon.
储存在长生剑中的气，此刻也在术阵中逸散了一些，如蚕茧抽丝般浮在空中。

Pearl Finch: Come, Heron, come. You must be starved after that detention. I've saved you some taro. Best not let the master see it.
师姐：来来来，师妹！看你关禁闭这么久，特地给你留的一碗桂花糖芋头……千万别告诉师父！

Master: Cheeky little rascal. I hope no one finds out you were my student on your travels.
师父：顽劣！到时出外游历，闯出祸来，可莫把师父和几位师兄师姐说出去！

Master Ren: You-You saved my life. I swear I will repay you. I'll do whatever it takes.
任仙子：……是，是您从天雷中救了我……恩人！我将永生永世报答……

Paper Heron: ...
鹭鸶剪：……

Mayfly: So? How is it? Amazing, right? I told you it's delicious.
惠姑：怎…怎么样，鹭鸶剪？这桂花糯米糕好吃吗……对吧！我就讲，一定很甜吧?

Mayfly: I-I wanted this. I wanted to try. I have no regrets.
惠姑：我……求仁得仁，不后悔走上这条路……

White Horse School Students: Over here, Heron. Under the Mei tree.
白马派众人：快过来，到梅树边来——！

Master: Remember, Paper Heron. In the end, we need only answer to our conscience.
师父：鹭鸶剪，记住。我辈问心无愧。

The scenes she replayed countless times over a hundred years now vanish from her in a single moment.
诸多画面，她曾在这百年间反复回想，如今不过一瞬，便云散烟消。

Paper Heron tilts her head back, and a single tear shatters against the sheath.
鹭鸶剪感慨地仰起头，一滴泪水撞碎在剑鞘之上。

Paper Heron: I understand now.
鹭鸶剪：我明白了……

Paper Heron: It wasn't my isolation that numbed my senses. It was regret.
鹭鸶剪：困住我的并非石头，而是极度的悔恨。

Paper Heron: For a hundred years, it was the only thing I knew.
鹭鸶剪：因为这悔恨是我被封在树里的百年中，唯一切实拥有的东西。

She draws the Longevity Sword from its sheath, her hand slow and deliberate, revealing the white jade blade.
她轻轻地抽去了长生剑的剑鞘，露出了白玉的剑身。

Paper Heron: The beast's rage has grown beyond control. Whether Rén ascends or not, Huanzhou will fall to ruin. Unless ...
鹭鸶剪：揽诸已被激怒。任仙子升仙无论成败，涣州城都将分崩离析。除非……

All things return to their beginning.
除非一切由何而起，便由何而终。

Paper Heron: Master, now I understand why I survived.
鹭鸶剪：师父、师姐、师兄。现在我终于明白，为何是我从你们中活下来。

Paper Heron: I have an unfinished purpose. And now, I will realize it.
鹭鸶剪：因为我还有未竟之命，而那一刻就是现在。

She grips the Longevity Sword with both hands. A crack forms across the blade.
鹭鸶剪双手用力握住剑身，长生剑现出了裂痕。

Paper Heron: Only one who witnessed the first seal as it was forged long ago can see this done.
鹭鸶剪：只有见证过当年灭门的白马派弟子，才能重现那一日的封印，结束这场天地浩劫。

Far beneath her, Master Rén takes notice of the change in her former teacher.
天幕下，任仙子第一时间注意到了鹭鸶剪的异样。

Master Ren: Heron, what do you think you're doing?
任仙子：住手！鹭鸶剪，你想干什么?!

Master Ren: If you shatter the sword, those Yao will have died for nothing, and the White Horse School will be gone forever.
任仙子：你想让他们白死吗？你难道没有长进吗!？你可知此剑一折，世间再无白马派?!

Yet the howling wind drowns out her cry.
呼啸而过的烈风盖过了任仙子的呼喊。

Paper Heron: If the sword breaks, the Method of Longevity will die with it.
鹭鸶剪：这把剑若也折断，世间便再无长生之法，那些精怪们也再无延年益寿之路可走。

Paper Heron: And the legacy of the White Horse School will be forever lost.
鹭鸶剪：白马派的最后一把遗物，亦将就此毁去。

Master Ren: Heron, you'll never forgive yourself for this.
任仙子：鹭鸶剪！你想好了！

Master Ren: Shatter the sword, and everything here will be sealed for another hundred years or more, your new friend included.
任仙子：你若折了那剑，便又会被封印上百年，还连带着那程和光!

Cheng Heguang: Do it!
程和光：折就折！

Cheng Heguang: If you believe it is necessary, do not hold back.
程和光：做你想做的，我来挡住她！

Master Ren: You're mad. How could you be willing to seal yourself into that tree again?
任仙子：你疯了！你好不容易从那里出来，还想再回去当块石头不成!!!

Paper Heron: For years, I have dwelled on the day my master shattered the first sword, trying to understand his thoughts, his fears, his hopes.
鹭鸶剪：漫长时光里我苦苦追求的，也许只是师父当年折断长生剑时那一刻的心情罢了。

Paper Heron: My mind is set, even if I must give up my senses and become like stone again.
鹭鸶剪：即使此后我将永远重返石头的世界……我也可作为一颗石头活下去。

Paper Heron: Like him, once again, I will shatter the sword.
鹭鸶剪：——这一次，我来折剑。

Paper Heron: And like him, once again, I will feel no regret.
鹭鸶剪：——这一次，我不后悔。

Paper Heron: See you in a hundred years.
鹭鸶剪：百年后见。

致此离离
Goodbye, Friend SU-21

Paper Heron: See you in a hundred years.
鹭鸶剪：百年后见。

That familiar voice from a hundred years ago fades in the wind. Before the Mei tree, a figure materializes.
熟悉的声音在风中低了下去。百年前的风声散去后，梅树前浮出一道身影。

The image grows more solid and vivid, exactly as Reed saw in the memories.
这影像越发凝实，生动，与芦草结在故事中所见的如出一辙。

Reed: Heron!
芦草结：……鹭鸶剪！

As her form solidifies, Reed can't suppress a gasp.
看到那道身影时，芦草结不禁惊呼出声。

Reed: I-I get it now. Those Wind Knots were frozen by the power of the Longevity Sword, that's why the Windweave's been experiencing so much interference.
芦草结：难怪她会让我解开所有系结，难怪城里会有风网扰动！这些系结，是当年被长生剑凝滞的风！

Reed: And Heron, she's been trapped here for all these years?
芦草结：这就是长生之法的真相……难道她从此之后就一直被封在此地?

Mule: Bray!
骡子：咴……！

The mule trots out happily, eager to bring its friends, old and new, together at last.
骡子欣喜地小跑两步，迫不及待地想引领两位老朋友在现实中的首次会面。

Seeing Reed frozen in place, it gently tugs at her, taking a blade of grass on her head into its mouth.
见芦草结半天不动，便叼住她头顶草叶，轻轻拉扯起来。

Paper Heron: Stop that. She's not a snack.
鹭鸶剪：去。她可不是你的食物。

She laughs. The old mule reluctantly trots aside and lingers behind the Mei tree.
主人家笑了笑，老骡不情愿地朝一旁退去，小跑到梅树后。

Paper Heron: It is good to finally see you in person, Reedit.
鹭鸶剪：——终于见面了，“小小草”。

Paper Heron: I sincerely apologize for the trouble. There was little I could do from within the seal. You look well, though. I'm glad.
鹭鸶剪：因为阵法阻隔的缘故，让你辛苦了。很高兴你看起来过得还不错。

Reed: When you said you'd find me, I didn't think you meant like this.
芦草结：你说你自会找我……没想到是以这种形式见面。

Reed: It was you, wasn't it? The wind, the paper notes, you used them to guide me here, didn't you?
芦草结：如果我没猜错，那些风，还有给我指明方向的纸页，应该都是你做的?

Paper Heron: I did. I believe you've seen this little Qi trick a few times by now.
鹭鸶剪：嗯，多亏了望气的小把戏，你应该见过很多次。

Paper Heron: Within the seal, I was unable to communicate with the outside world, until those curious strings were put up.
鹭鸶剪：那场大战之后，我就一直被封在这梅花树中，无法与外界沟通。直到几年前，人们来这里拉了一些奇怪的线。

She raises her finger and points first at the old Mei tree and then at the telephone pole standing next to its canopy.
鹭鸶剪抬手指了指头顶的老梅树，以及树冠不远处的水泥电线杆。

Paper Heron: An odd Qi runs through them, one I found I could control. That's how I got on the forum.
鹭鸶剪：这些黑色的线里游走着一股股特殊的“气”，我的神秘术可以御使它们，所以才能在论坛上和你联系。

Reed listens, making mental notes of her questions, until she arrives at a realization.
芦草结一头雾水地听着，随后忽然明了了什么。

Reed: Strings? You mean the cables? You're telling me you can connect to the Internet through Qi?
芦草结：你是说电流和信号？你的神秘术……可以让你通过这些光缆连接互联网？

Paper Heron: It is a remarkable technology. Though at times, the Qi would disappear.
鹭鸶剪：或许吧？我不确定。不过，毕竟是受困于此，这些气有时候会忽然消失。

Paper Heron: When that happened, I could no longer reach you.
鹭鸶剪：这些时候我就没法看到你，也没法和你交流。

Reed: Well, as much as I'd like to dive into it—I really, really would—let's save it for another time, kinda on a deadline here.
芦草结：好吧，虽然我很想采访你，但那估计是另一篇报道了——抱歉，我的时间真的很紧迫。

She stops and stares at Paper Heron.
她站定了脚步，认真地望着鹭鸶剪。

Reed: I did what you asked, Heron. I untied all the knots.
芦草结：鹭鸶剪，按照我们说好的，我解开了所有风结。

Reed: Now it's time for you to hold up your end of the deal.
芦草结：该轮到你履行承诺，给我答案了。

Reed: Only, you said that the Method would die along with the sword. So, you never really planned on passing it on to me, huh?
芦草结：你亲口说过，长生剑折断，长生之法也随之断绝。那你先前在论坛上说的什么传法、什么线索，都是在骗我吗?

Reed: Or by "teach me," did you mean showing me your story in the Wind Knots?
芦草结：还是说，这些风结里的故事……就是你想告诉我的全部?

She studies Reed. Her smile and tone are just as Reed remembers—light and warm.
鹭鸶剪打量着她，笑容和语气都像芦草结曾看到的那样，轻快而温和。

Paper Heron: You are so very much like her.
鹭鸶剪：你果然和她一样。

Reed: Her?
芦草结：……和她?

Paper Heron: Mayfly. She too was a reed, sprouting in spring, withering by winter.
鹭鸶剪：我知道的，你就像惠姑一样，是短生之种。春生冬死，命数极短。

Paper Heron: And just like her, you move with haste in every single moment.
鹭鸶剪：你果然也像她一样急切。

A name that they both know lingers in the air, stirring up memories and melancholy.
那个她们都很熟悉的名字引出了编辑眼中的怀念和怅惘。

Reed: Mayfly ...
芦草结：惠姑……她……

Paper Heron: That's why I reached out when I saw your post. Fate really seems determined to bring your kind to me.
鹭鸶剪：也是因为这点，我才在 BBS 上联络了你。看来我和你们这一族的缘分，还远远没有结束。

Paper Heron: There's one last knot. I want you to be the one to undo it.
鹭鸶剪：这段长达四百年的因果，还要由你来解开。

Reed: Another one? But didn't I already ...
芦草结：解开……？可是风结不是全部已经……

Paper Heron: The story has yet to come to an end. The Method of Longevity didn't truly die with the sword.
鹭鸶剪：不是的，一切还未真正结束。长生之法，也并未真正断绝。

Paper Heron: When I shattered it, I truly didn't expect I'd ever wake again. I thought the Method of Longevity would die with me.
鹭鸶剪：当年我以为自己将永久沉眠于梅花树中，便以为长生之法也将随我一同消失。

Paper Heron: And even less that I'd be awakened by this new Qi.
鹭鸶剪：没想到世事更新，多亏了你和人类的新发明，我才能重现于世。

With a sigh, she brushes the old Mei tree as if closing a door behind her.
她感慨地抚上落灰的老梅树。

Paper Heron: The sword may be gone, but it was nothing more than a vessel. Now that I've returned, the Method of Longevity lives on.
鹭鸶剪：长生剑只是器物，只要我在，便仍有长生之法。

Paper Heron: And I shall pass it on to you, as thanks for your help.
鹭鸶剪：这也是我真正要予以你的报答。

Reed: ...!!!
芦草结：……!!!

Her heartbeat quickens in her chest.
她听到自己的心跳骤然分明了起来。

Reed: I ...
芦草结：这……

Paper Heron: Don't be afraid. It sounds complicated, but it only takes a moment to grasp.
鹭鸶剪：别怕，这法门听着玄妙，实际上不过一瞬而已。

Paper Heron: You've returned me to life. Please, allow me to extend yours.
鹭鸶剪：我在梅树中等了四百年，是你给了我重生的希望。我知道，你一直执着于长生的故事，就是在寻求这个答案。

She smiles and extends her hand, then nods to Reed.
她微笑着伸出手，向芦草结点了点头。

Paper Heron: Now, give me your hand.
鹭鸶剪：来吧，我将法门传授于你。

The answer she has pursued across lifetimes finally within reach.
一直以来追寻的答案马上就要落入掌中。

Yet now that it's here, Reed feels an inexplicable panic.
面对此情此景，芦草结忽然感到了没来由的惶惑。

Reed: Are you ... Are you for real, like, really real?
芦草结：我……真的可以吗?

Paper Heron: Having second thoughts?
鹭鸶剪：害怕了？你会后悔吗?

Reed touches her own hair with anxiety. More blades of grass, each one growing yellower with each passing day, fall to the ground.
芦草结用力抓了抓头发，比几天前更枯黄的苇叶因此摇落一地。

Paper Heron: I would never wish to pressure you. An offer like this could take time to process.
鹭鸶剪：也是……对我来说，那是四百年前的过往。对你来说，却只是方才的幻境。

Paper Heron: Perhaps you feel differently about longevity now, after seeing what happened to Mayfly.
鹭鸶剪：看完了这样的故事，知道了惠姑最后的命运……也许你会有新的想法。

Paper Heron withdraws her hand and waits for Reed's answer.
鹭鸶剪收回了手，静静地等待着芦草结的回答。

Paper Heron: Do you still wish for more time in this world, little reed?
鹭鸶剪：小小草，在知晓了这一切后，你还会继续追寻长生吗?

She reflects on the question for a long while. A moment later, she raises her head slowly and firmly.
芦草结沉默了一会儿，而后，她缓慢而坚定地抬起头来。

Reed: I do.
芦草结：我会。

Reed: I know my time's short, but I still have a life to live, just like anyone else, and I have the right to live as long as I can.
芦草结：尽管我们的时间不过一个四季，但生命都予以了我和我的族群尽情去追求它的权利。我们乐于这样做，也勇于这样做。

Reed: Even if it's hard, even if it's impossible, I can't stop just because I'm scared.
芦草结：无论长生是真正存在，或只是一个骗局。我都不会因为未知的结果和恐惧，就放弃这份追寻本身。

Reed: I want to live, to see more, write more, experience more.
芦草结：我想要活下去，我想见更多未曾见过的景象，写出更好的报道，想成为众多“芦草结”中取得成功的那一个。

Reed: I'll do anything to have one more day, one more hour, even one more minute to live.
芦草结：这是只属于我的生命旅程。我当然也希望能延长它，哪怕只是多一小时，一分钟！

She steps forward with growing certainty.
芦草结向前一步。

Reed: I know that the "me" who sprouts next spring will be "me" in some way, but she'll never be "me." My goals, my experiences, my thoughts, my work ... They'll be lost forever.
芦草结：即使寻求的事物一致，即使走上同一条路，我的经历，我的思想，我写下的报道也永远不会与谁全然相同。

Reed: And even if that Reed continues to sprout across a thousand lives, it will never be me again.
芦草结：世上有许多苇草，而我也只是我。

Reed: So I'll keep looking, till my last leaves have withered away.
芦草结：所以我仍会继续追寻长生，直到抵达旅途的终点。

Reed: At least then, I can go without any regrets.
芦草结：无论结局为何，我都不会后悔。

Paper Heron's response begins with surprise, but soon, her face adopts that familiar smile, serene and wistful.
鹭鸶剪微微讶异，继而面露赞许。

Paper Heron: Well said!
鹭鸶剪：好！

Paper Heron: Many have held back for fear of the risks. It's rare to see someone with such remarkable courage.
鹭鸶剪：这世上瞻前顾后举棋不定的庸类太多了，已经很少见你这样有志气的精怪。

Paper Heron: I am glad to have at last found the right person.
鹭鸶剪：你能不昧本心，这很好，我没有看错人。

She extends her hand a second time, offering Reed a sincere invitation.
她向着芦草结二次伸出了手，递过一个相当诚挚的邀请。

Paper Heron: Then repeat after me: In the vastness between heaven and earth, all things will bow to my measure.
鹭鸶剪：跟我念——天地无极，任我裁量。

Reed reaches for the ending and answer she has yearned for. Her fingers meet the rough bark.
芦草结向着她渴望的结局和答案伸出手。她的手指往前，碰触到了粗糙的树干。

Reed: In the vastness between heaven and earth, all things will bow to my measure.
芦草结：天地无极，任我裁量。

Frozen wind cascades from her fingertips, then begins to flow.
凝固的风在她指尖重重下坠，而后开始缓缓流动。

Suddenly, the illusion before her eyes shatters. Another unexpected figure emerges from within, laughing.
眼前的幻影倏然散开，另一道未曾设想的凝实身影大笑着从中走出。

???: Ahahaha ... Finally, after all this time!
???：终于让我等到了这一天！

The figure beneath the Mei tree brushes away the ash from her shoulder.
梅树下的人随意拍了拍肩头，拂去了一丁点儿尘土。

Reed steps back in shock. The name falters on her tongue, as if she's unable to believe it herself.
芦草结下意识地朝后退去。她万分惊异，以至于无法立刻从一片空白的脑海中找出那个名字。

Reed: You-You're Rén!
芦草结：你是——任仙子?

Master Ren: Indeed. Now, come and pay respect to your master.
任仙子：不错。你倒是与他们不同，尚且讲几分情义，还识得允诺你传法的恩人。

Reed: So it was you who sent those messages on the forum, not Heron?
芦草结：你骗我?！在论坛上一直联系我的人，并不是鹭鸶剪……

Reed: And I've, I've just ...
芦草结：天啊，那我——

Reed staggers, the depth of her mistake striking her with the force of a heavy blow.
编辑震惊地后退一步，意识到自己犯了一个天大的错误。

Master Rén's smile grows mad and overwide, unconcerned by her fear.
任仙子微微一笑，似乎对她的惊惶全不在意。

Master Ren: There's no need to be afraid. I may have used Paper Heron's name to bring you here, but I did not lie about the Method of Longevity. I will guide you to it, if you wish.
任仙子：我虽假借了她的名号，但授法一事却从无欺瞒。你既助我脱困，我这便带你长生。

She reaches for Reed's forehead.
她向芦草结额前伸出手去。

But her hand meets nothing but air.
这只手落空了。

Reed: You-You did all this to bring me here, just to make me your student? Why?
芦草结：……我做了什么，值得你这样大费周章?!

Reed: What're you trying to do?
芦草结：你又在策划些什么阴谋？！

Her question is met with a mocking laugh.
她的质问换来了一声嗤笑。

Master Ren: Hmph. I had hoped you were wise enough to not mistake my kindness for malice.
任仙子：呵，又是一个一生所求近在眼前，却畏葸不前的鼠辈。

Master Ren: All this fuss over a borrowed name, and yet you overlook the truth. I am your only hope to attain longevity.
任仙子：事到如今，你何须在意细枝末节？无论何人，赐法于你之人，才能应你所求！

Master Ren: Everything has a price. If longevity is what you desire, you must take the risk and pay it.
任仙子：凡有所求，又怎会没有代价！既有所求，为何又在此刻畏首畏尾?

Master Ren: I came so close back then. Lǎnzhū would have been long dead if Heron hadn't stood in my way.
任仙子：百年前那一次谋求，我本就已聚得了足够的气，重伤揽诸。没想到鹭鸶剪一意孤行，全然不顾此地众生。

Master Ren: I never thought she would be mad enough to shatter her school's legacy just to seal me away.
任仙子：她折了法剑，救下揽诸，令此地气息滞涩，令我与她沉睡至今，整整四百年！

The rising wind nearly swallows up her words.
呼啸的风声几乎压过了她的声音。

Master Ren: So much time has passed. None who remember those days now live. Only you and I.
任仙子：……四百年过去，当年其他人早已化作飞灰。

But now even the howl of the wind is lost beneath the roar of cracking earth.
但这风声很快又被土地崩裂、震颤的响动盖去。

Master Ren: All those lives wasted because of her!
任仙子：你当知晓，若鹭鸶剪未曾横加阻拦，诸多小妖的牺牲本不会被白白浪费！

Reed: You're not gonna ...
芦草结：你难道想……

Ignoring Reed's shock, Master Rén flicks her sleeve sharply, and a patch of ground near the Mei tree's roots sinks.
罔顾芦草结的惊愕，任仙子猛然拂动衣袖，梅树根系附近的一小片地面陷落下去。

Water surges from the cracks between rock and soil, carrying panicked fish along with it.
从岩层与泥土的缝隙中涌出水流，甚至偶有几条惊慌的游鱼。

Master Ren: If those "cables" hadn't been built, I wouldn't have awoken so soon. For that, I am grateful.
任仙子：祝县众人，于此地铺设法宝，无意间引了一线生机给我，我便收敛些力道，不至于毁伤他们的屋舍。

Master Ren: Ahahaha ... I should thank you, too, for untying those knots and freeing me from the seal.
任仙子：你解开风结，打通揽诸身上的气穴。天地气顺，我也得了解脱——我自然要谢你！

Master Ren: You see, unlike Master Heron, I ensure those who aid me are properly repaid.
任仙子：忘恩负义之辈，岂能假称仙人！

Master Ren: Come here.
任仙子：过来！

She yanks Reed close. Qi gathers in her right hand as she aims at the newly formed lake.
她拉过芦草结，右手聚起气息，对准了眼前凭空生出的湖泊。

Leaves fall like rain from the tree as the earth buckles. Ripples bounce across the water.
树叶摇落，土地震颤，水面荡起一圈圈波纹。

And the water continues to rise.
湖水仍在上涨。

Master Ren: Today the beast will fall, and I will ascend triumphant.
任仙子：今日诛杀这揽诸，我便夺了它的气，谋得长生！

Reed: ...!
芦草结：——！

The lake overflows, soaking the parched yellow grass around it. The chaos of the scene matches the mounting panic surging through Reed's body.
湖水如同芦草结的恐惧一般满溢而出，澄澈的清水无情地淹过干黄的枯草，而大地的颤动使它们抖得都如筛子一般。

Forgetting everything else, she grabs at Master Rén's arm.
顾不得其他，编辑猛地拽住任仙子的胳膊。

Reed: Stop! You can't do this!
芦草结：停下，这里的人是无辜的！

Reed: Rén!
芦草结：任仙子——

She stumbles, almost falling into the lake.
她打了个趔趄，险些跌落到湖中。

Just as the visions showed, Lǎnzhū's eyes were once a lake at this very spot.
和过往影像所示的一般，揽诸的眼睛本是此地的一片湖水。

Now after centuries of slumber, it awakens.
在数百年的沉睡后，它终于要醒来了。

Reed: I can't let her ...
芦草结：等等……！

The wind cries.
风声。

Reed: ... destroy the city.
芦草结：不能……灾难……

A gale rushes toward the center of the lake.
风朝湖面中心席卷而去。

Signs and awnings, bikes and roof shingles, everything the wind touches is pulled up in the rush.
周遭的万事万物都被呼啸而过的劲风撕扯着。

Reed: I have to do something.
芦草结：我必须……拦住……

But she can't reach her.
但她根本无法再次抵达任仙子近旁。

It's too late now.
一切已无可挽回。

???: No need to worry.
???：不必忧心。

Reed: Huh?
芦草结：……谁?

Somewhere in the groaning of the wind, she catches a faint, familiar voice.
在猎猎作响的风中，她捕捉到了细微的，熟悉的声音。

???: Every creature, whether beast or man, wishes for more time in this world.
???：凡有生者，大多渴望存续。追求长生，亦是万物本能。

???: But know this: Those at their peak will decline, and those that have fallen will rise, for it is the Way to take from those in excess and give to those who lack. When Lǎnzhū sleeps, the world around it thrives; when it awakens, the world falls into ruin. All is in balance.
???：过盛则衰，枯后则荣。揽诸想活下去，是它的本能。它苏醒时伴随灾难，却也自在这套规律流转之中，能平衡世间气的流动。

???: The workings of Heaven remain constant. There is no need to stop her.
???：天行有常。你无须阻拦她。

Reed doesn't answer. She forces herself forward, the grass blades on her head bending flat against the fierce wind.
芦草结并未应答。她艰难地向前去，头上的草叶在狂风中弯折。

She strains with all her might, but Master Rén has already raised her hand, ready to strike.
她试图尽一点微小的气力，但任仙子已经抬起手，准备击下最后一掌。

Master Ren: It's too late. The beast ends today, and your mission with it.
任仙子：再要分辨是非对错，为时已晚！后世之事，与你我何干!

Master Ren: Haaah!
任仙子：喝!

Reed: Lǎnzhū has awakened.
芦草结：揽诸……睁眼了……

Master Ren: The beast is weak. But my Qi, it flows out from me.
任仙子：我已准备万全，这揽诸如此虚弱……为何气竟在流失……?

Master Ren: What have you done, Heron?
任仙子：——鹭鸶剪，你欺我至此!

Master Ren: I will never ...
任仙子：我……定不会……

Master Ren: ...!
任仙子：——!

Paper Heron: Eight views merge, the mystery of Qi.
鹭鸶剪：八景冥合，炁入玄玄。

Paper Heron: Three lights darken, and all lose their way.
鹭鸶剪：三光无明，皆失其路。

别来无恙
Long Time No See SU-22

Mei Tree, Zhu County
祝县·梅花树下

The rising mist blurs everyone's vision, including that of a terrified, fleeing Critter.
腾起的水雾模糊了所有人的视线，也包括慌张逃窜的魔精。

A hand reaches in and lifts it up with ease, saving it from falling into the growing cracks.
一只手伸来，轻松地拎起了它，使它不至于跌入地面裂缝里。

Paper Heron: ...
鹭鸶剪：……

She remembers when they first met. She had been just as miserable then as she is now.
她想起了第一次与它见面的时刻。她们和现在一样狼狈。

A burning ozone smell hangs in the air. Paper Heron sits beneath the Mei tree and looks up.
焦煳味弥漫在空气中。鹭鸶剪坐在梅树边，望了望头顶。

The lightning is gone. She sighs in relief, then glances toward her feet.
雷光早已隐去了。她松了口气，又看向脚边。

Critter: *whimper*
魔精：……呜。

A black fuzzball, weakened from multiple lightning strikes. Paper Heron looks down at it, pity welling up in her for the creature, despite everything.
望着这挨了几记雷，有气无力的黑黝黝一团，鹭鸶剪思索片刻，随便捡了个跑到嘴边的称呼。

Paper Heron: Psps, come here, little one, come.
鹭鸶剪：咪咪，过来，过来。

Critter: ...?
魔精：……?

Paper Heron: My master always said we should remember the good done to us and find ways to repay it.
鹭鸶剪：我师门有言，行走于世，绝不可沦为忘恩负义之辈。

Paper Heron: You drew that lightning to the Mei tree and freed me from my seal. Though it was an accident, I have reaped its benefits, and for that, I must give you my thanks.
鹭鸶剪：你救我一命，引雷劈开了梅树，放我出来。虽是无意，我也应还你恩情。

Paper Heron: I have nothing of value save the Method. Here.
鹭鸶剪：既身无他物，就授一法门与你。

Paper Heron: Now, be on your way.
鹭鸶剪：你走吧。

She releases the struggling Critter, and it runs swiftly into the distant grass before vanishing from sight.
她放下挣扎的魔精。它飞快地消失在了远处的草丛里。

Paper Heron raises her head. Another figure is walking toward her through the mist.
鹭鸶剪抬起头，另一个身影正穿过水雾，朝她靠近。

Reed: ...
芦草结：……

The editor studies this new woman with a familiar face, cautious not to make the same mistake.
编辑谨慎地打量着她。

Reed: Paper Heron? Is that you?
芦草结：……鹭鸶剪?

Reed: Is it really you?
芦草结：我应该不会再认错人吧……

Mule: Whinny ...
骡子：咴……

The old mule, inexplicably safe despite all the calamity, trots over and whinnies affectionately.
刚才不知躲去何处的老骡小跑过来，亲昵地唤了几声。

Paper Heron pats its head and smiles at Reed.
鹭鸶剪拍了拍它的脑袋，朝芦草结露出一个微笑。

Paper Heron: Yes, Reedit. It's the real me, this time.
鹭鸶剪：小小草，这次真的是我。

Restaurant, Zhu County
祝县·餐馆

The restaurant by the lake has only just opened for the day, but it's already packed with customers.
湖边的餐馆刚开业不久，生意却异常火爆。

Visitors are willing to pay extra to see this new lake that appeared overnight.
来县里旅游的客人，大都也愿意多花些钱，近距离瞧瞧这片一夜间现出的湖水。

Neighbor I: What did I tell you? This place is blessed. So many bright talents!
街坊 Ⅰ：早说了，咱这里是风水宝地，是出神仙状元的地方！

Neighbor I: See those reporters? We're gonna be on TV.
街坊 Ⅰ：看看看看，上头来调查了对不？都上电视了！

Neighbor II: So much for peace and quiet. I don't get it. What's so special about an old tree and a lake, anyway?
街坊 Ⅱ：弄得吵死喽！那么多人！一个湖，一棵树，有啥好看的?

Waiter: Look on the bright side. Uncle Lǐ's been thinking about getting into the food business lately. With all these visitors, I bet he'll be moving into a big new house in no time. Isn't that right, Lǐ?
服务员：哎，别这么说。李叔这些天做梦也想着餐馆经营，人多了，生意好，他好盖大楼房！

Neighbor I: Haha, sure is. When I've got the place settled, I'll have all of you over for a night of mahjong.
街坊 Ⅰ：买了叫你们上屋里打麻将！

Waiter: We'll be there, and we won't go easy on you at the table.
服务员：好啊，可要赢你钱的，说话得算数！

Neighbor I: Do your worst. Hah-hah!
街坊 Ⅰ：算，怎么不算！

Guests at the corner tables take turns stealing conspicuous glances in their direction.
角落的餐桌边，有人朝这边频频张望着。

The waiter hurries over and sets down a plate of Fuliji Roast Chicken.
服务员赶紧加快步子走来，放下一盘符离集烧鸡。

Reed: Thank you.
芦草结：谢谢。

Waiter: Here on a visit? You don't look like you're from around here.
服务员：别客气。对了，你们是来旅游的吧?

Waiter: We've been getting a lot of visitors lately. Just a heads-up: Watch out for the tourist traps, eh? Some of the souvenirs in the gift shops are pure rubbish.
服务员：镇上最近来了不少人，做小生意的也多，不要乱买工艺品啦，不划算的。

Waiter: Ah, just look at that sword. Exactly what I mean. What a shame. Better off spending your money on local cuisine, I'd say.
服务员：这把剑质量就不行，这都断了。省几个钱，还能多加道菜呢。

Paper Heron: Appreciated! We just tried the duck and snail stew. Maybe Bāo Zhěng's fish next?
鹭鸶剪：那太好了，这次还尝了青螺炖鸭，下次就尝尝招牌的包公鱼!

The waiter turns away. Paper Heron taps the sword gently, but any sound it might make doesn't rise above the chatter of the restaurant.
脚步声远去，餐馆里的谈话声盖过了鹭鸶剪轻叩剑身的声响。

She lets her hand linger over the fractured blade, then picks up their conversation.
她抚了抚那道断口，捡起被搁置的话题。

Paper Heron: So, what did you want to tell me, Reedie?
鹭鸶剪：小小草，你刚才要和我说什么来着?

Reed: Err, it's not a big deal really. I just wanted to say it in person.
芦草结：不算特别重要的事。但我还是得当面告诉你才好。

Reed: I'm sorry, Heron.
芦草结：对不起，鹭鸶剪。

The words pour out bitter and regretful.
编辑郑重地开口。

Reed: I shouldn't have fallen for Rén's trick. I knew something was off about her, but I-I guess I got greedy.
芦草结：我不应该上任仙子的当，放她出来……我本来已经发现了你们语气的不同，最后却还是相信了她。

Reed: If you hadn't come to my rescue in time, I ...
芦草结：如果不是你……

Paper Heron: There, there. It's over now. We needn't worry about what's in the past.
鹭鸶剪：好了，好了。事情都结束了，为何还要苛责自己?

She picks up the sword playfully, weighs it in her hand, then sets it down.
她玩笑般拿起那把剑，在手中掂了掂，又小心放下。

Paper Heron: Long ago, Qi flowed strong in the world, surging and rolling like ocean waves. But now, it has quieted.
鹭鸶剪：过去，天地之中的气像浪潮一般涌动。如今四百年过去，它们已成了平缓的细流。

Paper Heron: It no longer has the force to shake the plains or topple mountains, and the spells drawn from its power have lost much of their might.
鹭鸶剪：摇山撼海的场面不会再有啦。那些术法也早就不复当初的威力。

Paper Heron: Lǎnzhū's power is much the same. That's why things didn't go Rén's way, even though she awakened the beast.
鹭鸶剪：时过境迁，揽诸早已不复从前。任仙子贸然打通气穴，但此时情景早已今非昔比。

Paper Heron: When Lǎnzhū was strong, Rén could draw out its Qi to strengthen herself.
鹭鸶剪：曾经，揽诸强盛，而她不过一画皮小妖，方可吸取揽诸之气，强化自身。

Paper Heron: But the flow of its Qi changed course. It draws in Qi rather than letting it flow out. A necessary balance. This is the Way.
鹭鸶剪：如今揽诸虚弱，气的流势已然改变。当初她从揽诸身上抽得的气，如今加倍还了回去。

Paper Heron: Lǎnzhū is unlikely to cause any disasters for a long time to come. You needn't worry.
鹭鸶剪：此后，揽诸的苏醒不会再造成灾难。你尽可放心。

She leans forward and offers a hand of comfort to Reed.
鹭鸶剪向前探身，拍拍芦草结的肩膀。

Paper Heron: Thanks to you, everything's finally settled. Though I can't help but take a little of the credit. I did do my best to guide you here.
鹭鸶剪：而且，多亏你如我所料，解开了最后的系结，这一切才得以圆满。也不枉我中途一直提示你。

Reed: Hm?
芦草结：咦……？

Reed: Hold on, so, then you really were the one who guided me here? You wanted me to set Rén free from the seal?
芦草结：你一直在默许我解开系结，放出揽诸和任仙子……？

Paper Heron lets the question hang in the air, offering only a knowing smile at first.
鹭鸶剪却没有立刻回答，而是微笑着望向她。

Then she speaks, her answer delicately pruned and insightful.
似乎是斟酌了一会儿词句，最后，她开口了。

Paper Heron: When I saw your post on the forum, I knew that you were a Yao, but I couldn't be sure of what you'd do until you showed up in person.
鹭鸶剪：我刚联系上你时，便隐约有了猜测。在你来到祝县之后，便用望气一法加以确认，知道了你本是苇草。

Paper Heron: Just like Mayfly, I knew you would take any risk to find the Method, and I realized Rén would seize on your desire and exploit it.
鹭鸶剪：我料到你不会放弃长生线索，也料到了任仙子会利用这一点。

Paper Heron: You wouldn't be put off by what you saw in the Wind Knots; I knew you'd see it through to the end.
鹭鸶剪：我也预料到，你即使知道了所有的事，也依然会做出自己的选择。

Paper Heron: So when Rén took my name to approach you on the forum, I didn't stop her, just like I didn't stop her from releasing Lǎnzhū.
鹭鸶剪：所以我任由任仙子顶替我，与你联系，也放任了她先我一步出现在你面前，令揽诸苏醒。

Paper Heron: She would only be returning Qi to its rightful place, not disturbing it.
鹭鸶剪：而后，天地之气，重回流通。一切因果前缘，亦随风消解。

Her voice drops. After a brief pause, she continues.
鹭鸶剪的声音稍稍低了下去。略作停顿之后，她接续上未尽的话题。

Paper Heron: One gains, and the other loses. In the end, what's lost returns to where it is needed, and thus balance is maintained.
鹭鸶剪：每个人的欲望互相交织，然后此消彼长，达成平衡，世事便如此延续。

Paper Heron: Were it not for your resolve, none of this would have come to pass.
鹭鸶剪：是你的坚持，让一切来到了这里。

Paper Heron: And because all who took part in this—you, Rén, me—stood by each of our choices to the end ...
鹭鸶剪：正因为你、我、任仙子，每个卷入其中的人，都不曾后悔，再来千百次，也还会如此选择。

Paper Heron: What started hundreds of years ago could at last come to its rightful end.
鹭鸶剪：诸般因果，才能消却。这个故事才会迎来它最合适的结局。

Paper Heron: So you see, there's no need to apologize. All unfolded as fate intended.
鹭鸶剪：你从来无需道歉。

Reed: I see.
芦草结：……我知道啦。

Reed lets out a long breath. Her grass blades wilt on her head.
编辑如释重负地松了一口气，那些草叶也因此抖落了几分。

Reed: I haven't found longevity, but at least I found a story worth telling.
芦草结：虽然没有得到长生之法，却能参与这一切，留下一篇很好的报道……

Reed: That's good enough for me.
芦草结：对我来说，现在的结局也已经足够圆满。

She can't hide the sting of regret in her voice, but she buries it as best she can.
她的语气中仍有一丝遗憾。但它们很快就轻轻地隐没了。

Yet Paper Heron seizes on it.
鹭鸶剪难得地捕捉到了这点儿变化。

Paper Heron: There's a little more to it, actually.
鹭鸶剪：小小草，我还没说完呢。

Paper Heron: In the spring after Mayfly's death, a green shoot grew from the place where she last stood.
鹭鸶剪：百年前，惠姑倒下的土壤之上，生出了一丛新绿。

Paper Heron: When winter came, it withered, but in each following spring, a sprout grew anew.
鹭鸶剪：其后，她的同族虽然春生冬死，却年年都能从干枯的身躯之中再度抽芽。

Reed: ...!
芦草结：——！

Reed: You mean I'm ...?
芦草结：你是说，现在的我——

Paper Heron: In a way, Mayfly's wish has been fulfilled.
鹭鸶剪：惠姑的所求，确有收获。

Reed: Yeah.
芦草结：这样……

Reed: I like this little epilogue.
芦草结：我很喜欢这个答案。

Reed smiles as she closes her notebook.
芦草结微笑着合上自己的笔记本。

Reed: I'm planning to write a couple more stories before winter comes.
芦草结：接下来的时间里，我打算扩充一些别的选题。

Reed: I hope the "Reed" that sprouts next year likes them too.
芦草结：希望以后的“芦草结”们读到我留下的记录，也会由衷地称赞它。

Paper Heron: Hmm.
鹭鸶剪：唔……

She frowns playfully.
鹭鸶剪皱起眉头。

Paper Heron: I must say, you're quite inquisitive for a reed.
鹭鸶剪：我早就想说……你是一株苇草，却格外擅长思考。

Paper Heron: You'd likely make an excellent Daoist. Were you born in my time, many would have wanted you as their student.
鹭鸶剪：放在我拜师的年代，就是大家争着抢的修道好苗子。

Paper Heron: How about I—
鹭鸶剪：不如我来教——

Reed: Thanks for the offer, but I've always wanted to be a commissioning editor. I think I've had enough of Daoism for one lifetime!
芦草结：不了不了，我的规划是一直努力到成为责任编辑！

They both laugh for a long while. Reed composes herself first.
两人笑了一阵，芦草结先收敛了声音。

She thinks for a moment, then extends an invitation.
她想了一想，向鹭鸶剪发出邀请。

Reed: But how about we take a walk around the Mei tree again?
芦草结：再去那棵梅树边走走，怎么样?

Two figures approach the Mei tree. One crouches low; the other stands nearby.
梅树下多了两个身影，一个矮着身子，一个立在一旁。

Paper Heron looks up at the tree full of red blossoms and pats the bark as if greeting an old friend.
鹭鸶剪仰望着满树红梅，鼓励般拍了拍树干。

Paper Heron: This old thing will soon bloom more beautifully than ever.
鹭鸶剪：过一段时间，这棵梅树大概也会因为开花太勤登上新闻吧。

The editor examines the stone bricks arranged around the tree, apparently recovered from some old houses that collapsed years ago.
旁边的编辑端详着树边铺设的砖石。
当地人告诉过她，这些石块是早些年从塌了的老房子里捡来的，也算颇有年头。

A half-buried stone catches her attention.
一块半埋在土中的石头吸引了她的注意。

Reed: This is ...
芦草结：这是……

She bends down and brushes away the layer of dirt covering its face.
她弯腰想去拨开石头上的泥土。

Paper Heron: Come on, Reedie.
鹭鸶剪：走了，小小草。

Paper Heron: We'll still have some time if we take a shortcut to the streets.
鹭鸶剪：从这湖边抄近路去街上，我们还有空逛一会儿呢——

Reed: Oh, sure!
芦草结：噢，来啦！

The editor runs a few steps to keep up with her companion.
编辑小跑几步，跟上了同伴的步子。

Reed: I've gotta report back to the office soon, tomorrow or at least by the day after.
芦草结：明天或者后天，我打算回编辑部一趟。

Reed: What about you? What're you gonna do?
芦草结：你呢？你之后准备去做什么?

Paper Heron tilts her head, gesturing toward a tall building in the distance.
鹭鸶剪扬扬脑袋，示意她望向远处的高楼。

Paper Heron: I'll keep traveling. I seem to have missed a great deal over these last centuries.
鹭鸶剪：继续游历，去见识这几百年错过的东西。

Paper Heron: And, you know, my taste seems to have restored a little. Perhaps I'll search for a place with good food and stay there for a half-month.
鹭鸶剪：最近，我能尝出更多菜的味道了。所以我会先挑个好吃的最多的地方，住上十天半个月……

Reed: I'd love to join you, if I still have time, that is.
芦草结：要是有空，我们还可以同行。

Reed: You'll still be on the forum, right? The same account?
芦草结：你还会继续用那个论坛账户吧?

Paper Heron: Of course, and there's a friend I'd like you to meet, hm?
鹭鸶剪：当然了，我还有一位朋友要介绍给你……嗯?

Cat: Meow.
猫：喵。

The lake lies quiet as the wind laps gently over it, now a place where small creatures can gather to rest beneath the shade.
湖边安静，风也温和，常有些小动物在附近出没。

Paper Heron scoops up the fur ball and strokes its sleek coat.
鹭鸶剪一把将这团绒球提溜了起来，毫不客气地摸着它油光水滑的毛。

Paper Heron: Hey, little one. Are you from around here?
鹭鸶剪：喂，咪咪，你是在这里安家了吗?

Paper Heron: How about some fish for supper, hm?
鹭鸶剪：既然有缘，我一会儿帮你抓几条鱼来……

Seeing the cat lounge contentedly beside them, Reed rests her hand on its back as well.
见这只猫一副心安理得的模样，编辑也将手掌落在了它背上。

She remembers her last question.
她还没忘记最后的问题。

Reed: A friend, huh? Someone else you met on the forum? Who are they?
芦草结：你说的朋友也是你的网友吗？也会……五感缺失吗?

Reed: Any idea what kinda food they like? There's a couple restaurants around here that look good.
芦草结：要是这样，就选几个菜色不那么清淡的餐馆……

Paper Heron: You needn't worry. He'll be grateful to eat anything, and in fact, you already know him.
鹭鸶剪：别担心，不全是网友，这个人你也认识。

Paper Heron: Last time, the seal took away my sense of taste, but his, at least, seems fine.
鹭鸶剪：那五感缺失的毛病，是我第一次被匆忙封入树中落下的。我是一时半会儿好不了啦，但他应当没事。

Paper Heron: He will have awakened by now. We can discuss it on the forum later.
鹭鸶剪：我猜他眼下总该醒了。剩下的事情可以待会儿论坛上商量。

Paper Heron: I have to say, the Internet is quite amazing, connecting people from all corners of the globe.
鹭鸶剪：尽管天大地大，但现在联系比往日方便太多，总能说上话、见上面的。

Reed: It sure is.
芦草结：天大地大吗……

The editor gazes at the silver line where the lake meets the sky.
编辑望着湖面与天际相接的那一线银色。

Reed: *blow*
芦草结：呼——

She raises her arms, stretching her tense body.
她高举起手臂，舒展着紧绷许久的肢体。

Reed: So I got all worked up for nothing. But I guess I shouldn't complain.
芦草结：好像白费了很多紧张的心情……但这阵风真好。

Reed: There's no cataclysm, no raging beast, just a tree, a lake, and a gentle breeze over a quiet little path.
芦草结：到头来，末日和灾难都没发生，多大的天地之间也只是多了片能散步的地方。

Paper Heron: Indeed.
鹭鸶剪：是啊。

She watches the fish as they bob up from the lake, surfacing one moment, diving deep the next.
她注视着湖中的游鱼。看它们时而上浮，时而潜入更深处。

One jumps up and vanishes away the moment it hits the water.
池鱼入水，顷刻便会隐没踪迹。

Paper Heron: It was all but a splash in the pond.
鹭鸶剪：不过一方鱼池而已。